What Grows in the Silence

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Explicit

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Major Character Death

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Additional Tags:
Past Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Past Perfuma/Scorpia, Grief/Mourning, Chronic Illness, Chronic Pain, Ehlers-Danlos Syndrome | EDS, catra has EDS, Disability, Physical Disability, Healing, Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Slow Burn, Widowhood, POV Catra (She-Ra), Catra Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Perfuma is so soft, Ghost Adora (She-Ra), Angst with a Happy Ending, Hopeful Ending, Heavy Angst, Fluff and Angst, Introspection, poetic prose, Coffee Shops, Animal Crossing References, cane user, Suicidal Thoughts, Learning to live again, South-Facing Windows, What Grows in the Silence, Trans Catra (She-Ra), Catra Has a Penis (She-Ra), Asexual Character, asexual adora, Barista Perfuma, Alternate Universe - Real World, real world au with canon species

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What Grows in the Silence

by weedcatra420

Summary

Five years ago, Catra’s world shattered with the sudden death of her wife, Adora. Now, she lives in a silent apartment filled with ghosts, her body a traitorous landscape of chronic pain she navigates with a cane and sheer stubbornness. Every morning is a battle—against the ache in her bones, the memory of a laugh that will never sound again, and the crushing weight of a loneliness so deep it feels like a second skin.

A story about grief that doesn’t end, but changes shape. About a body that can't be fixed, but can still be lived in. And about the quiet, stubborn courage it takes to open the curtains on a south-facing window and let the light back in.

Notes

Hi friends! I'm very excited to share this with you. It's a work that's close to my heart, and based quite closely on my own lived experiences. It's going to start heavy, but it's ultimately a hopeful story, so hang in there, okay?

ALSO: Starting December 1, I'll be uploading a chapter a day of my urban fantasy holiday cryptid romance 'The Moth and the Mistletoe' until December 25. <3

See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1: The Weight of Mornings

Dawn isn't a herald. It's an intrusion. The grey light bleeding around the edges of the heavy curtains doesn't promise a new day; it announces the resumption of an old, familiar siege. Catra wakes as she always does: to pain.

It lives in her bones, a deep, resonant ache that pulses in time with her sluggish heartbeat. It nests in the sockets of her hips, a grinding dissonance that feels like rusted gears forced to turn. It radiates from her shoulders, a dull, insistent throb that makes the simple act of breathing feel like lifting weights. It hums in the delicate joints of her fingers and wrists, a constant, low-level buzz of wrongness.

Ehlers-Danlos syndrome. The name is clinical, sterile, utterly inadequate to describe the reality of inhabiting a body built of faulty scaffolding. Weak connective tissue means tendons stretch like frayed elastic, ligaments offer flimsy support, and joints slide treacherously out of place with the slightest provocation. Her body isn't a temple; it's a ruin held together by willpower and sheer, grinding stubbornness.

She lays perfectly still, eyes closed against the unwelcome light. Movement is the enemy. Any shift, however minute, risks escalating the dull orchestra of aches into a shrieking cacophony of dislocation. Her ears, sensitive and expressive despite the pain, twitch minutely against the pillowcase.

Her tail, thick-furred and usually restless, is coiled tightly around her right calf, a self-soothing pretzel knot–a habit Adora had teased her about relentlessly. *"Look at you, all tangled up like breakfast,"* Adora would chuckle, her voice still sleep-rough, reaching over to gently unwind the furry appendage. *"My little cinnamon twist."*

The memory hits like a physical blow, sharper than the pain in her SI joint. Five years. Five years since the sharp clatter of a spatula

dropping to the floor shattered a perfectly ordinary Saturday morning.

Five years since the frantic ambulance ride to the hospital, the smell of antiseptic and dread thick in the air. Five years since the doctor’s too-gentle voice in the too-bright, too-quiet hallway, delivering news that shattered her world.

Five years since Adora’s bright, booming laugh, her off-key humming, the solid warmth of her presence, had been replaced by… silence. An immense, echoing silence that fills the apartment, fills Catra’s chest, fills every aching crevice of her fragile body.

The room remains dim, the curtains staunchly drawn against the intrusive morning. Catra focuses on her breath. In. Hold. Out. Slow. Measured. A technique her therapist has drilled into her.

"Breathe through the pain, Catra. Don't let it steal your air."

Easier said than done when every inhalation feels like shifting broken glass in her ribcage. She counts. One. Two. Three. The numbers are a flimsy raft on a sea of discomfort. She wills her muscles to unlock, one agonizing fiber at a time. *Move. Just move.*

She reaches for the cane leaned against the nightstand, its wooden handle worn smooth by years of desperate grips. Her fingers, stiff and swollen with the morning's ache, fumble to close around it.

The cool grain of the wood seeps into her skin, a familiar dullness that only deepens the cold already settled in her joints. This is the fulcrum of her world now. Leverage. Control. A precarious substitute for strength.

She braces her free hand on the mattress, knuckles white. Gritting her teeth, a low grunt escaping her lips, she hauls her weight upwards. Her spine protests, vertebrae shifting with alarming looseness. Her hips scream as they take her full weight. The

stiffness in her knees is a vice, locking and unlocking with painful jerks.

She stands, swaying slightly, fur bristling along her spine and shoulders at the sheer, exhausting effort of verticality. The simple act of rising from bed feels like summiting a mountain.

The walk to the kitchen is a gauntlet run in slow motion. Sixteen shuffling steps. Each one meticulously calculated, a complex algorithm of weight distribution and joint preservation. Lift. Shift weight to the cane. Swing the weaker left leg forward, pray the knee won't buckle or the hip subluxate–partially dislocate–sending a lightning bolt of agony up her spine. Plant the foot. Transfer weight. Repeat.

The worn hardwood floor feels treacherous. A slight unevenness, invisible to the eye, could be catastrophic. Her breath comes in shallow pants. The silence of the apartment is deafening, broken only by the tap of the cane, the rasp of her own breathing, and the maddening, rhythmic *drip… drip… drip* from the kitchen faucet Adora had always meant to fix.

The coffee maker sits on the counter, a relic. Adora's domain. Its plastic casing is worn smooth in places from years of use, the buttons faded. Catra leans heavily on the counter, the cool laminate a minor relief against her aching palms. Her claws, usually sharp and ready, retract deep into her sheaths, a protective instinct to spare the machine's surface.

She fills the reservoir with water, her trembling hands making the task clumsy. Scooping grounds feels like handling lead weights. She spills a little, the dark granules scattering across the counter like fallen stars. She doesn't bother cleaning them up. Pressing the *brew* button requires focusing all her concentration into her knuckle, avoiding the treacherous flex of her finger joints.

The gurgle and hiss begins. The scent of brewing coffee, rich and bitter, floods the tiny kitchen. It's a smell saturated with memory.

Suddenly, she isn’t 40, standing alone, leaning on a cane in a silent, too-empty apartment.

She's 35, leaning against the counter with her cane hooked beside her. Adora stands behind her, a solid, warm wall of muscle, her arms caging Catra in on either side as she reaches for the coffee mugs. Catra lets her full weight sink back into Adora's chest, her drowsy head lolling against the firm shelf of Adora's collarbone. The sleep-smell of her skin is a familiar comfort.

Adora's left hand is braced flat on the countertop beside the sink, her right hand pouring the coffee. This close, Catra feels every minute shift of muscle in Adora's torso and arms, a live wire of movement against her back.

A splash of near-boiling liquid hits the counter perilously close to Adora's bare left hand. Catra turns her head slightly, her cheek rubbing against the soft cotton of Adora's shirt.

"You're gonna burn yourself, genius," she mumbles, her voice thick with sleep.

Her own hand drifts up from where it rested on Adora's forearm, her claws retracted. Her fingers find the vulnerable pulse-point on Adora's wrist, a gentle, teasing pressure. "And then I'll have to carry you to the ER."

Adora pauses her pouring. She turns her head, her lips brushing Catra's temple. Her face, when Catra tilts her head back to see it, is illuminated by a grin so bright it could power the city. Her laugh erupts—loud, uninhibited, a sound that fills every corner of their home, vibrating through Catra's bones in the best possible way.

The memory is a hologram, vivid and warm. Then, like smoke, it dissolves. The gurgle of the coffee maker is just a machine. The scent is just coffee. The counter is just a surface scattered with spilled grounds.

Her gaze snags on the protein powder tub, and the ghost of Adora’s voice echoes, *'Gotta hit my macros, babe.'*

The space beside her is cold, empty air. Vertigo washes over Catra, a dizzying wave of loss that has nothing to do with her inner ear.

She grips the counter edge, knuckles bone-white, claws scraping faintly on the laminate. She squeezes her eyes shut, waiting for the world to stop tilting. *Five years. I'm okay. Mostly.* The mantra feels hollow, a pebble dropped into the chasm of Adora's absence. It doesn't fill it. It just makes a small, insignificant sound.

Coffee mug clutched precariously in one hand, cane tapping an uneven rhythm, she shuffles the sixteen steps back to the bedroom. Lowering herself onto the edge of the bed is another exercise in controlled collapse. She sips the scalding liquid, the heat a welcome distraction, the bitterness grounding.

She sets the mug down and reaches for her Switch, nestled on her nightstand. The cheerful, saccharine jingle of *Animal Crossing* fills the room, a jarring counterpoint to the heavy silence and the leaden weight in Catra's chest.

Her character stands in the pixelated sunshine of her virtual island. Her hands, resting on the console, feel heavy and clumsy. Her knuckles throb. Her claws, extended slightly for better grip, feel stiff and unwieldy on the small buttons. She navigates her character across the green grass, past her own neat cottage, towards the smaller, slightly crooked house nestled near the beach.

Player 2's House. Adora's Cottage. The digital weeds around it are thick and overgrown, spilling onto the path. Catra stares at the screen. The cheerful music feels like mockery. The effort of pulling virtual weeds suddenly seems insurmountable. Her thumb hovers over the button.

With a sharp exhale, she hits the power button. The screen goes black, plunging the room back into silence, save for the drip of the faucet from the kitchen. The weight of the Switch feels like a stone in her lap.

At precisely 11 a.m., her tablet chimes with the familiar, overly bright tone of a video call from the nightstand. Dr. Netossa's face appears on the screen, pixelated but sharp, her white hair pulled back, her expression one of professional calm.

Catra hauls the device onto the rumpled landscape of her chest, angling it so the camera captures her face from the nose up. She fixes her gaze on the edge of the tablet itself, the dark plastic bezel. Her ears, however, swivel forward, attuned to the therapist's voice, even as her eyes trace a faint, familiar scratch on the tablet's casing.

"Good morning, Catra," Dr. Netossa begins, her voice calm and even. "How are you feeling today?"

"Fine," Catra rasps, the single syllable clipped. Her tail flicks once against the sheets, a nervous metronome.

"Pain levels?"

"Usual." Catra's gaze doesn't waver from the scratch on the plastic.

Dr. Netossa nods, making a note on her own tablet, visible at the bottom of the screen. "Sleep?"

"Some."

A pause, heavy despite the digital distance. Catra can feel the therapist assembling her next question, the careful tread around the minefield of her grief and isolation.

"You've been alone for a long time now, Catra," Dr. Netossa observes, her tone neutral, not unkind, but probing.

"Five years is a significant period. Isolation… it can feel like a fortress. It protects us from potential hurt, from misunderstanding, from the exhausting effort of navigating the world. But fortresses can also become prisons. They can constrict. Have you given any more thought to… reaching out? Even just a

little? A text to an old friend? Checking an online forum? Maybe joining a quiet, text-based support group? Something low-pressure?"

Catra's tail lashes, a sharp, involuntary movement. Her claws dig into the faded cotton of her duvet. The thought of opening a message, seeing a name from a past life, navigating the awkward condolences or, worse, the oblivious chatter… it's paralyzing.

The imagined energy required to formulate a response, to engage, feels like trying to lift a car. "It's too… hard," she manages, the words scraping her throat. "I don't… I don't know how to be around people anymore. Not really. Not like before."

Before Adora. Before pain and silence became her only companions. Before she became this fragile, grief-stricken husk.

"Even online?" Dr. Netossa presses gently. "A quiet space? No cameras, no voices? Just words on a screen? A place to observe, perhaps, without the pressure of immediate interaction?"

Catra stares at the tiny lightning bolt. The idea of anonymous strangers, their own pain laid bare in text, feels overwhelming. What could they possibly offer her that the silence doesn't? What could she offer them except her own crushing emptiness?

"I'll… think about it," she mutters, the lie tasting like ash. They both know she won't. Thinking requires energy she doesn't possess.

The session continues, a familiar dance of gentle probes and deflected answers. Dr. Netossa speaks about coping strategies, mindfulness exercises, the importance of small goals.

Catra nods occasionally, her gaze never leaving the scratch. The words wash over her, failing to penetrate the thick fog of pain and apathy.

When the call finally ends, the silence rushes back in, heavier than before. The pixelated image of Dr. Netossa vanishes, replaced by

her own reflection in the black screen–tired eyes in a face framed by messy, unbrushed fur.

She lets the tablet slump back onto the mattress beside her and turns away, staring at the empty side of the bed.

Noon arrives with the sharp clatter of a key in the lock and the heavy thump of a medical bag hitting the floor just inside the door. Her aide, Mara. Her twice-weekly lifeline and a reminder of her dependence.

Mara bustles in, a compact woman with kind eyes and brisk efficiency. Her presence fills the small space, a whirlwind of practicality that momentarily displaces the suffocating silence.

“Afternoon, sunshine,” Mara chirps, her voice deliberately bright. She hangs her coat on the back of the door. “Ready for the spa treatment?”

Catra manages a noncommittal grunt. The ‘spa treatment’ was a clinical shower, a necessary indignity. Her tail curls tightly around her leg again, the tip twitching. As Mara approaches, Catra braces herself.

The aide’s hands are gentle but impersonal as she helps Catra maneuver out of her sweatpants and t-shirt. Catra keeps her gaze averted, focusing on the pattern of the rug beneath her bare feet. The vulnerability is always acute, the exposure of her fragile, scarred body to another’s gaze, even a professional one.

Adora had been the only one whose touch hadn’t felt like an intrusion, whose eyes hadn’t held a flicker of pity. Adora had been fiercely proud when Catra finally agreed to hire Mara after a particularly bad dislocation episode.

"It’s not giving up, Catra. It’s being smart. Letting someone help so you can save your energy for kicking ass."

The shower stool is cold against her skin, a shock that makes her fur prickle. Mara adjusts the detachable shower head, testing the

temperature with her hand before directing the warm spray.

The water feels good, loosening the ever-present tension in her muscles. Mara works with practiced efficiency, massaging shampoo into the thick fur around Catra's ears and neck. The scent of the generic shampoo fills the small bathroom.

"New shampoo?" Mara asks, her fingers working the lather down Catra's spine.

"Same one," Catra mumbles, her eyes fixed on the familiar cracks in the white tiles in front of her. One crack splinters into a fine, intricate network, like a pale root system searching for water. She traces its path with her eyes. *Professional. Normal.*

"Hm. Smells nice," Mara remarks conversationally, rinsing the soap away with the spray. The water sluices over Catra's shoulders, down her back.

Catra's ears flatten instinctively as the spray moves lower, as Mara's efficient hands soap her belly, her legs. The routine of being washed, particularly in the most intimate areas, is a stark reality of her condition. Mara is clinical, respectful, focused solely on the task. It's as unremarkable as folding laundry, a necessary chore.

Catra focuses on the tiles, counting the cracks. One. Two. Three cracks converging. Four. Five. She's counted them hundreds of times. Mara has been bathing her for almost ten years. A decade of cracks, a decade of dependence. Adora's phantom voice echoes, *"See? Smart."*

Clean, damp fur plastered to her skin, Catra is bundled into a large, soft towel. Mara helps her into clean, loose sweatpants and a baggy t-shirt, the fabric soft against her sensitive skin. The simple act of dressing leaves her trembling with fatigue. She collapses into her worn armchair near the window, the one Adora had salvaged from a thrift store and reupholstered in a hideous

but incredibly soft green velvet. Mara gathers her things, the medical bag clanking softly.

"Alright, kiddo. All set. I'll see you Thursday. Try to eat something more substantial than coffee, yeah?" Mara gives a cheerful wave, her smile warm but holding a familiar undercurrent of concern she never voiced directly.

The door clicks shut behind her, the lock engaging with a soft snick.

Silence floods back, thicker this time, amplified by the lingering scent of soap and damp fur. Catra sits in the armchair, staring out at the sliver of grey sky visible between the buildings opposite.

The shadows cast by the afternoon sun lengthen across the scuffed wooden floor, streaming in a sharp sliver past the edge of the heavy curtain drawn over the south-facing window—the reason Adora had chosen this apartment, insisting the clear, steady light would be perfect for Catra's art.

Adora's absence is a physical hum in the room, quieter than the screaming grief of the early years, but persistent. An emptiness that vibrates in her bones, harmonizing with the ache of her joints.

She has built a life around this emptiness. It's a life measured in routines and checklists: the pills Mara sorts meticulously into a pill organizer every week; the heating pad perpetually plugged in and ready by the bed; the cane always within reach; the silence no longer fought against, but accepted as the ambient noise of her existence.

She's okay. Functional. Mostly. She breathes. She endures. She exists within the narrow parameters her body and her grief allows.

But some nights… some nights the loneliness isn't just an absence. It's a presence. A second skin, cold and clinging, that no amount of blankets can warm. It whispers in the silence,

reminding her of the warmth that has gone, the laughter that will never sound again.

Her Switch lays dormant on the small table beside the chair. The book she's been trying to read for months sits splayed open, face down, on the armrest, the same paragraph half-read for weeks. She traces a claw along the worn green velvet of the chair arm, the texture familiar under the pad of her finger.

The question surfaces, unbidden and sharp as a thorn: *Is this all?*

She can hear Adora's voice, a phantom sigh in her ear, soft yet chiding: *'It doesn't have to be.'*

The room darkens as the sun dips lower. Catra closes her eyes, her tail twitching in a slow, restless rhythm against the chair cushion, keeping time with her shallow breaths. Tomorrow.

She'll get through today, and tomorrow… she'll try again. To breathe. To endure. To exist. It's the only promise she can make.

The next morning arrives with a vengeance. Catra wakes not just to the familiar ache, but to a body that feels utterly broken, a treacherous landscape actively hostile to its inhabitant.

The pain isn't a dull throb; it's a serrated knife, freshly sharpened and plunged deep between her lower ribs. Her hips grind with every micro-movement, a sensation like rusted gears packed with sand.

A sharp, sickening *pop* echoes in the silence as she shifts slightly– her left shoulder partially slipping from its socket with casual cruelty. A gasp tears from her throat, sharp and involuntary, her body seizing at the white-hot spike of wrongness. It slides back in a moment later with a nauseating shift of tissue and bone, leaving behind not relief, but a deep, radiating throb that pulses in time with her heartbeat. She claws weakly at the sheets, her tail thrashing once in a spasm of agony before falling still, a leaden weight beside her.

Five years of mornings. Five years of waking to this decaying vessel, to the suffocating silence where Adora's voice should have been–warm, concerned, *present*. *"Bad one? Let me get the heat pad."* The untouched side of the bed yawns beside her, a pristine expanse of cold sheets. A shrine to absence. A mockery.

Tears of frustration and sheer, unadulterated pain prick her eyes. She blinks them back fiercely. Tears are useless. They change nothing. They only waste energy.

Gritting her teeth, she reaches for the cane. Her grip trembles violently as she hauls herself upright, each vertebra protesting, her hips shrieking betrayal. Sweat beads on her forehead despite the room's chill.

The apartment greets her with its hollow quiet–no laughter, no off-key humming, just the relentless, accusatory *drip… drip… drip* from the kitchen faucet.

Coffee. Breakfast. Routine. The anchors of her existence. But today, the rituals feel less like anchors and more like shackles. Heavy, chafing, imprisoning her in this cycle of pain and solitude.

She shuffles towards the kitchen, the cane skidding slightly on a patch of floor she hadn't noticed was dusty. Her left leg buckles, a sickening lurch that sends a jolt of white-hot panic through her.

She catches herself on the doorframe, breathing hard, the knuckles of her free hand white. She makes it to the counter, leaning heavily, her vision swimming slightly. The coffee tin sits there, familiar. Her claws, stiff and uncooperative, fumble with the lid. It slips.

Dark grounds explode across the countertop and floor, scattering over the spilled remains from yesterday, a messy constellation of her incapability. She stares at the mess. Cleaning it would require bending, reaching, movements fraught with peril. A wave of overwhelming weariness crashes over her. She leaves it. What does it matter?

The window above the sink beckons. Weak winter sunlight streams through the glass, painting a distorted rectangle of gold on the worn linoleum floor. Drawn by some instinct deeper than reason, Catra shuffles closer. She leans her forehead against the cool glass, squinting.

Outside, the world exists. The sky is a startling, crisp blue, scrubbed clean by a night wind. Fluffy white clouds drift like tufts of dandelion fluff. A breeze, carrying the damp, earthy scent of thawing soil, sneaks through the window frame and ruffles the fur around her ears.

'A good day,' Adora's voice whispers in her memory, bright and eager. She can almost see her, lacing up her battered running shoes by the door. *'C'mon, let's get out there. Even just to the corner. Breathe some real air.'* Adora had always been her tether to the outside world, her encourager, her carrier when needed.

Catra doesn't realize she's decided until she hears the soft snick of the deadbolt turning, the rasp of the sticky front door opening. She's moving, propelled by a sudden, desperate impulse that overrides the screaming protests of her body. The door clicks shut behind her, the sound final, cutting her off from the known misery of her apartment.

The outside world assaults her senses. The sunlight, weak as it is, feels blinding after the perpetual dimness indoors. The air is cold, sharp in her lungs, carrying smells of car exhaust, damp pavement, and that tantalizing hint of earth.

The sounds are a cacophony–distant traffic, a dog barking, the shriek of children somewhere. It's overwhelming, terrifying. And utterly, heartbreakingly *alive*.

The walk to the park three blocks away is an agonizing pilgrimage. Her cane taps a slow, uneven rhythm on the uneven pavement. Her left leg threatens to buckle with every step, cane skittering dangerously on a patch of ice she didn't see.

She remembers, with a pang that's more grief than nostalgia, sprinting across sun-baked rooftops as a reckless teenager, her body a coiled spring of muscle and mischief, joints obeying her every command. Now, those same joints creak and groan like the timbers of a sinking ship.

A group of kids on bikes, shrieking with laughter, swerve around her on the sidewalk, a blur of color and noise that makes her freeze, ears flattened tight against her skull, her heart giving a single, painful lurch against her ribs. She stands rigid, a statue of pain and anxiety, until their laughter fades into the distance.

The park bench, overlooking the small, scum-edged duck pond, is blessedly empty. The painted wood is icy cold beneath her thin sweatpants, the chill seeping into her bones, but the weak winter sun on her face and fur is a benediction.

She tilts her head back, closing her eyes, letting the light paint red patterns on her eyelids. Sounds wash over her, replacing the apartment's silence: birds–sparrows, maybe?–bickering fiercely in the bare branches of an oak tree. The rhythmic *tap-tap-tap* of a woodpecker somewhere. The frantic scrabbling of a squirrel racing up a trunk, its tiny claws clicking against the bark. Across the pond, ducks squabble, a raucous, undignified sound.

For a moment, the sheer, messy, uncurated *noise* of life is a balm. It isn't silence. It isn't absence. It's… presence. Her tail, still coiled tightly, gives a single, hesitant twitch in time with the rustle of dead leaves skittering across the path.

"I'm really trying," she whispers, the words crumbling as soon as they leave her lips, stolen by the breeze. They sound pathetic, insignificant against the backdrop of the living world.

A tear escapes, tracing a hot path down her furred cheek. "Why did you have to go?" The question isn't new. It's the constant refrain of her internal monologue. But spoken aloud here, in the weak sunlight, it feels raw, exposed.

The moment shatters as a white-hot blade of pain lances through her pelvis–her SI joint, protesting violently against the prolonged sitting, the walk, the cold. She gasps, doubling over slightly.

The fragile peace evaporates. The birds sound shrill. The duck squabbles grate. The cold of the bench intensifies, biting deep.

Gritting her teeth, she pushes herself upright using the cane, her knuckles screaming. Standing is worse. The joint feels unstable, loose, threatening to give way entirely.

Fifteen minutes. That's all she can manage. Fifteen minutes of borrowed peace, paid for in excruciating coin.

The walk back is a nightmare. Every step is a gamble. Her vision blurs at the edges with the effort and the pain. She focuses solely on the pavement directly in front of her cane tip, a world reduced to grey concrete and the next precarious placement of her foot.

She fumbles with the keys, the cold metal slippery in her stiff fingers. The familiar scent of the apartment–dust, stale coffee, lingering grief–hits her like a wall as she stumbles inside.

She doesn't make it to the bed. She collapses onto the rug just inside the door, her cane clattering beside her, her hips and pelvis a molten pool of agony. She lays there, panting, trembling, the cold floor leeching what little warmth she has.

A flicker of something–pride?–tries to ignite. *She left. She tried.* But it's instantly smothered by the crushing weight of exhaustion and the relentless, grinding pain. It's smothered by the question that echoes louder than ever in the silence of the apartment, amplified by the brief, brutal foray outside:

How many more mornings like this can I survive?

The thought slithers in, cold and venomous, whispering from the darkest corner of her exhaustion: *You don't have to.*

She crawls, slowly dragging her protesting body the to the bed. Hauling herself onto it feels like scaling Everest. She buries her face in Adora's pillow, the fabric now holding only the imagined ghost of her scent beneath the years of her own tears and sweat.

She inhales deeply, desperately, seeking comfort, finding only dust and memory. *'You're allowed to want more,'* Adora's voice teases, a half-remembered dream from a happier time. *'More than this. More than pain and silence.'*

Catra's claws dig into the pillowcase, tearing the fabric slightly. *I don't want more,* she rages silently against the fading imprint of her wife. *I don't want grand things. I don't want adventures. I just want… you. I want the sound of your voice. I want your hand on my back when it hurts. I want your ridiculous laugh. I want* ***you****.* The silent scream echoes in the hollow of her chest.

Sleep, when it finally comes, drags her under like a riptide. But not before the image surfaces, clear and terrifyingly seductive: a door.

Not the apartment door. A different door. Simple wood, unassuming. But it stands slightly ajar. Unlocked. And beyond it… silence. Not the heavy silence of the apartment, but a deep, absolute, painless quiet.

An end to the grinding ache, the exhausting effort, the unbearable loneliness. An end to the weight of mornings.

Tomorrow, the whisper promises in the depths of her exhaustion, *you'll decide if you open it.*

Chapter 2: The Floor

Chapter Notes

A Note Before You Read:
Hey friends, this chapter goes to a very dark and physically difficult place. It's a raw look at Catra hitting her lowest point, and it includes a graphic scene of her struggling with her body's limitations in a way that involves bathroom hygiene.

If that's something you'd rather skip for any reason, you can jump from the paragraph ending with *Rotting together,* she thinks. down to Darkness falls by the time she drags herself back to bed. You won't miss any major plot, just the most intense part of this struggle.

Look after yourself first. <3

Catra dreams in fragments.

Adora’s hands—pale, steady, human—tracing the delicate curve of her spine. Laughter, breathless, tangled in sheets, the weight of Adora above her, sweat-slick skin pressed to fur, her touch firm but tender as she guides the strap-on into Catra’s ass. The stretch burns sweetly, and Catra’s tail thrashes, claws digging into the sheets.

Adora’s face, illuminated by the dim bedside lamp, is a study in fierce concentration. Her blue eyes, usually bright with laughter, are dark, focused intently on Catra’s reactions. She moves with deliberate rhythm, her thrusts deep and unhurried, focused entirely on the way Catra’s breath hitches, the way her small cock twitches against her belly.

“There you go,” Adora murmurs, her voice soft but assured. Her free hand wraps around Catra’s throbbing length, stroking in time with her hips. “Let go, baby. I’ve got you.”

Adora never cared about her own release—asexual to the bone, she had always said the joy was in this: Catra unraveling beneath her, the curve of her fanged smile, the heat of her body. Catra's ears flatten, her body arching as the pressure coils.

She comes with a choked cry, her release spilling over Adora's fingers. Adora slows but doesn't stop, easing her through the aftershocks until Catra goes boneless. Only then does she pull out, collapsing beside her and pressing a soft, lingering kiss to the fur of her sweat-damp shoulder.

No groan of relief, no frantic chase for her own pleasure—just the steady rise and fall of Adora's chest, her fingers carding through Catra's fur. "Love you," she whispers, lips grazing the sensitive tip of Catra's ear, sending a final, delicious shiver down her spine.

She wakes with a gasp.

The bed is cold. Her fur is matted with tears and the wetness of her release between her legs. Five years. Five years since Adora's hands, Adora's mouth, Adora's sweat-slick skin pressed against her. Five years since *anyone* touched her like that.

She misses the stretch, the fullness, the way Adora would laugh afterward—*'Think the neighbors heard you that time.'*

The mess between her legs feels like a betrayal–her body remembering what her heart can't have. Catra claws at her chest, a guttural sob ripping through her. The apartment swallows the sound.

The park is overcast today, the sun veiled behind gauzy clouds. Catra's cane taps a uneven rhythm on the damp pavement as she limps past couples sprawled on picnic blankets, their fingers interlaced. A child chases a dog, squealing. She lowers herself onto the cold, familiar bench, her SI joint screaming.

She watches an elderly man feed pigeons, their wings fluttering. A teenager sketches under a tree, and Catra's claws twitch. She

used to fill notebooks with ink—Adora's profile, the stark geometry of rooftops at dusk, the way light and shadow pooled in the hollow of her own throat. Now, her hands are traitors, stiff and swollen by noon.

A flash of color. A toddler, bundled in a puffy jacket, stumbles into her line of sight, chasing a balloon. Catra watches, her ears tilting toward the child's giggles. For a moment, the noise is a lifeline. She stands again, hobbling along the path, cane tapping unevenly.

The fragile moment shatters as a sharp cramp seizes her hip. Gritting her teeth, she pushes herself up using the cane, her hip joint feeling like it's packed with shards of glass. Forty-five minutes. She clings to the number. A record. A pathetic, painful victory.

She manages a few shuffling steps along the path, leaning heavily on the cane, each movement a calculated risk. Then, her left leg–weakened, betrayed by ligaments stretched beyond tolerance–simply buckles. She pitches forward with a gasp, catching herself hard on a nearby wooden railing.

The impact jars her entire frame, sending fresh waves of agony radiating from her wrist, shoulder, and hip. She clings to the rough wood, breathing raggedly, humiliation burning her cheeks.

Graceful, she thinks bitterly, the word laced with venom.

She remembers scaling rain-slicked fire escapes with effortless, feline agility, Adora shouting from the sidewalk below, equal parts exasperated and admiring: "Showoff! Get down before you break your neck!"

Now, standing upright feels like a death-defying stunt.

Her hip grinds, bone on bone. Forty-five minutes. A record. She steadies herself, joints popping, and hobbles home.

The apartment greets her with silence. She doesn't make it to the bed. She collapses face-first onto the rug just inside the door, her cane clattering beside her.

She lays there, panting, trembling, the rough fibers scratching her cheek. Her body is a litany of failures: the throbbing SI joint, the screaming hip, the wrenched shoulder, the stiff, swollen hands. And beneath it all, the hollow, aching void this morning's dream has violently reopened.

Catra makes her way, crawling, onto the bed, her body a litany of failures. She stares at the ceiling, tail flicking in agitation. The dream replays behind her eyes—Adora's warmth, the profound ache of being filled, the friction of Adora's hand on her cock, the way her release pulsed over Adora's fingers—and for a moment, the loneliness is so vast she can't breathe.

But then, unbidden, other images surfaced: the toddler's bright red balloon, bobbing defiantly against the grey sky. The frantic flutter of pigeon wings. The way the clouds had parted for just a few minutes earlier, a shaft of weak sunlight gilding the frost-bitten grass near the pond, making it glow with transient, impossible beauty.

Catra reaches for her Switch. Pulls a few weeds around Adora's digital cottage. Plants a single virtual lily—Adora's favorite.

Tomorrow, she'll water it.

The next morning, Catra wakes to a body that no longer obeys.

Her SI joint screams, a white-hot dagger lodged deep in her pelvis. She tries to roll onto her side, but her hips lock, muscles seizing in protest around misaligned bones. A whimper escapes her—sharp, animal—before she clamps her jaw shut.

*Shouldn't have gone to the park. Shouldn't have **dared** to hope fresh air might fix this.* She lies rigid, staring at the water stain on

the ceiling, its edges blurred by pain. Adora used to joke it looked like a cloud. Now, it's just a stain.

Pressure in her bladder sharpens into something worse. Her bowels twist, a cramp clawing up her gut. Catra grits her teeth, tail lashing weakly. *Not now. Not like this.* But her body betrays her, insistent and merciless.

She waits until the pressure is unbearable, then twists onto her stomach, biting the pillow to muffle a scream. The floor is cold against her fur as she slides off the bed, legs dragging like dead weight.

Crawling is an art she's perfected: shoulders hunched, claws gouging hardwood, tail tucked tight to avoid snagging. Each drag forward sends fresh bolts of agony from her dislocated SI joint shooting up her spine. The bathroom door, only ten feet away, might as well be a mile.

She remembers running with Adora at dawn, their breath fogging the winter air. Adora's laughter, breathless and full of admiration as Catra outpaces her, magicat agility defying human limits. *"Wait for me, you cheetah! Save some dignity for the humans!"* Adora would pant, doubling over with hands on her knees, grinning up at Catra who had looped back, barely winded.

Now, her elbows grind with every shuffle, her dislocated joint radiating agony up her spine. *This isn't living. This is* ***surviving****.*

The toilet mocks her. Catra grips the seat, arms trembling as she hoists herself up. Her SI joint slips further, a wet *pop* she feels more than hears. She pisses first, tears dripping into the bowl. Then the real ordeal begins.

Her bowels clench, and she strains—a mistake. Engaging her muscles around a joint that's out of position makes her entire

body light up in agony. Pain lances through her pelvis, her spine, her ribs.

She chokes on a sob, claws digging into the porcelain. *Just get it over with.* But her muscles spasm, refusing to cooperate. Sweat mats her fur as she pushes again, vision blurring.

When it finally happens, it's messy, humiliating, the stench sharp and nauseating. Wiping is impossible; bending her spine, twisting, reaching back–every movement required is geometrically forbidden by the searing protest in her SI joint and locked hips.

She tries anyway, gasping, tears streaming freely, mingling with sweat. It's futile. She crumples to the floor, tail streaked with filth, and retches dryly. The humiliation is a physical weight, crushing her.

She lays there, panting, staring at the tiles inches from her face. The tiles are grimy, grout blackened with mold Adora would've scrubbed away. *Rotting together,* she thinks.

The thoughts come louder now. *You could end this. Right here. No more crawling, no more shame.*

She imagines the bathroom cabinet: orange bottles lined like salvation. But reaching them would require standing.

Darkness falls by the time she drags herself back to bed. The journey is a blur of pain and determination. Her fur reeks of sweat and waste, her claws caked with grime. She doesn't eat. Doesn't drink.

Sleep is a feverish haze—Adora's voice, frayed with worry, pleading: *"Let me help you."* A memory: Adora kneeling beside her after a bad flare years ago, wiping tears from her cheeks with gentle thumbs, her own eyes soft with concern. *"You're not alone. I've got you. Always."*

When Catra wakes, it's not to Adora's touch, but to the profound, aching silence of the empty apartment.

Grey morning light filters around the curtains. Her body is a landscape of pain. Every breath hurts. Every heartbeat sends throbbing reminders through her damaged pelvis. She feels hollowed out, scraped raw, both physically and emotionally.

But the sun glints off the Switch on her nightstand, its screen smudged with claw marks. A tiny, stubborn spark flickers in the vast emptiness within her. It isn’t hope. It isn’t joy. It’s defiance.

Trembling, every movement sending fresh jolts of agony through her frame, she reaches out. Her stiff fingers fumble, but she manages to grasp the console, dragging it towards her. She powers it on.

The cheerful, oblivious music of her island greets her. She navigates her avatar, movements slow and clumsy, to the small cottage overlooking the pixelated sea. *Player 2’s House*. The single white lily she’d planted yesterday looks small, vulnerable. A few new digital weeds have sprouted nearby.

Catra focuses on the screen, blocking out the screaming protest of her body, the lingering shame, the crushing loneliness. Her thumb hovers over the button. With a breath that’s more a sob, she presses it.

Pull.

One weed vanishes.

She shifts slightly, gritting her teeth against the flare of pain in her hip.

Pull.

Another weed disappears.

Two weeds. An infinitesimal act of order in a world of chaos and decay. It isn’t much. It isn’t living.

But for now, in the cold, silent aftermath of a night that had broken her in new ways, it’s survival. It’s the only thing she can do.

She stares at the screen, the pixelated lily standing alone by the cottage door, and waits for the strength to breathe again.

Chapter 3: Reduction

Mara stands frozen in the bedroom doorway, her usual brisk efficiency shattered. Her gaze snags, not on Catra curled miserably on the bed, but on the fresh, raw gouges scarring the hardwood floor leading to the bathroom. Deep, frantic claw marks, etched with desperate force.

They tell a story of agony and degradation far louder than the silence hanging heavy in the air, thick with the sour tang of sweat and the lingering, unmistakable scent of waste.

Catra lay facing Adora's nightstand–a shrine Mara has never dared touch.

Even now, five years later, it holds sacred relics: Adora's cracked running watch, its face frozen at some forgotten hour; the faded green water bottle, plastered with peeling stickers from races Adora would never run again; the dog-eared paperback thriller, its spine broken from being read aloud countless times during Catra's worst flares, Adora's voice a lifeline against the pain.

"Hey," Mara manages, her voice softer, gentler than she'd planned. It feels inadequate against the stark reality. "Let's get you cleaned up."

Catra doesn't fight. There's no snarl, no defensive curl. Just a terrifying, hollow resignation. She allows Mara to roll her onto the disposable absorbent pad laid out beside the bed, her body limp, a dead weight.

The mess is worse than Mara had anticipated from the smell. Feces matts the fur on Catra's hindquarters and tail.

Her body is a brutalized landscape: the telltale, unnatural bulge of her dislocated SI joint visible even beneath her fur, her left hip swollen and angry, and several claws on her right hand visibly split and bloody from dragging herself across the unforgiving wood.

A low, continuous whine vibrates in Catra's throat, a sound of pure, abject misery.

The antiseptic wipes sting. Mara works with methodical, clinical detachment, her touch efficient but as gentle as possible as she maneuvers around Catra's locked hips and screaming pelvis.

She uses warm water and the lavender-scented soap she always carried–a scent Catra knew Adora would have hated, finding it cloying and artificial. *Adora preferred pine,* she thinks dully, the memory a fresh twist of the knife.

She claws at the filthy sheets beneath her, muffling gut-wrenching sobs into the mattress as the aide carefully cleans the soiled fur between her legs. The humiliation is a living thing, crushing her lungs.

"I'm sorry," Mara murmurs, pausing briefly to adjust the pad beneath Catra's hip. Her voice is thick. "I know this sucks."

Adora's ghost sits cross-legged on the floor beside the bed, translucent and shimmering with sadness. Her blue eyes are wide with the helpless anguish she'd always worn during Catra's worst flares.

"I'm here," she whispers, her voice a faint echo only Catra could hear. She reaches out, her spectral palm hovering just above the curve of Catra's spine where the SI joint screams. *"You're okay. You're okay."* It was the mantra she'd always used, a lie offered with desperate love.

But Catra isn't okay. The tears, held back by shock and shame, break loose in violent heaves. Her body shudders with the force of them.

"I *tried*," she grits out, her voice raw and splintering, claws tearing tiny rents in the sheet. "Went to the park. Two days. Just—wanted to *see* people. Hear voices that aren't… aren't yours." Her voice cracks on the last word, dissolving into a choked gasp.

Mara pauses her cleaning, her hand resting lightly on Catra's trembling flank. "You pushed too hard, honey. Your body…"

"*I pushed normal!*" Catra's head snaps up, fangs bared in a rictus of fury and despair. "Everyone else gets to *walk*. To sit on a goddamn bench in the sun! I tried *existing* outside these walls, and it *broke* me. That's not *fair*! None of this is—" A sob chokes off her words, her body collapsing back onto the mattress, racked with tremors.

Mara doesn't argue. She simply resumes her work, her movements slower now, infused with a profound, weary sadness.

She finishes cleaning, applying a soothing barrier cream to the inflamed skin, and then sets about the grim task of stripping the soiled bedding (leaving Adora's pillowcase untouched) and replacing it with fresh layers.

The silence stretches, punctuated only by Catra's ragged breathing and stifled whimpers.

"I'm so *tired*, Mara," Catra admits, her face buried deep in the fresh pillowcase. "So fucking tired. Every time I think I've… clawed my way back up just a little… it gets worse. Something *else* happens. What's the *point*?" Her voice drops to a shattered whisper. "I'm already in hell."

Adora's ghost drifts closer, her form shimmering like heat haze. She leans down, her spectral lips near Catra's ear. *"You're still here,"* she murmurs, the words pulled from a memory of a different flare, a different breaking point. *"Still fighting."*

Later, when Catra is clean, bundled in fresh sweats, and propped slightly on pillows, Mara holds a straw to her lips. The vanilla protein shake tastes like sweetened chalk dust. Catra manages a few reluctant sips.

"Catra…" Mara's tone shifts, the gentleness hardening into something more serious. "We need to talk. You're not safe like

this. Not alone. If you keep pushing yourself past your limits, if you can't guarantee you can get help if you fall like that again…"

"Don't." The word is a cracked whip.

"…we might need to revisit the assisted living talk."

Catra snarls, a feral, defensive sound, baring her fangs fully. "*Get out.*" The words are venomous, laced with panic.

"Catra, be reasonable—"

"*Get OUT!*" Catra shrieks, her voice raw and tearing. "They'll *erase* her! You know they will! They'll throw her watch in the trash, donate that stupid book… they won't know she *hated* coconut water, that she could recite entire chapters of that garbage novel by heart, that she…"

Catra's breath hitches violently, a wet, ragged sound. Tears stream down her face. "If I leave this apartment… it won't be our home anymore. It'll just be… space. The last thing I have left of *her*… the place we lived… it will be *gone*." The admission hangs in the air, heavy with a grief that transcended the physical pain.

Adora's ghost drifts across the room, towards the draped window. Her translucent fingers brush a sunbeam cutting through the dusty air—a lone escapee from where the heavy curtain met the wall—illuminating swirling motes.

"South-facing windows," she murmurs, her voice thin and distant as cobwebs. *"You loved the way the shadows moved across the floor in the afternoon. We picked this place for the light."*

Mara watches Catra's gaze follow the empty space near the window, understanding dawning. She sighs, rubbing her temples. The fight drains out of her, replaced by a bone-deep weariness and the crushing weight of responsibility.

"Okay," she says, her voice flat. "Okay. No assisted living talk. Not today." She takes a deep breath. "But I'm adding two extra visits

this week. Non-negotiable. Morning and evening checks. You need monitoring after this. Hydration, nutrition, making sure you're… stable."

Money I don't have, Catra thinks. The extra co-pays will drain her meager reserves—the same disability payments she's received for over a decade, her only income since Adora's death 5 years ago, stretched so thin already.

Catra stares at the wall, the fight gone out of her, replaced by numb despair. She gives a single, jerky nod.

Mara leaves a cluster of protein shakes and applesauce pouches on the nightstand within easy reach. At the door, bag in hand, she hesitates. Her gaze sweeps the room–the claw marks, the shrine, Catra's broken form on the bed.

"You're not in hell," she says, her voice quiet but surprisingly firm. "Just… stuck. For now."

Catra doesn't answer. She doesn't turn her head. She just stares at the water stain on the ceiling–Adora's cloud, now just a meaningless blotch.

The lock clicks shut. Silence rushes back in, thicker, heavier. The only light comes from the Switch glowing dimly on the nightstand. Catra reaches for it, her movements stiff and painful.

She navigates to her island, to Adora's pixelated cottage. Three new digital weeds mock her from its doorstep. With trembling thumbs, she moves the cursor. *Pull.* One weed vanishes. She stares at the screen for a long moment, then sets the console down and slowly types a text on her phone.

To Mara: thank you

She hits send. The screen dims.

Adora's ghost shimmers into view behind her, curling close, a phantom warmth against her back that offers no real heat. *'You're okay,'* she whispers, the familiar lie echoing in the silent room.

The next few days pass in a grey, pain-filled haze. Catra exists in the narrow space between the bed and the bathroom, trips to the latter now supervised by Mara during her extra visits, a humiliating but necessary routine.

She lays staring at the walls, the ceiling, the dust motes dancing in the south-facing light. Sometimes she sleeps. Sometimes she manages a few minutes on her Switch, pulling a weed or two around Adora's cottage, planting a virtual flower with agonizing slowness.

Mostly, she just exists, the dull throb in her pelvis a constant companion, the ghost of Adora a silent sentinel.

Mara arrives for the morning visit, snapping on her gloves with her usual brisk efficiency, though her eyes hold a new layer of watchful concern. "Ready?" she asks, approaching the bed with fresh wipes and the basin.

Catra's claws dig into the mattress, her tail thrashing weakly against the sheets like a dying animal caught in a trap. Resignation wars with a flicker of old defiance. "Just *do it*."

The bed bath is mechanical. Mara swabs her armpits, the crease of her thighs, the base of her tail where the fur is still slightly matted despite previous cleanings. Catra fixes her gaze on the water stain–*Adora's cloud/stain*–as the washcloth scrapes gently over her left hip.

The joint still juts slightly, the surrounding muscles tight and inflamed.

"You're healing," Mara offers, pressing a fresh, cold gel pack firmly against the swollen area. The chill bites through the thin fabric of Catra's sweats. "Slowly. But the inflammation's going down."

"Fuck off," Catra mumbles, but there was less venom in it. The cold actually helps.

Progress, however glacial, is undeniable. By day five, Catra can sit up on the edge of the bed with Mara's help, supported by a fortress of pillows, her spine curved into a painful question mark. The dizziness is intense, the world tilting precariously. By day seven, Mara stands before her, hands outstretched.

"Okay, try it. Nice and slow. Use my arms."

Catra grips Mara's forearms, her claws retracted but pressing hard into the aide's sleeves. She pushes with her legs, a groan tearing from her lips as muscles scream and joints protest. Her legs tremble violently, threatening to buckle instantly.

She sways wildly, a sapling in a gale, her vision tunneling to grey. Mara holds firm, her grip unyielding, taking Catra's weight.

"Breathe," Mara orders, her voice calm but firm. "Deep breaths. Don't lock your knees."

Adora's ghost hovers by the window, bathed in the morning light. Her lips move, forming silent words Catra can't decipher over the roaring in her ears. Her spectral hand reaches out, hovering near Catra's trembling shoulder.

The *pop* comes on a Tuesday morning. Catra is leaning heavily on her cane against the kitchen counter, her weight mostly on her right leg, her left hovering cautiously. She's reaching for a protein shake Mara had left on the counter–a small act of independence. As she stretches, her weight shifts minutely.

It's not a loud sound. More a deep, internal *thunk*, a vibration that resonates through her bones like a seismic shift deep within the earth. It isn't the sickening wet pop of dislocation. This is… different. Solid.

The cane clatters to the floor as she screams, a sound of pure shock and agony. She collapses sideways against the fridge, bracing herself for the white-hot blade of pain to return.

It doesn't.

The blinding, grinding agony that has been her constant companion for over a week… dissolves. It doesn't vanish entirely; it recedes, transforming into a deep, manageable ache, a bruised throb rather than a stabbing torment.

The unnatural pressure in her pelvis eases. The joint feels… aligned. Stable. Still painful, but *bearably* so.

"Oh," she gasps, sliding down the fridge door to sit on the cool linoleum floor. She stares at her left hip in disbelief, then at the fallen cane lying beside her. "Oh, *fuck*."

A breathless, disbelieving laugh bubbles up, followed immediately by hot tears. She wipes at them furiously with the back of her hand, the motion feeling strangely fluid.

Adora's cracked running watch on the nightstand in the next room blinks serenely.

Catra laughs again, the sound watery and strange, tears dripping onto her sweats and the floor. Relief, profound and dizzying, washes over her, leaving her trembling.

Dr. Netossa's face fills the tablet screen, crisp and clear. Midday sunlight streams through the window behind her, backlighting her and making her look a little severe. Catra has angled her own camera carefully, showing only her face and shoulders, hiding the nest of rumpled sheets and the small pile of empty applesauce pouches on her nightstand.

"The joint reduction? That's significant progress, Catra," Dr. Netossa says, though her tone holds a note of professional caution.

“There’s something else, too. That moment by the cabinet… you recognized the suicidal ideation for what it was. A signal. A symptom of overwhelming pain and despair, not a directive. And your response? You reached out. To Mara. That’s seeking connection, however small.”

Catra’s gaze drifts from the screen, focusing intently on Dr. Netossa’s left hand resting on her desk. The gold wedding band gleams, snug and secure.

Adora’s ghost sits perched on the edge of Catra’s own bed, just out of the camera’s view. She’s tracing the grooves on her own faded tungsten band, a wistful expression on her translucent face.

'Matching,' her voice echoes faintly in Catra’s mind. *'Scratch-proof. Unbreakable. Just like us.'* A promise shattered.

“I didn’t *seek* anything,” Catra mutters, dragging her eyes back to the therapist’s pixelated face. The gold band feels like an accusation. “I ran. Like a cornered animal. Same as always.” The words taste bitter.

Dr. Netossa’s gaze follows Catra’s line of sight, landing on her own ring. Her expression softens almost imperceptibly. “You miss her.”

The simple statement cracks something open. The carefully maintained dam of stoicism crumbles.

“I miss…” Catra’s voice catches, thick with tears she refused to let fall. “I miss *existing* in a world where she *did*.” The words spill out, raw and unbidden.

The confession hangs in the air between them, a palpable thing. Suddenly, the world outside the tight frame of the tablet screen—her apartment, her life—crashes in on her, a prison of memory she is sitting in the center of.

The specter of Adora’s parka by the door, just out of sight. The knowledge of those expired protein bars standing guard in the

pantry. The permanent hollow in the mattress beside her that she can feel more than see.

"It's been five years," Catra whispers, the tremor in her voice unmistakable. "I'm still *here*. Trapped in this… this broken thing." She gestures vaguely at her own body. "And *she's* still here. In every corner. In every damn dust mote. Just… not." Her vision blurs, Dr. Netossa's wedding band dissolving into a smear of gold light.

A pause stretches. Adora's ghost picks at a loose thread on the worn quilt beside her. *"You shouldn't be doing this alone,"* she sighs, her voice thin and melancholic. The words hang in the air, a simple condemnation of the unbearable reality.

Dr. Netossa shifts, her ring catching the sunlight again, sending a bright spark across the screen. "What if the park," she begins carefully, "wasn't just about trying to connect with other people? What if it was about connecting with *her*? With the memories that live out there? The places you shared?"

Catra's tail, resting on the bed beside her, lashes once, a sharp, irritated movement. "So I should what? Haunt our old bench like some pathetic widow? Throw stale bread at ducks because *she* thought it was funny?" Bitterness coats her tongue.

"I'm saying grief isn't linear, Catra. Healing isn't a straight path from point A to point B. It's messy. It loops back. It stalls." Dr. Netossa leans slightly closer to her camera, her expression earnest.

"You tried to expand your world. It backfired. That doesn't mean you stop trying. It means you find *new* bridges. Smaller ones. Different ones. Bridges back to *her*, maybe. Bridges to… something else. Eventually."

The call ends, leaving the apartment buzzing with a different kind of silence. Not just absence, but the echo of uncomfortable

truths.

Catra stares at the blank tablet screen for a long moment. Then, slowly, painfully, she leans over and claws open the small drawer in her nightstand. Inside, nestled in a velvet-lined box, are their wedding rings.

She lifts the lid. The two bands nestled together. Adora’s was slightly larger, thicker, a brushed tungsten ring. Catra’s was slimmer, polished. Simple. Strong.

Unadorned except for the single word engraved inside each: "Always". Catra traces the engraved word on Adora’s ring with a trembling claw tip. *Always.* A promise that hadn't survived.

A notification chimes on her phone, shattering the moment.

Mara: Ate the applesauce?

Catra glared at the pouch still sitting on the nightstand. **Catra:** No.

Mara: Eat it. Now.

Catra snarls silently at the phone. But the phantom ache in her pelvis, now a dull throb rather than a scream, was a potent reminder. It's a simple, brutal equation she understands: fuel the healing, or the pain will get worse.

With a grimace, she snatches the pouch, tears the top off with her teeth, and sucks down the overly sweet, cloying puree. It tastes like defeat, but also, reluctantly, like survival.

Adora’s ghost drifts closer, humming the bombastic theme to *Celestial Wars*, Adora’s favorite cheesy space opera. The ridiculousness of it, the sheer *Adora-ness*, pulls a faint, unwilling huff of something almost like amusement from Catra.

She grabs her Switch. Adora’s cottage is besieged again. Three fat pixelated weeds mock her from the virtual garden. She moves her

avatar, her thumbs still stiff but moving with less protest than a week ago. *Pull.* One weed vanishes.

She glances at the TV she left on mute. Princess Serenia's clone, tears streaming down her perfect face, is pleading with her creator on some stark asteroid. The subtitles read, *"You left me to rot! Alone!"*

Catra's gaze drifts back to the open ring box beside her. The engraved word seem to pulse.

"Always," she mouths silently to the screen, to the ghost, to the empty room. She turns back to the Switch. *Pull.* Another weed disappears. Just one left. Tomorrow.

Chapter 4: Velvet Heat and Open Doors

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra drifts into a landscape saturated with sensation, a cruel hologram of what was lost. She feels touch. Not the clinical touch of Mara.

Adora's hands: calloused palms from weightlifting and stubborn DIY projects, yet impossibly gentle. Real, solid warmth radiates from them as they trace the curve of Catra's spine, skate over her ribs, palm the swell of her hip.

A low hum vibrates in Adora's chest, a sound Catra feels more than hears, resonating through her own fur.

Adora's mouth follows a blazing trail down Catra's stomach, her breath hitching in that familiar way against the sensitive fur just below her navel. A soft laugh, warm and intimate, puffing against her skin.

"You're shaking," Adora murmurs, her lips brushing the base of Catra's cock, the words sending a jolt through her already trembling body.

Then, the velvet heat. Adora's mouth, enveloping her. A perfect, wet pressure. Catra's claws instinctively twist into the thick, golden hair she knows so well, fisting it tight. Adora's lips stretch around her, taking her deeper, her hollowed cheeks creating a relentless suction that pulls a ragged gasp from Catra's throat.

"Fuck—Adora—" The name is a plea, a prayer. Her thighs quiver violently, threatening to buckle even in the dream.

Adora grips the base of Catra's cock, stroking in a firm, grounding rhythm perfectly synced with the movement of her head. Her

other hand cups Catra's balls with a possessive, reassuring squeeze. The pressure is perfect–anchoring and urgent.

Then Adora hums, the vibration shuddering up Catra's cock, radiating through her core, lighting every nerve ending like a live wire.

Her tongue laps at the leaking tip, salty and slick, then slides down to press flat and firm against the sensitive underside.

Catra's back arches violently off the dream-bed, a strangled cry tearing from her as her tail thrashed wildly. "Don't stop," she gasps, heat coiling impossibly tight, ready to snap—

She wakes with a gasp that feels like surfacing from drowning. Claws tangle deep in the sheets, her body rigid, taut as a bowstring, trembling uncontrollably.

The afterimage burns behind her eyelids: Adora's smirk, triumphant and tender; the phantom weight of her palm resting possessively on Catra's chest; the searing echo of release that hadn't actually happened.

Her fur is damp with sweat, her cock throbbing with a fierce, insistent ache that held no thrill, only a profound, hollow yearning.

She stares at the water-stained ceiling, her tail flicking in slow, frustrated arcs against the mattress, a metronome of unmet need.

Five years. The number slams into her, cold and final. Catra grits her teeth, a low growl rumbling in her chest. Her claws drag down her own sternum, torn between the desperate urge to chase the fading, torturous high of the dream and the violent impulse to claw her own skin off, to purge the phantom sensations, the unbearable memory of pleasure.

Her hand hovers over her cock, trembling violently. Just touch. Just finish it. Ease the ache. But the silence of the apartment is a vast, suffocating presence.

The echo of Adora's bright, uninhibited laugh–the one that would have followed such intensity, the one that would have held pride and affection–feels like shards of glass in her mind.

With a sound of pure frustration, she rolls onto her side, burying her face in Adora's pillow, her tail lashing wildly until the physical need fades into a dull, heavy throb, a suffocating weight low in her belly.

The park feels like penance. Sunlight dapples through the new spring leaves, a sharp contrast to the leaden weight in her chest.

One lap. That's the bargain she struck with her treacherous body. Her cane taps a steady rhythm against the pavement, a counterpoint to her heartbeat.

Her SI joint grumbles, a familiar, deep ache, but it holds. She focuses on grounding herself, a technique Dr. Netossa had suggested that felt less like therapy and more like desperate survival.

Cracked asphalt under the cane tip. Soft moss spilling between worn cobblestones near the old fountain. A child's chalk drawing on the path–a lopsided cat with too many eyes and a cheerful, jagged smile.

She cataloges each sensation, forcing her mind away from the lingering heat of the dream, away from the phantom pressure between her legs.

The willow tree looms ahead, its long branches weeping over their bench, shrouding it in green-tinted shadow. A wave of visceral memory washes over her–picnics on good days, Adora reading aloud on bad ones, silent tears shared when words failed.

Catra's pace quickens, her cane tapping faster. *Don't look. Just walk*.

A blur of movement. A toddler, bundled in bright yellow, lurches off the grass and directly into her path. Before Catra can fully

register the obstacle, the child thrusts a dandelion towards her face. “Fower!” the little voice declares, sticky fingers glistening.

Adora’s ghost materializes instantly beside the child, translucent and shimmering. She mimicks the eager gesture with spectral hands. *'Take it, take it!'* her voice echoes, bright with amusement only Catra could hear. *'It’s a national treasure! Look at that fluff!'*

Catra snorts, a harsh, unexpected sound. The sheer absurdity of the ghostly commentary juxtaposed with the sticky reality cuts through her gloom. “Thanks,” she mutters gruffly, accepting the crumpled weed. The petals are already mangled.

She stuffs the damp, slightly sticky offering into the pocket of her hoodie, avoiding the mother’s quick, apologetic smile. She’s already moving, the cane finding its rhythm again. Adora’s laughter, a faint, warm echo, trails her down the path like a persistent, bittersweet shadow.

The coffee shop door is heavy, old wood swollen with humidity. Its hinges groan in protest as Catra tries to maneuver her cane and push. A man in a bright blue bike helmet, waiting behind her, lunges forward. “Here—let me,” he offers, effortlessly swinging the door wide.

Catra’s ears twitch. The offer isn’t laced with pity, just practical, unassuming kindness. She gives a single, sharp nod, eyes fixed on the floor tiles just inside the threshold.

Inside, the air is thick with the comforting scents of steamed milk, rich coffee, and growing things. Plants seem to cover every available surface, blooming on tables, spilling over shelves. A wave of warmth and chatter and color envelope her, momentarily overwhelming.

Behind the counter stands the barista. She's all softness–flowing, cream-colored linen trousers, a loose sage-green tunic, her hair a cascade of spun gold pulled back in a loose braid. A faint smudge

of vibrant green matcha powder dusts the edge of her apron pocket.

Catra focuses her gaze on the barista's collarbone, the delicate line visible above the neckline of her tunic. A safe focal point. She shuffles forward, bracing her free arm subtly against the counter to take pressure off her shoulder joint on the side that holds the cane.

"Black coffee," Catra rasps, her voice rough from disuse and the lingering tightness in her throat.

The barista smiles, a warm, genuine expression that crinkles the corners of her eyes. "Sure thing. Name for the order?"

Catra freezes. The simple question feels like a chasm opening. Her name. Said aloud. To a stranger. Her tail tip gives a single, involuntary flick against her leg.

She stares at the espresso machine, the hiss of steam suddenly loud. Five years of being "the patient," "Mrs. Gray", or just silence.

"...Catra," she manages, the name feeling strange and vulnerable on her own lips.

"Catra," the barista repeats the name sounding soft, unhurried, perfectly normal in her melodic voice. She writes it out onto a to-go cup. "Nice to meet you, Catra. I'll have this right out." She turns to the gleaming machine, her movements fluid and practiced.

Catra watches, her gaze drifting from the woman's collarbone to the smudge of matcha, to the efficient way her hands moved. The silence stretches, filled by the cafe's bustle, but it isn't uncomfortable. Just... present.

Soon, the black coffee slides across the counter towards her. The barista's fingers, dusted with the same green powder, linger for a

fraction of a second longer than necessary. “Hope you have a good rest of your day, Catra.”

Catra’s ears flick again, a quick, nervous movement. She grabs the cup, the heat seeping into her stiff fingers.

“Thanks,” she mutters again, already turning away, the warmth of the beverage and the sound of her name spoken so casually burning against her skin.

She flees home to the silence of her apartment, her heart pounding strangely.

Back at her apartment door, the keyhole mocks her. Juggling the cane and the coffee cup, Catra fumbles with her keys. They slip from her stiff fingers, clattering to the floor. A growl of frustration escaped her.

She bends, a movement sending sharp protests from her SI joint and knees, claws scraping the linoleum as she retrieved them.

Adora’s ghost shimmers into view beside the doorknob, leaning casually against the frame. “Let me,” she whispers, her translucent hand hovering over the lock. “I always got it on the first try.”

“You can’t,” Catra snaps under her breath, glaring at the spectral figure. She jams the key into the lock again, twisting with more force than necessary.

The deadbolt finally clicks open with a heavy thunk. “See?” she mutters, pushing the door open and stumbling inside, leaving the ghost smirking faintly in the hallway.

The coffee mug is deposited on the counter, steam long gone. Catra stares at it. Not at the coffee, but at the side of the mug. Scrawled in loopy, dark green ink is a single word: *Catra.* Simple. Unadorned. Undeniably her.

A stranger. Had seen her, registered her, and written her name. Like it was normal. Like she belonged in the stream of other people ordering coffee. The significance of it, small as it was, lands with surprising weight.

Catra collapses onto the worn green velvet armchair, her spine crackling in protest. She pulls her Switch onto her lap, the familiar weight a comfort. Powering it on, she navigates directly to the island, to Adora's cottage.

The digital weeds seem particularly aggressive today, practically choking the pixelated path. Jaw clenching, she moves her avatar. Pull. Pull. Pull. Three weeds vanish into digital oblivion. The small act feels cathartic, a tiny reassertion of control.

She opens the mailbox icon. The cursor blinks in the blank field.

To: Adora

Subject: (no subject)

went to the park. got a weed from a baby.

some barista said my name like it was normal. wrote it down.

i miss you.

She hits send. The little envelope icon flies off into the pixelated sky. She shuts off the Switch, the screen going dark.

Adora's ghost perches on the armrest beside her, her outline softly gilded by a sliver of late afternoon sun streaming through the curtain covering the south-facing window. "Proud of you," she says, her voice clear and warm.

For a single, fleeting heartbeat, leaning against the worn velvet, the ghost of Adora beside her and the echo of her own name from a stranger's lips in her ears, Catra almost believes her.

A fragile scaffolding begins to form. Not hope, exactly. More like… structure. A framework for existing slightly outside the suffocating confines of the apartment and her grief.

Mondays she makes *one* lap around the park. The cane taps the rhythm of her heartbeat. She catalogues textures: Rough bark of the old oak. Smooth coolness of the bronze duck statue. Squishy mud near the pond edge after rain. She avoids the willow. Mostly.

Thursdays she sits fifteen minutes on a bench by the duck pond. She counts dandelion puffs blown by the breeze, counts the ducks squabbling, counts the cracks in the pavement at her feet. Sometimes, she just closes her eyes and let the chaotic sounds of life wash over her.

The Verdant Cup, the quiet coffee shop with the discreet sign, becomes the quiet anchor of most of her days.

Catra claims her usual corner table, bracing her elbows firmly against the sticky laminate to offload weight from her treacherous shoulders, a small defense against dislocation.

The first tentative sip of black coffee is a grounding ritual, the bitterness a familiar anchor.

The coffee shop becomes an unlikely laboratory. Catra, the reluctant scientist, experiments with tiny increments of exposure:

Day 1: One gray morning, she pulls Adora's dog-eared thriller from her bag. Her hands tremble violently, blurring the words, threatening to tear the fragile paper.

After three agonizing pages, knuckles throbbing, she shoves it back into the bag's depths. *Failure.* Yet the coffee cup sits empty before her. A small, bitter victory.

Day 4: She skips the park, conserving energy. She times her visit for the mid-morning student rush. The café erupts in a cacophony of overlapping conversations—exams, heartbreaks, weekend plans —a wall of static that presses against her skull.

She focuses on the ceramic's heat against her palms, the measured in-and-out of her breath. At the twelve-minute mark, a rising tide of panic forces her to retreat, ears pinned flat. *Partial success?* She endured longer than she thought possible.

Day 11: She pulls out a small, unlined notebook and a pen. Not to write. To draw. Or attempt to. Her claws grip the pen too tightly, cramping her hand. She starts with spirals, simple shapes. The pressure needed makes her thumb joint grind unpleasantly.

She manages half a page of shaky, overlapping spirals and cubes before the pain forces her to stop. She flexes her fingers under the table, frustrated but not defeated. The notebook stays on the table for the rest of her visit.

Catra feels the barista's eyes on her.

Not obviously, not intrusively, but it's a subtle pressure on the back of her neck. She's learned to read the woman's attention in the way she pauses a half-second too long when wiping down the nearby tables, a quiet observation Catra is sure has catalogued every tiny change: the way her tail, usually a tightly coiled spring curled against her leg, has begun to unkink slightly, the tip sometimes giving a lazy flick.

She's certain the woman has marked the evolution of her orders from a guttural "Coffee. Black," to "Small black coffee," and, one remarkable Saturday, the mumbled "Please," she'd directed at the gleaming espresso machine. A tiny word, heavy with effort, offered to the air and duly noted.

The world outside her grief begins to imprint itself, interaction by small interaction:

An older man, seeing her approach the heavy door burdened by her cane, holds the door open for her. "After you," he offers with a polite nod. Her eyes meet his for a fleeting second before her chin dips in acknowledgment. *Ears warm, but no panic.* Progress.

In line, an elderly woman with a puffball poodle gestures her forward. “You look like you need to sit down, dearie.” Humiliation burns Catra’s ears, but she holds her ground, muttering “Thanks” to the floor tiles. She doesn’t bolt.

The barista slides the familiar blue mug she's started giving Catra across the counter. “Here you go, Catra.” That name, spoken so normally. Catra’s gaze flickers from the barista’s collarbone down to the name tag pinned to her apron. *Perfuma.* The name lodges in her throat, making her tongue feel thick. Her fangs press against her lower lip.

“Thanks… Perfuma.” The name leaves her lips deliberately, an offering laid bare. Her heartbeat stutters—vulnerability tangled with a fragile sense of accomplishment.

As Catra turns towards her table, she doesn’t see Perfuma’s reaction: the barista’s hands flying briefly to her chest, clasped tight, her eyes wide with startled delight and wonder, as if cradling the rarest, most precious bloom.

Catra writes another letter to Adora:

To: Adora

Subject: progress?

the barista remembers my name. calls me catra.

i said hers today. perfuma.

she’s nothing like you. no loud laugh. no calluses from weights. no coconut water hate (probably).

but she doesn’t look at me like i’m glass. or a ghost. she just... sees catra. ordering coffee.

it’s weird.

Before powering off her Switch, she navigates to Adora's cottage. Four particularly obnoxious pixelated weeds have sprouted overnight near the door. Catra moves her avatar. Delete. Delete. Delete. Delete. Four weeds vanish.

She doesn't plant anything new. Just eradicating the encroaching chaos. A small act of order. A tiny declaration that maybe, just maybe, the weeds aren't winning quite as much today.

She sets the Switch down, the phantom warmth of Adora's dream-touch fading into the cool reality of the sheets, replaced by a fragile, unfamiliar sense of… something less than utter despair.

That night, sleep comes easier. Catra dreams of Adora's hands again–calloused palms skimming the curve of her hips, lips trailing heated promises against the fur of her neck, promises that dissolve like smoke upon waking, leaving only a faint echo.

But for the first time in five years, the ache that follows the dream feels distant. Not gone, not healed, but manageable. A dull throb instead of a fresh wound. It's a subtle shift, but seismic in its implication.

It isn't peace. But it isn't the crushing weight of yesterday. It's space. And for now, that space was enough.

Chapter End Notes

yayyyyy we finally get to meet perfuma <3

Chapter 5: The Unspoken Language

The Verdant Cup in the quiet lull after the morning rush becomes Catra's sanctuary. The air hangs rich with the scent of freshly ground beans, a comforting, earthy perfume that mingles with the damp green breath of thriving plants and the faint, sweet aroma of pastries.

Sunlight, filtered through leaves, dapples worn wooden tables which still bare ghostly rings from hurried mugs–testaments to lives briefly intersecting before scattering into the day, now watched over by silent, growing things.

Trailing ivy cascades from high shelves, tendrils brushing the tops of framed local art. Lush ferns spill from ceramic pots on the counter near the register, their fronds vibrant against the gleaming steel of the espresso machine.

On the windowsills, rows of herbs–fragrant basil, pungent rosemary, soft-leafed thyme–grow in neat terracotta pots, ready to be snipped for fresh teas or garnishes, their vitality a counterpoint to the steam rising from the milk frother.

A large, glossy monstera dominates one corner, its split leaves reaching towards the skylight, while smaller, flowering plants–cheerful purple orchids, clusters of white peace lilies, even a stubborn little kalanchoe blooming defiantly red–perch on tables and nestle amongst books on the community shelf.

Near Catra's corner, a tall, graceful snake plant stands sentinel, its upright spears of variegated green a quiet pillar in the space. It wasn't just decoration; it was an ecosystem.

The cafe pulses with quiet, chlorophyll-rich life, a testament to the barista who nurtures roots as tenderly as she poured shots.

Perfuma is a constant, grounding presence. Catra shuffles in, the bell above the door a soft chime announcing her arrival, and finds

Perfuma already immersed in the rhythm of the quiet hour–restocking sugar packets with precise movements, polishing the chrome of the espresso machine until it gleams, or meticulously arranging almond croissants in the glass case like precious artifacts.

Perfuma rarely looks up immediately, her focus seemingly absolute on her task. But Catra has learned the subtle language of this space. As she reaches the counter, her mug appears as if conjured: black coffee, steaming gently in the familiar chipped ceramic cup–*her* cup. It's a silent offering, a wordless acknowledgment that requires no fanfare.

Catra's tail gives an involuntary twitch, the tip flicking once against her leg. Acknowledgement. Not a word passed. Perfuma might be wiping invisible crumbs from the counter with a tea towel, her soft humming syncing perfectly with the rhythmic *drip-drip-drip* of the espresso machine's final drops.

Four weeks ago, the presumption might have sparked irritation in Catra, a bristling against unspoken expectations. Now, she simply curls her claws safely within her sheaths, wrapping her free hand around the warm mug, letting the heat seep into the perpetually aching joints of her fingers.

The silence between them isn't empty; it's worn smooth, comfortable as the grain of the wood on her corner table, a shared understanding built on consistency and unspoken respect.

The corner table by the window becomes Catra's unofficial territory. The chair was marginally better for her hips, offering a fraction more support.

One damp, gray morning, she arrives to find a new addition: a thick cushion, covered in faded navy fabric, its edges slightly frayed. It hadn't been there yesterday.

Catra pauses, ears swiveling forward. Perfuma is arranging clean mugs on a high shelf, humming a tune Catra almost recognized. Without looking, Perfuma gestures subtly towards the table.

Catra lowers herself cautiously, bracing on her cane. She sinks onto the cushion, and lets out an audible sigh of relief. It's firm yet yielding, perfectly contoured to take pressure off her sacrum.

She risks a glance at the counter. Perfuma is now polishing the steam wand, her humming uninterrupted, but Catra catches the faintest upward tilt at the corner of her mouth.

Later that week, a delivery truck backfires violently right outside the large window. The sharp crack echoed like gunfire. Catra flinches hard, a cold jolt of adrenaline locking her muscles, her ears ringing, flattening tight against her skull, claws digging reflexively into the table's edge, leaving tiny crescents in the wood.

Perfuma, frothing milk for another customer, doesn't pause her task or her soft hum. But the next morning, the café's background playlist is different. Gone are the occasional brassy, jarring tunes. In their place flowed gentle acoustic guitar, soft piano melodies, the soothing murmur of cello strings.

Catra notices. She unclenches her fists, the tension slowly ebbing from her shoulders.

"You're not scowling as much," Mara announces, meticulously sorting Catra's weekly pills into the dispenser's tiny compartments. She doesn't look up.

Catra, perched stiffly on the edge of her bed, glares. "I don't scowl."

Mara finally glances over, raising one eyebrow pointedly. "You're doing it right now. Right this second."

Catra huffs, a puff of air escaping her nostrils. Her tail, which had been lying still, curls defensively around her ankles.

“The coffee’s decent,” she mutters, focusing intently on a loose thread on her sweatpants. “That’s all.”

Mara snaps the last compartment shut, the sound final in the quiet room. She meets Catra’s gaze, her expression unreadable for a moment. Then, she simply nods, a small, knowing smile playing on her lips.

She doesn’t push. She doesn’t tease further. Her silence feels like a permission slip, an acknowledgment of something shifting that doesn't need immediate labeling.

Rain lashes against the café windows, transforming the outside world into a blurry, grey watercolor. Inside, it’s a cocoon of warmth and golden light, the downpour amplifying the sense of sanctuary.

Catra stares at her reflection warped in the rain-streaked glass–a rippling, indistinct figure that could be anyone. It reminds her of the duck pond on stormy days.

Perfuma drifts over, a clean towel draped over her shoulder like a waiter in a quiet bistro. “Need a refill?” Her voice is soft, blending with the patter of rain and the mellow guitar music.

Catra startles slightly, pulling her gaze from the window. Her mug was still half-full. “Still full,” she rasps, the words catching. She clears her throat, the sound overly loud to her own ears. “Storm’s worse than Tuesday.” It’s an observation, offered unprompted into the comfortable quiet.

Perfuma blinks, surprise flickering across her face before settling into gentle attentiveness. “It’ll drown the park again,” she says, her gaze drifting towards the window as if picturing it. “Your bench by the pond might float away.”

“My bench?” Catra’s ears twitch upright, a defensive spike running through her. How does she know? Has she been watching that closely?

“I see you from the window sometimes,” Perfuma says, her tone softening as if to soothe a startled animal. She gestures lightly with the towel toward the cafe's large front window.

“When I’m setting up. You seem to like that spot when the weather’s nice.” Her words hold no judgment, only quiet, simple fact.

Catra’s claws flex against her mug. Instinct screams to shut this down, to throw up a wall with a sneer or a cutting remark. Instead, her tail gives a single, restless flick against the chair leg– a stilted, hesitant beat.

“Ducks don’t care about floods,” she mutters, looking back at her coffee. “They just… float.”

It isn’t witty. Isn’t even coherent, but Perfuma’s mouth softens into a genuine, understanding curve. “They paddle through everything. Resilient little things.”

Silence stretches, filled only by the rain and the music. Catra stares into the dark depths of her coffee, willing her traitorous pulse to slow down.

The defensiveness wars with a strange, unfamiliar urge to… connect. “They’re assholes,” she adds abruptly, the words tumbling out too late.

Perfuma doesn’t miss a beat. Her laugh isn’t a startled burst, but a warm, rich exhale that seemed to fill the space between them. “True,” she agrees, her eyes crinkling at the corners. She gives Catra another soft look, then retreats back behind the counter.

Catra’s cheeks burn. She doesn’t touch her cooling coffee. When she finally leaves, she doesn’t head straight home. She takes the long route, skirting the edge of the park.

Through the downpour, she can see the willow tree's branches whipping like frantic arms against the grey sky. But strangely, beneath the drumming rain on her hood, her chest feels… lighter.

A flicker of something unnameable, like the determined flutter of a duck riding the choppy water of the pond–something she'll never admit she admires.

Back in the dim apartment, Catra powers on her Switch. The cheerful jingle of her island feels jarring after the rain-soaked intensity. She navigates past Adora's cottage, its pixelated form a comforting constant.

Instead of pulling weeds, she opens the construction app. Down by the virtual beach, she starts building. Rough-hewn wooden stools take shape. A small chalkboard menu appears beside a tiny counter. She places a jukebox nearby, selecting K.K. Slider's most mellow tunes.

It isn't The Verdant Cup, but it has its own quiet charm. Finally, she places a single, perfect white lily in a small vase on the counter. Adora's favorite.

She opens the mailbox.

To: Adora

Subject: rain

park is flooding.

the barista sees me on the bench. from the cafe window.

~~i think she watches me.~~

whatever.

Chapter 6: Roots in the Cracks

Weeks bleed into a comfortable rhythm. Catra learns the café's heartbeat: the elderly couple who arrives precisely at noon to split a single almond croissant and share a pot of Earl Grey; the intense student who types furiously on a battered laptop until the battery dies, fueled by triple espressos; the large, cheerful woman—Scorpia, according to her name tag—whose booming laugh and easy camaraderie with Perfuma sometimes cut through the café's hum.

The way Perfuma's usually warm laugh sharpens, becoming clipped and efficient, when a large, complicated order comes in right before closing.

One bustling Tuesday morning, Catra arrives to find her corner table occupied by a trio of students spreading out textbooks and laptops. A flicker of panic, cold and familiar, shoots through her. Her ears flatten. Where can she go? The other tables feel too exposed, too close to the chatter.

Perfuma appears instantly, a slight flush on her cheeks. "Morning! Bit crowded today. How about…"

She gestures towards the back of the café, where a high-backed booth nestles beside a large, lush potted fern.

"The fern's looking particularly lively today." Her smile is bright, but Catra sees the slight tension around her eyes.

Catra eyes the booth. It's shielded, quieter. "Did you water it with espresso?" she deadpans, a test.

Perfuma blinks, then let out a sudden, unfiltered snort of laughter that makes a student look up from her laptop. "I'll never tell," Perfuma chuckles, the tension dissolving.

But as she hands Catra her mug, her fingers brush Catra's for a heartbeat too long. Perfuma stiffens almost imperceptibly and

retreats swiftly back behind the counter, busying herself unnecessarily with the grinder.

Catra's tail coils tight around her leg. She sinks into the seat, the fern's broad leaves offering a sense of privacy. Adora's ghost leans against the pastry case, arms crossed, a translucent eyebrow arched. *'She's trying to say something. Look at her fidget.'*

"Not your business," Catra mutters into her coffee, the warmth spreading up her neck.

Two days later, under a sky the color of bruised lilacs, they collide at the park.

Catra is on her bench, methodically counting dandelions (fourteen, mostly decapitated by the breeze or eager children) when a familiar figure appears on the path.

Perfuma, hair escaping a frizzy braid, her usually pristine apron streaked with dirt, lugs a heavy woven tote bulging with pruning shears and seed packets.

"Oh! Catra." Perfuma stops short, surprise widening her hazel eyes. She shifts the heavy tote. "I—uh. Hi."

"Do you *live* here?" Catra's ears twitch, intrigued. Out of the café's warmth, Perfuma seems smaller, her sunbeam aura dimmed by the overcast sky and physical labor. She feels… real.

A small smile touches Perfuma's lips. "Feels like it sometimes. Volunteering. The city's replanting native wildflowers near the pond bank. Erosion control, pollinator support… that kind of thing."

She gestures vaguely at her dirt-streaked tools. "Anyway…" She hesitates, shifting her weight. "Would you… like company? For a bit?"

Catra’s claws sink into the bench’s chipped wood. The air smells richly of damp earth and impending rain.

Adora’s ghost materializes beside her on the bench, translucent fingers tracing the empty space next to Catra. *'Say yes,'* the ghost’s voice gently nudges.

“Fine,” Catra relents, the word gruff. “But don’t—” *Ask about the pain. Touch me. Look at me like I’m about to shatter.* “—talk about the weather. It’s depressing enough.”

Perfuma carefully lowers her tote and sits, leaving a careful foot of space between them. She doesn’t speak immediately, just breathing in the cool, earthy air.

The silence stretches, companionable at first, then growing heavier, punctuated only by distant shrieks of children chasing geese and the rustle of the tote’s contents as Perfuma fidgets.

Finally, Perfuma knots her hands in her lap, dirt caked under her short nails. “You’ve noticed I’ve been… off lately,” she states, her voice uncharacteristically small. It isn’t a question.

Catra’s tail lashes once, a sharp whip-crack against the bench wood. “You flinch every time I walk in the door.”

The direct hit makes Perfuma suck in a sharp breath. She looks down at her dirty hands, twisting them together. There is no hiding from this.

“It’s not a bad flinch,” she blurts out, then seems to surprise herself with her own swift honesty. She swallows, her voice softening to a vulnerable whisper. “It’s… it’s like when you see a beautiful animal and you freeze, because you don’t want to scare it away. Your heart just… jumps. And you forget how to breathe.”

The silence that follows is deafening. It's a confession wrapped in a metaphor, terrifyingly brave and utterly disarming.

Inside Catra's head, a single, static thought: *Beautiful.* The word rings, leaving a void where her defenses used to be.

Perfuma lifts her eyes, meeting Catra's wary gaze. Sunlight, breaking weakly through the clouds, catches the flecks of green in her hazel irises. "Catra, would you… ever want to talk? Not as a barista and a customer. Just… as me. Talking to you. As *people*?"

Catra freezes. The rough wood of the bench bites into her palms. The question feels like a chasm opening beneath her. "Why?" The word comes out flat, defensive. "Why would you want to?"

Perfuma turns fully towards her, her expression open, earnest, vulnerable in a way Catra hasn't seen before. "Because you see the cracks in the world," she says softly. "And I see the cracks in you. Not as flaws, but as proof that you survived."

"You don't just carry the world's heaviness—you've absorbed its shrapnel. I see the weight of it in your shoulders, the way you hold yourself like you're still expecting a blow."

A faint smile touches her lips. "And yet, you still count the dandelions. You notice the ducks on the pond. I… want to know the person who holds both of those truths. The real you behind the black coffee and the carefully chosen corner table."

Catra's laugh is a harsh, rasping sound, devoid of humor. "Trust me, you don't." The image of the bathroom floor flashes–the claw marks, the humiliation, the crushing weight of brokenness.

"Try me," Perfuma whispers, the challenge quiet but absolute. Her hand rests on the bench, palm up, not demanding, just open.

Adora's ghost leans in close, her spectral form radiating warmth Catra can almost feel. *'She's safe, Catra. Open up to her.'* The ghost's voice is tender, insistent.

The dam, brittle and strained from years of isolation, cracks. Then it shatters.

Catra starts with the skeleton of her reality. “Ehlers-Danlos,” she rasps. “My connective tissue… it’s defective. Like cheap glue.”

She describes the snap of tendons, the way reaching for a mug can make her shoulder pop out of place, the constant, grinding instability in her joints.

“Used to climb fire escapes,” she adds, a flicker of defiance in her tired eyes. “Just to watch the sunset paint the rooftops. Sketch it later. Murals, sometimes. On walls people were gonna tear down anyway.”

Her gaze drops to her stiff, clawed hands resting on her cane. “Now I can’t even hold a fucking pen steady.” The admission scrapes her throat raw.

Perfuma’s breath hitches audibly. Her hand on the bench twitches, but she doesn’t reach out. “How long?” she asks, her voice thick.

“Diagnosed at nineteen.” Catra plucks a nearby dandelion, its stem limp. She shreds it methodically, her claws precise despite the stiffness. “More than twenty years of this slow decay.” She flicks the mangled petals away.

“Adora… she carried me up stairs when my knees gave out. Made braces out of ACE bandages and sheer stubbornness when we couldn’t afford proper ones.” A ghost of a smile touches her lips, fleeting and painful.

“Taught me how to—”

Breathe through the agony. Find the small joys. Keep living when every cell screamed to stop.

Her throat closes, the words lodging there.

“Adora,” Perfuma echoes softly, the name hanging in the damp air. “Your… partner?”

Adora’s ghost meets Catra’s gaze, shimmering faintly. She nods, her expression a mix of pride and profound sadness. *'Tell her.'*

Catra’s gaze dropped to the weathered wood of the bench between them, to a deep groove scored by time and weather. The rain began falling, light and cold, misting her fur. “My wife,” she says, the word tasting both sacred and like ash. “She’s gone. Five years next month.”

Perfuma goes utterly still. Not a breath seeming to escape her. “Gone?” The word is a whisper, barely audible over the patter of rain on leaves.

“Brain aneurysm.” Catra watches a raindrop slide down the weathered wood of the bench, tracing a slow, inevitable path. “Made pancakes that morning. Chocolate chip. Burned the first batch, like always.” Her voice roughens, the memory vivid, agonizing. “Laughed when I called her a disaster. Said the smoke alarm was her cooking timer.”

Her claws dig into the wood, puncturing the soft surface. “Then… she dropped the spatula. Just… collapsed.” Catra squeezes her eyes shut, the image seared onto her retinas. “Gone before the ambulance even got there. No warning. No chance to say goodbye. Just… silence.”

The rain falls softly around them. Perfuma makes a small, choked sound. Her hand, still resting open on the bench, trembles visibly. Then, slowly, carefully, she turns it over and settled it on top of Catra’s clenched fist where it grips the cane. The touch is warm, solid, alive. A lifeline thrown across the chasm of grief. “Catra…” Perfuma’s voice cracks. “I’m so sorry.”

Catra doesn’t pull away. The warmth of Perfuma’s hand is foreign, almost shocking against the cold numbness that has settled over her. It grounds her.

“She promised,” Catra whispers, the raw ache of betrayal resurfacing. “Promised she’d never leave. Then she *did*. And I…

just let myself rot inside our apartment. Become part of the dust. Until…”

She lifts her gaze, meeting Perfuma’s tear-filled eyes.

Until the park bench. Until the scent of damp earth. Until your quiet humming.

“Until now,” she finishes, the words barely a breath.

A large mallard, one foot dragging slightly, waddles past their bench, oblivious. Catra’s laugh is a broken, watery sound.

“That’s Waddles. Kids named him. He’s a menace.”

Perfuma’s grip on her hand tightens, a gentle, reassuring pressure. Her tears spill over, tracing clean paths through the smudges of dirt on her cheeks. She doesn’t wipe them away. “He’s perfect,” she whispers, her voice thick. “Just… perfect.”

Catra stands abruptly, her hip joint grinding in protest at the sudden movement. The emotional torrent, coupled with the damp cold, is making the pain flare. “Need to go. Sitting too long.” Her voice is rough, scraped raw.

“Of course,” Perfuma says instantly, rising swiftly but maintaining a respectful distance. She doesn’t crowd. She doesn’t fuss. “I’ll… see you tomorrow? At the Cup?”

Catra nods, adjusting her grip on the cane. She takes a step, then pauses, turning back slightly. “Perfuma?”

Perfuma looks up, her eyes still shimmering. “Yeah?”

“Thanks.” The single word holds the weight of the shared confession, the offered hand, the witnessed grief.

Perfuma offers a shaky, tearful smile that held immense warmth. “Any time, Catra. Truly.”

That night, Adora's ghost perches on the edge of Catra's bed. Moonlight streams through her translucent form, catching the faint scar on her brow–a souvenir from hauling Catra off a collapsing fence when they were seventeen. She just watches Catra for a long moment, her gaze full of a love that has outlasted death itself.

"Shut up," Catra mumbles into Adora's faded softball jersey, pressed against her face. The fabric is soft, threadbare at the seams, holding only the an imagined ghost of coconut shampoo and Adora's unique scent.

'She sees you,' Adora persists, her spectral hand hovering near Catra's shoulder. *'Really sees you. The strength, the snark, the pain… the artist who can't hold a pen.'* Her voice is warm, suffused with pride. *'Like I did.'*

"I don't *want* anyone else," Catra whispers fiercely, the jersey muffling her words. The familiar possessive ache flares. "Just you. Always you."

Adora's smile is infinitely tender, tinged with deep sadness. *'You don't have to replace me, Catra. You never could. But you need to breathe. Just… let someone else in. A little. Let them see the light we chased in these south-facing windows.'*

Catra burrows deeper into the jersey, the worn fabric a tangible connection to the past. But the phantom warmth of Perfuma's hand on hers lingers as well, a confusing, present anchor.

She reaches for her Switch, the blue glow illuminating the bedside table. She navigates past the cottage, past the beach café, directly to the mailbox.

To: Adora

Subject: (no subject)

told her about you.

the pancakes. the aneurysm. the silence.

she cried. i didn’t. mostly.

~~she held my hand.~~

it doesn’t hurt *as much* today.

Lying in bed later, Catra’s eyes trace the familiar crack in the ceiling–her nightly constellation. For the first time in almost two thousand sunsets, she doesn’t just think it. She whispers it aloud, the words feather-light yet solid in the quiet dark:

“I’m still here.”

Somewhere in the city, rain is still falling, and a duck named Waddles quacks in the downpour. Somewhere, on a pixelated island, a cactus blooms unseen.

The night stretches on, and the silence feels less like a void, and more like… space. Space that holds memory, holds pain, but also, tentatively, held breath. And the promise of morning.

Chapter 7: Altar of Truths

The sharp, almost cloying scent of lavender fills the cramped stockroom, thick enough to taste.

Perfuma stands hunched over a crate, shoving sprigs into glass jars with trembling, frantic hands. Tears stream down her cheeks, silent but relentless, dripping onto the purple buds, making them glisten unnaturally.

The image of Catra's face on the park bench–raw, etched with a grief so profound it seemed carved into her bones, yet fiercely vulnerable as she spoke of Adora, her voice hollow with a grief that threatened to obliterate her–plays on a loop behind Perfuma's eyes. The trust bestowed feels like a fragile, priceless artifact she's terrified of dropping.

The door creaks open, and light floods the small space. It's momentarily blocked by Scorpia's broad frame as she steps inside, taking in the scene instantly

Oh, sweetpea," Scorpia murmurs, her voice soft as down. In two strides, she is across the room, wrapping Perfuma in a fierce, all-encompassing bear hug, her strong arms pulling her away from the scattered lavender

Perfuma crumples against Scorpia's sturdy shoulder, a sob finally wrenching free.

"She's so *lonely*, Scorpia," she chokes out, the words muffled against the soft cotton of her friend's shirt. "Five years. Trapped in that apartment with nothing but ghosts and pain. She *trusted* me today. Told me about her wife. Adora. How she died."
Another sob shakes her. "It was… devastating. Beautiful and devastating. But I'm… I'm scared. What if I move too fast? What if I say the wrong thing? What if she just…?" Her voice hitches, the fear too vast to articulate fully.

“Disappears?” Scorpia finishes softly, the smooth, cool curve of one large pincer coming up to gently smooth Perfuma’s frizzy braid with infinite care. “I know. I know. Your heart… it’s too big for your own good sometimes. It wants to fix everything, right now.”

She holds Perfuma tighter, her strong arms a haven. “But you can’t fix this. Not like that.”

Perfuma pulls back slightly, looking up at Scorpia, her hazel eyes wide and pleading, red-rimmed. “What do I *do*?” It’s a whisper, lost and desperate.

Scorpia’s expression softens. With a tenderness that belies their size and strength, she brings the broad, flat side of one pincer to rest against Perfuma’s cheek. It’s not a human hand’s cup, but a firm, steady pressure—a grounding touch. Her dark eyes are earnest and steady. “You keep watering the seed,” she says, her voice firm with conviction.

“Remember the orchid you have at the front counter here? The one everyone said was a lost cause? You didn’t yank it into the blazing sun. You didn’t drown it. You just… gave it water when it needed it. Kept it in the right light. Patient.”

With careful precision, she uses the very tip of her pincer to catch a falling tear on Perfuma’s cheek, blotting it away with a delicate touch. “No forcing. No rushing. Just… let it grow. In its own time. However it needs to.”

Perfuma sniffles, searching Scorpia’s face for reassurance. “What if it doesn’t?” The fear of failure, of the fragile connection withering, is palpable. “What if the roots are too damaged? What if the soil… the grief… is too toxic?”

Scorpia’s smile is sad but unwavering. She pulls Perfuma back into the hug, resting her chin on top of her golden head.

“Then,” she murmurs, her voice thick with empathy, “you loved it anyway. You gave it the best chance you could. That’s never

wasted. Never."

She holds her friend as the quiet sobs gradually subside, the scent of lavender and tears mingling in the small, safe space.

The park bench overlooking the duck pond ceases to be just a place to sit. It becomes an altar.

Catra arrives without her usual armor. Her defensive hunch is gone, her shoulders soft instead of braced for impact. Her claws remain sheathed, tucked away. Her hands rest empty on her lap or curled loosely around the familiar worn handle of her cane.

Words, raw and unfiltered, become the offerings laid bare between them.

One afternoon, sunlight dappling through the new leaves, Catra stares not at the water, but at her own hands resting on the cane. The knuckles are swollen, the joints stiff, a stark contrast to the memory surfacing.

A ghost of a smirk touches her lips. "Adora was… all muscle," she begins, her voice a low rasp. "Total meathead. Seriously. Could've bench-pressed a car."

The smirk fades, replaced by a distant look. "Watching her hands work… that was something. Planing a door until it shut without a sound, wrestling with a stubborn lug nut, hoisting weights at the gym… I loved it. Thick knuckles. Callouses like sandpaper. Veins standing out like a river delta under her skin when she really gripped something."

Her own hand flexes slowly, painfully, on the cane. "Strong hands."

Her voice drops, roughened by memory. "On bad days… the days I felt like shattered glass inside, every piece grinding, when I couldn't breathe… she'd make me lie down. And those hands…"

Catra trails off, her ears giving a faint, involuntary twitch, as if feeling the phantom touch. "Strong enough to wrench pipes or lift ridiculous weights… but on me?" She swallows. "Gentle. So fucking gentle. Knew exactly where to press. Shoulders… lower back… right *here*." One of her own hands flies to a spot, pressing hard against her hip, as if to recreate the pressure.

"Didn't talk. Didn't ask a million questions. Just… knew where it hurt. Knew how deep. Held the pieces of me together with those hands." Her voice drops to a whisper. "Until I could breathe again."

Perfuma had set down her trowel early in the monologue. Now, she sits utterly still, her gaze fixed on Catra's profile, absorbing the weight of the confession. "She just…" Perfuma breathes, awe softening her voice. "… knew your body like that? The map of your pain?"

Catra nods once, a sharp, almost defensive movement. "Yeah. Said my ears pinned down a certain way when the pain was really bad. And my tail… she knew the massage was working when the tension right at the base began to relax, when the tip stopped twitching and lay still."

A pause stretches, heavy with the intimacy of the revelation. It was a testament to a profound, wordless understanding forged in the crucible of chronic pain and fierce love.

A mallard paddles by, its wake rippling the water's surface, momentarily distorting the reflection of Perfuma's face–soft, intent, bearing silent witness.

"You felt safe," Perfuma murmurs. It isn't a question. "Small. Fragile. But… held. Protected."

The words hang in the still air, over the quiet pond.

Catra's claws flex slightly against the cane's handle. The phantom weight of Adora's hands feels suddenly, achingly real. A grounding force. A shield.

“Yeah,” she rasps, the single syllable scraping her throat. “Felt like… nothing could break me when she had those strong hands on me."

Perfuma simply nods. She understands the juxtaposition–the athlete's formidable power wielded with the precision and tenderness of a healer.

She picks up her trowel, not to resume work, but to hold it, an anchor in the emotional current.

The silence that descends is thick with the echo of muscle and tenderness, heavy with the ghost of those anchoring hands, but not oppressive.

It holds the space Adora had once filled, a space Catra has just bravely mapped out loud.

Days later, they find themselves under the broad, graceful boughs of an ancient oak, a patch of soft clover their chosen ground. Perfuma kneels, carefully easing seedlings from their plastic trays, her movements deliberate.

Catra sits nearby on the folded blanket, her posture held in a rigid, calculated line against the lingering ache in her hip. A silent countdown ticks off in her head: *twelve minutes left*.

Her limit is fifteen. Fifteen minutes before the stiffness locks in, before the pain becomes sharp and consequential.

Her tail gives a sharp, involuntary flick—not quite restless energy, but a system reading its own escalating distress signals.

“People think I’m weak,” Perfuma says abruptly, her voice low, focused intently on loosening a root ball. She doesn’t look up. “Or naïve. A pushover.”

She brushes dirt from her knee with a sharp, frustrated motion. “‘Oh, Perfuma,’” she mimics, her voice adopting a saccharine,

patronizing tone, "'always seeing the good in everyone! So trusting. So *soft*.'"

The mimicry drops, replaced by a raw edge. "As if caring deeply is a character flaw. As if wanting connection… *needing* it… makes me fragile. Less than. Like I'm not strong because I don't build walls."

Catra watches the careful press of Perfuma's palms into the cool earth, the tenderness with which she cradles the fragile roots of a lupine seedling.

It looks like a different kind of strength, a quiet, persistent force.

"They're wrong," Catra states, the conviction in her own voice surprising her. It feels like an echo of Perfuma's own unwavering kindness thrown back at the world.

Perfuma's laugh is thin, brittle, devoid of humor. "Easy for you to say." She finally looks up, her hazel eyes meeting Catra's. Catra sees it then–a flicker of old, deep-seated hurt beneath the usual warmth. A vulnerability laid bare.

"People admire the flowers, they like the 'vibe' of the café, but they don't get it. It's not just… aesthetics. It's survival. For me."

She looks down at her soil-stained hands, the tools of her purpose. "Being around people, helping things grow… nurturing life, connection… it's *air*, Catra. Without it…" She trails off, her voice catching.

"Without it, I start to wilt. Feel… invisible. Like I'm not solid. Like I'm fading."

The words paint a picture of dissolution Catra understands in her very bones. That feeling of disappearing, of being insubstantial and unseen—it's a ghost that has haunted her own steps for years.

To hear Perfuma, this solid, sun-warmed pillar of life, give voice to that same spectral fear was unbearable. It *could not* stand. It was wrong.

"No." The word cracks out, sharp and definitive, surprising them both. Catra's ears flatten momentarily, then pricked forward again. She holds Perfuma's gaze, refusing to let her look away.

"You're not weak." She searches for the right words, clumsy but earnest. "You're… brave. Stubborn. In a good way." She gestures vaguely, encompassing the seedlings, the park, the unseen café.

"The world's full of people who quit. Who shut down. Who build walls so high they starve behind them. You?" Catra's gaze sweeps over Perfuma's kneeling form, her dirty hands.

"You walk right up to the cracks. You plant gardens in them. You seek connection. Even when it's hard. Even when people mock it. *That's* not weakness. That's…"

She falters, the intensity of her own declaration startling her. "Courage."

Perfuma stills completely, the small lupine seedling forgotten in her fingers. She stares at Catra, her eyes wide, shock warring with a dawning, profound relief.

A faint, tremulous, but utterly real smile touches her lips. Tears well, not of sadness, but of overwhelming validation. "Me?" she breathes, the word a fragile, disbelieving thing. "You think… I'm courageous?"

Catra looks away abruptly, heat rising in her cheeks. She focuses with intense concentration on a ladybug making its laborious way up a blade of clover.

"It's how you *are*," she mutters, the gruffness failing to mask the sincerity of the admission. The words hang in the dappled shade, a fragile but undeniable truth offered across the clover.

Adora’s ghost shimmers at the edges of their deepening connection, a silent, encouraging presence only Catra perceives. She hovers near the pond’s edge as they gather scattered trowels and trays, her voice a soft echo in Catra’s mind.

'Ask her,' she murmurs when Catra lingers too long at the park gate, watching Perfuma’s retreating figure walk towards the café. *'Invite her in.'*

The suggestion sends jolts of pure panic through Catra. *In*. Into the sanctuary, the shrine, the suffocating silence of the apartment. Into the heart of her grief, where Adora’s absence is a physical presence. It feels like a desecration. A terrifying surrender.

Catra waits. She waits through days of bright sun and blustery wind. She waits until the sky, which had been a clear blue just an hour before, darkens ominously from the west.

The first cold drops fall, sparse and heavy, a prelude to the deluge. They had been repotting a final flat of seedlings, the work too absorbing to notice the approaching clouds.

Now, a cold, relentless rain sweeps in, drops pelting the surface of the pond like flung pebbles, turning the path to slick mud.

They scramble for cover, huddling under the inadequate shelter of the maple tree, the air thick with the petrichor scent of wet earth and the metallic tang of ozone. The drumming rain creates a cocoon of sound.

“You could…” Catra says abruptly, her voice tight, almost lost in the downpour’s roar. She stares straight ahead, not at Perfuma, her knuckles white on the cane’s handle. “…Come over. If you want.”

She braces herself for hesitation, for polite deflection, for the crushing weight of pity.

Perfuma turns towards her slowly. Rainwater streams down her braid, plastering loose strands to her temples and neck. Her expression is unreadable for a moment, searching Catra's averted face.

Then it softens into something incredibly tender, cautious, and profoundly touched. Her voice, when it comes, is low but clear, cutting through the noise of the storm with an intimate precision.

"Are you sure?" she asks, the words carrying no judgment, only a quiet readiness.

"No." Catra's throat constricts painfully. The vulnerability is a yawning chasm. "But…" She swallows hard, forcing the words past the lump of terror and hope. "Adora would've liked you."

The admission hangs between them, heavy as the rain-laden air, saturated with Adora's absence and Catra's monumental gesture of trust. It was the highest compliment, the deepest offering she could make.

Perfuma's eyes widen, then shimmer unmistakably, welling with tears that mingle with the rain on her cheeks.

The simple acknowledgment of Adora's potential approval, the validation from the woman Catra had loved so fiercely, strikes deep. Her lips part slightly.

"When?" she breathes, the word full of quiet awe.

"Saturday. Noon." Catra's claws dig into the soft wood of her cane grip, anchoring herself against the vertigo of the invitation.

A pause. Perfuma nods, a slow, deliberate movement, her gaze never leaving Catra's face. Then, softer, gentler, infused with a warmth that defies the chill rain: "I'll bring tea."

Friday night dissolves into a blur of anxious, restless energy. Catra prowls the apartment, her movements a stiff and jerky

counterpoint to the silent, suffocating dread.

She dusts the bookshelf, her fingers tracing the spines of Adora's worn thrillers on the shelf—the ones she'd read aloud during countless bad pain days—before stopping to straighten the framed photo of their grinning faces, forever frozen in time.

But she leaves Adora's faded softball jersey untouched, a sacred relic perpetually draped over the back of the armchair—a tangible, comforting weight she couldn't bear to move.

Her gaze falls on the bare space beside the worn couch. Too empty. Too sterile. Too revealing of the hollowed-out space Adora had left.

An impulse, sharp and defensive, strikes her. She shuffles to the small, sunniest window in the kitchen where a few resilient succulents clung to life, enduring her sporadic care.

She selects the prickliest cactus–a small, spherical barrel cactus covered in fierce, unyielding golden spines. She carries it carefully, its weight insignificant but its presence potent, setting it on the low table beside the couch.

A piece of her own current landscape, thorny and defensive, placed deliberately within the space Adora had once filled. A declaration: *This is me now. Handle me with care.*

Adora's ghost drifts closer, her translucent form hovering near the new addition. She traces a spectral finger over one of the sharp spines, a hint of a knowing smile playing on her lips.

'She'll understand,' she murmurs, her voice a soft chime in Catra's mind. *'The thorns. The persistence. The need to protect the softness inside.'*

"Don't care if she does," Catra lies, turning away sharply. But her reflection in the rain-streaked window looks fractured, uncertain, eyes wide with a terror that belied her words.

She powers on her Switch, the cheerful jingle jarring in the tense silence. The mailbox icon seems to pulse. She navigates to it, the cursor blinking accusingly in the blank field.

To: Adora

Subject: (no subject)

she’s coming here.

tomorrow. noon.

to where we lived. where you lived.

to where i barely live.

i’m terrified.

what if she sees too much?

the dust? the cracks?

the way your jacket still hangs by the door?

~~what if she stays?~~

she’s bringing tea.

Saturday arrives draped in a blanket of low, grey clouds, a persistent drizzle misting the air. Catra wears her least-frayed sweatpants and makes a cursory attempt to smooth the worst of the tangles from her fur.

The apartment feels like a museum exhibit suddenly expecting a critic–simultaneously too cluttered with the artifacts of a lost life and echoing with a cavernous emptiness.

She paces until her hip joint shrieks in protest, then forces herself to perch rigidly on the very edge of the couch, facing the door like

a sentinel awaiting an unknown force. The cactus stands guard beside her, spines gleaming dully in the grey light.

The knock, when it comes, is soft. Respectful, but resolute. It reverberates through Catra's bones. Her heart hammers against her ribs, a frantic bird trapped in a cage of fear and fragile hope.

She levers herself up with her cane, every joint protesting the movement, the sheer weight of vulnerability.

She opens the door.

Perfuma stands on the threshold, haloed by the diffused, overcast light. Her hair is down, slightly damp from the drizzle, framing her face in loose waves.

She's wearing simple, clean dark linen trousers and a soft-looking cream sweater that seems to glow against the grey. She holds a sturdy-looking thermos and a small, clear glass jar filled with golden honey that catches the meager light.

Her smile is warm, tentative, her hazel eyes searching Catra's face, holding a question and an ocean of gentle understanding.

Catra hovers, blocking the doorway for a long, breathless moment, her spine prickling with the terrifying vulnerability of allowing someone to cross this sacred, haunted threshold.

Perfuma doesn't push. Doesn't fill the silence with platitudes. She simply waits, her presence steady, her gaze patient and kind.

Finally, muscles screaming with tension, Catra steps aside, gesturing stiffly with her cane.

Perfuma steps over the threshold. Her eyes sweep the room–taking in the meticulously dusted bookshelf, the framed photo, the faded jersey draped over the armchair–with a quiet, palpable respect. Then her gaze lands on the cactus on the low table.

“Oh,” she breathes, her voice soft with genuine appreciation. A small, warm smile blossoms on her face. “I love that.”

Catra braces herself for misunderstanding, for a flippant comment. “It’s… low maintenance,” she rasps, the defensive explanation tumbling out.

Perfuma’s smile deepens, reaching her eyes, crinkling the corners. She meets Catra’s guarded gaze directly. “Suits you,” she says simply. No judgment. No pity. Just an observation that holds profound acceptance, acknowledging the thorns and the resilience beneath.

The iron band of tension around Catra’s chest eases, fractionally. Perfuma holds up the thermos and honey. “Chamomile and ginger,” she offers. “Good for… well, nerves. Among other things.” A small, hopeful shrug. “And local honey. If you like it sweet.”

Catra nods, the simple act of speech momentarily beyond her. She gestures towards the couch. Perfuma moves carefully, settling herself on the opposite end, leaving a respectful, intentional space between them.

She unscrews the thermos cap, a cloud of steam and the warm, spicy, comforting scent of ginger and chamomile blossoming in the room, mingling with the ever-present dust and the faint, lingering ghost of coconut shampoo.

Catra lowers herself stiffly onto the couch beside her, the cactus a small, spiky landmark on the table within reach. She stares straight ahead at the rain-streaked window, her claws retracted, hands resting awkwardly on her knees.

Outside, the rain whispers its steady rhythm against the glass. Inside, the silence stretches, vast and new.

But it isn’t the heavy, suffocating silence Catra knows so well. It’s different. Lighter. Charged, yes, with nerves and the immense weight of shared and unshared history, but also… open.

She doesn’t look at Perfuma, but she feels her presence beside her, solid and calm. Not an intrusion. Not a replacement. A new presence.

The apartment, saturated with Adora’s memory and Catra’s accumulated pain, doesn’t feel smaller. For the first time in five years, Catra feels the space around her… *breathe*.

She takes a shallow, shaky breath, matching the rhythm. The rain falls. The tea steams.

And Catra, perched on the precipice of an uncharted connection, simply exists in the fragile, terrifying, fertile space of possibility.

Chapter 8: The Space Between

Chapter Notes

> i wanted to have this up earlier this morning but my own aide showed up unexpectedly for a shower. but now i'm a clean author!
>
> this chapter LONG. i considered splitting it, but nowhere felt right. Enjoy! let me know what you felt reading this chapter in the comments

The click of the door echoes in the sudden quiet. Catra hovers near the entranceway, the worn wooden handle of her cane slick under her sweating palm.

Perfuma stands just inside, holding the thermos of tea and jar of honey like offerings. Her gaze sweeps the room with a gentle curiosity that feels simultaneously respectful and intensely invasive.

It lingers on the faded softball jersey draped over the armchair—a relic worn thin at the elbows—then drifts to the framed photo on the bookshelf, its moment of wild, carefree joy forever frozen.

Catra doesn’t need to follow her eyes to know what she sees. Adora is *everywhere*. Even in the south-facing windows she’d chosen for the light—for Catra’s art—now mostly shuttered and closed off against the world.

Yet a stubborn sliver of light cuts through a gap, illuminating dust motes dancing in the hollow space she’d left behind. The apartment isn't just a place; it's a museum of absence, curated by grief.

Perfuma’s gaze drifts to that sliver of light. “It’s a lovely space,” she says softly. “You get beautiful light in here.”

Catra grunts, shifting her weight to alleviate the familiar ache blooming in her left hip. "Yeah. Adora picked it." She gestures stiffly towards the couch. "Sit. I'll… get mugs."

The walk to the kitchen feels longer than usual, her cane tapping a nervous rhythm on the hardwood.

She's acutely aware of Perfuma settling onto the couch, her movements careful, taking in the cactus on the side table, the piles of medical supplies discreetly tucked into a woven basket, the faint scent of dust and loneliness beneath the ghost of Adora's coconut shampoo.

Catra returns with two mugs, lowering herself gingerly onto the opposite end of the couch, a careful foot of space between them. Perfuma reaches for the thermos, busying herself with pouring the fragrant tea–chamomile and ginger–into the waiting cups.

The silence isn't exactly uncomfortable, but it's thick, charged with the unspoken history crowding the room. Catra focuses on the warmth of the mug against her palms, the slight tremor in her hands hidden by the ceramic.

"Your cactus is thriving," Perfuma offers, nodding towards the spiky plant. "Good light here."

"Yeah. Doesn't need much. Just… exists." *Like me,* Catra doesn't add.

The steam curling from their mugs paints fragile shapes in the thin late-afternoon light that slants through the gaps in the curtains.

Catra grips her tea, the ceramic warm against her palms, a stark contrast to the cool, nervous sweat on her skin where she clutches the handle of her cane propped beside her.

Perfuma sits on the opposite end of the couch, her posture relaxed but her gaze observant, gently taking in the room–the

worn jersey, the dusty protein powder tub, the framed photo of two grinning faces forever frozen in time.

The sheer *volume* of Adora, the life lived and abruptly halted, presses in on Catra. Her life, her grief, her stagnation–it's all laid bare.

Perfuma takes a delicate sip of her tea. Her eyes drift back to the photo. "She had a wonderful smile. Adora."

Catra's claws flex against the mug. "Yeah." The word is gravelly.

The silence stretches, and Perfuma's quiet presence, her obvious respect for the space filled with ghosts, nudges at something rusty inside Catra. A forgotten social reflex.

Ask about her. It's… polite?

The thought feels alien, like trying to remember how to use a muscle long atrophied. She clears her throat, the sound harsh in the quiet room.

"You…" she starts, then faltered, her ears twitching self-consciously.

She can't meet Perfuma's eyes, focusing instead on a loose thread on the knee of her sweatpants. "You run the café. With Scorpia." It isn't a question, more a statement flung out as an awkward opener.

Perfuma smiles, a warm, patient expression. "I do. Scorpia's the powerhouse behind the logistics and spreadsheets. I handle the customers, the baking, the plants, the coffee. Though sometimes you'll see Scorpia working the espresso machine too."

She takes another sip. "We make a good team."

Catra nods stiffly. Silence threatens again. She wrestles with it. "Scorpia seems…" *Loud? Enthusiastic? Like a walking hug?* "...steady." She finally lands on.

Perfuma chuckles. "That she is. A rock. We met years ago, actually. Back in college."

College. The word is a hook. Catra grasps it, surprised at her own faint curiosity overriding the awkwardness. "You studied…?" She trails off, leaving the question dangling, hoping Perfuma will fill the gap. Her knuckles are white on the cane handle.

"Botany," Perfuma supplies easily. "I wanted to save the rainforests, one endangered fern at a time." A wistful smile touches her lips. "I loved it. The complexity, the quiet resilience of plants. How they communicate, adapt… survive."

Catra makes a noncommittal sound in her throat, but she's listening. Plants. Quiet resilience. It fits the woman sitting across from her, radiating a calm strength.

"Why'd you switch?" The question comes out terser than she intended, almost accusatory. She winces internally.

Perfuma doesn't seem offended. She traces the rim of her mug. "I got my dream job. Field research assistant in the Whispering Woods preserve. Ecologically important, beautiful… and incredibly isolating."

Her voice softens. "Months spent cataloging moss varieties in near silence, surrounded by breathtaking life, yet feeling utterly… disconnected. From people. From… warmth."

She looks up, meeting Catra's gaze briefly. "Plants don't judge, but they don't laugh either. They don't share a cup of tea after a hard day."

Catra holds her breath. The image of Perfuma alone in a vast, silent forest resonated with a chilling familiarity. Five years in an apartment tomb.

"I burned out," Perfuma continues, her voice matter-of-fact but carrying an undercurrent of remembered pain. "Hard. Came back to the city feeling lost. Like I'd failed the thing I loved most."

She pauses, a flicker of gratitude warming her expression. "That's when Scorpia found me. We'd dated for a while in college–sweet, but we both knew it wasn't… forever. We just fit better as friends."

Perfuma smiles fully now. "She saw how adrift I was. How lonely, even surrounded by greenery. And she had this wild idea…"

Catra leans forward slightly, forgetting her nerves for a moment. "The café?"

Perfuma nods. "She knew I needed more human connection than I was getting, trapped in data sheets and silent forests. She needed… well, she needed someone to stop her from buying industrial-sized vats of caramel syrup on impulse." Perfuma's laugh is light.

"But seriously, she understood. I love plants, Catra. Deeply. But I love people, too. Their stories, their chaos, the way they come together over coffee and pastries." She gestures vaguely towards the window, towards the city beyond.

"The café… it lets me nurture both. Grow herbs in the window boxes, arrange flowers for the tables, *and* see the regulars smile when they get their usual order. It's messy, loud sometimes, exhausting… but it's full of *life*."

Catra absorbs this. The burnout. The isolation. The pivot towards connection, guided by a steadfast friend. It isn't her story, but the threads of loneliness and seeking solace feel… recognizable. Different paths, similar terrain.

Her grip on the cane handle loosens, just a fraction. The tightness in her chest, born of nerves, eases slightly. Perfuma isn't just sunshine and flowers; she has depths, shadows she's navigated.

The silence that followed isn't heavy. It's contemplative. Catra stares into her cooling tea. The urge to retreat back into the familiar shell of her own grief is still there, but it feels less… necessary.

Perfuma had shared a piece of herself, a vulnerability that mirrored Catra's own fortress of solitude, even if built from different materials.

And somehow, that shared understanding of hidden struggles, of paths rerouted, makes the space feel safer.

The relics of Adora around the room don't feel like exhibits under scrutiny anymore, but simply… part of the landscape Perfuma is respectfully navigating.

The weight of displaying her life lessens. The rusty gears of conversation have creaked into motion, and for the first time in years, talking to someone new doesn't feel like scaling a cliff face. It feels… possible.

And strangely, the path forward seems to lead naturally back to Adora, not as a shield, but because she *wants* to share her memories of Adora with this woman who understands about loving something deeply, even when it changes form.

She takes a slow breath, the scent of chamomile and ginger mingling with the faint, comforting ghost of coconut shampoo. The words feel ready to spill out, lighter now, shared across the space between them.

Perfuma takes a slow sip of tea. "What was she like? Adora."

Catra's claws tighten around the mug handle. "Stubborn," she rasps. "Hopelessly optimistic. A disaster in the kitchen. Burned toast like it was her job." The words come out sharper than intended, a defensive reflex.

Perfuma smiles, undeterred. "But she tried?"

"Every damn Saturday. Pancakes. Always chocolate chip. Always burned the first batch." A flicker of memory–smoke alarm blaring, Adora waving a towel frantically, laughing despite the charred mess.

"She'd just… laugh. Like setting off the smoke detector was the funniest thing in the world." Catra stares into her tea. "Had this ridiculous laugh. Loud. Like a… like a donkey braying."

The description is harsh, but Catra's voice holds no malice, only a raw ache.

Perfuma chuckles softly. "Sounds infectious."

"It was." Catra swallows. "Annoying. But… yeah. Infectious." She takes a shaky breath. Talking about Adora feels like picking at a scab, painful but somehow necessary.

"She ran. Every morning. Rain or shine. Said it cleared her head." Catra's gaze fixes on some distant point in the past.

"Used to drag me out sometimes. Before… before my body gave out, when I could still handle sitting in the car for thirty minutes. To the gorge."

"The gorge?" Perfuma prompts softly.

"Big canyon outside the city. Windy. Loud. We'd…" Catra hesitates, the memory sharp. "After bad doctor appointments. Hospitals. She'd drive us there. Let me scream."

She remembers the raw scrape in her throat, the way the wind snatched the sound, the solid warmth of Adora's arm around her shoulders afterward.

"She said pain deserved a witness. That silence just… lets it fester."

Perfuma's eyes are wide, empathetic. "That's… incredibly wise. And kind."

Catra shrugs, the movement stiff. "Just Adora." She traces the rim of her mug. "She hated hospitals. Hated seeing me hurt. But she never flinched. Not once." The dam is cracking. The words, dammed up for so long, start to seep through.

"She learned how to tape my knees. Made braces out of ACE bandages when we couldn’t afford the real ones. Carried me up three flights of stairs when our elevator broke."

A brittle laugh escapes her. "Nearly dropped me twice. Called herself 'Princess Carry'." She mimics Adora’s ridiculous, overly-deep 'hero' voice: "'Fear not, fair maiden!'"

Perfuma laughs, a bright, surprised sound. "Oh my god."

Catra finds herself grinning, a real, unguarded expression that feels foreign on her face. "Total dork. The *biggest* dork."

She launches into the story of the collapsed fence–Catra, seventeen and reckless, trying to scale it on a dare, her shoulder dislocating mid-climb.

Adora, panicking but determined, hauling her down, tearing her favorite shirt on a nail, getting a scar on her brow from the falling debris.

"Blood dripping down her face, and she’s just yelling, 'Are your claws okay?! Don’t scratch the fence, you’ll get tetanus!' Like *that's* the priority!"

Catra finishes the story, her chest heaving slightly, not from pain, but from laughter. A genuine, unburdened laugh that bubbles up from some long-sealed place inside her. It startles her, cutting off abruptly.

She stares at Perfuma, wide-eyed, her ears flattening slightly in surprise at the sound of her own joy.

Perfuma is beaming, her eyes suspiciously bright. "She sounds…" she searches for the word, her voice thick with emotion, "...like a really special person, Catra."

The words land softly, but they pierce the fragile bubble of levity. Catra’s grin fades. She looked down at her mug, her reflection wavering in the amber liquid.

The weight of Adora’s absence crashes back in, heavier than ever after the brief respite of shared memory.

Five years of silence, five years of carrying the weight alone.

Her throat closes. She nods, once, sharply, her vision blurring.

"She was," she chokes out, the words barely audible, scraped raw with grief.

The silence that follows is profound, filled only by Catra’s ragged breathing as she fights the tears. She feels exposed, raw, the carefully constructed walls around her grief crumbling under the weight of shared remembrance.

Perfuma doesn’t speak. She simply shifts slightly on the couch, turning fully towards Catra. Her expression is open, filled with a compassion that isn’t pity, but deep understanding. Slowly, deliberately, she opens her arms, a silent invitation.

Catra freezes. Physical contact beyond the necessary clinical touch of Mara or her doctors is alien territory. A hug? It feels monumental, terrifying. Her instinct screams to recoil, to build the walls back up instantly.

But Adora’s voice whispers in her ear, clearer than it had been in weeks: *'She’s safe. Let her in.'*

A sob rips from Catra’s chest, harsh and involuntary. The dam shatters. All the loneliness, the pain, the bone-deep yearning crashes over her.

With a sound like a wounded animal, she crumples forward, falling into Perfuma’s waiting arms. She buries her face against Perfuma’s shoulder, the soft linen of her tunic absorbing the torrent of tears.

Perfuma holds her without hesitation, her arms wrapping firmly yet gently around Catra’s trembling frame. One hand cradles the back of Catra’s head, fingers sinking gently into the thick fur

behind her ears. The other rubs slow, soothing circles on her back, carefully avoiding the tense, knotted muscles she can feel.

"Shhhh," Perfuma murmurs, her voice a soft vibration against Catra's temple. "It's okay. Let it out. Just let it out. I've got you. You're safe. Shhh…"

The words are a lifeline. Catra clings to Perfuma, her claws retracted but fists bunching in the fabric of her tunic. The sobs rack her body, years of suppressed grief pouring out in a relentless flood.

"I miss her," she wails, the words muffled and broken. "I miss her so much, Perfuma. Every day. It never stops. It *hurts*."

Her voice raises, ragged with despair. "Five years… and I'm still not okay. I don't think I ever *will* be okay. It's like… like half of me is just… gone. Cut out."

She gasps for air, the ache in her chest so profound it felt physical. "I can't… I can't breathe without her sometimes."

Perfuma holds her tighter, her own tears dampening Catra's fur. "I know, sweetheart. I know it hurts. It's an ocean of hurt. You've been carrying it all alone. So brave… for so long. Carrying so much."

Her hand continues its gentle stroking. "But you're not alone anymore."

Catra cries until her throat is raw and her body trembles with exhaustion, the deep, heaving sobs gradually subsiding into shuddering breaths and quiet sniffles.

Perfuma never stops her soothing motions, her murmurs of comfort a steady anchor.

When Catra finally pulls back slightly, her face is a mess of damp fur and tear tracks, her eyes swollen. She can't meet Perfuma's

gaze, staring instead at her hands still clutching Perfuma’s tunic. Embarrassment wars with profound relief.

"You were so brave today, Catra," Perfuma whispers, gently brushing a stray lock of hair from Catra’s cheek.

"Inviting me here… into this space that’s so full of her. Sharing those memories… letting me see her through your eyes. That took incredible courage after carrying it all inside for so long."

Catra sniffles, wiping clumsily at her face with the back of her hand.

"Adora…" she starts, her voice thick and hoarse. "She… she would’ve told me to do it." She takes a shaky breath, finally daring to glance up at Perfuma.

"Sometimes… I just *know* what she’d say. I can see her next to me. Hear her voice. Sometimes I can almost feel her warmth."

She looks towards the empty space beside her on the couch. Adora’s ghost sits there, translucent but vivid, a soft smile on her face, her blue eyes warm. *'You did good.'*

Catra looks back at Perfuma. "She’d tell me to invite you over. She’d tell me you’re safe. And…" Catra’s voice cracks. "She’d tell me I don’t need to forget her… but I *do* need to let someone in."

A fresh tear escapes. "Because she… wants to see me happy. And cared for."

Perfuma’s breath hitches. She looks from Catra’s tear-streaked face to the space beside her, though she sees only empty air.

The depth of Catra’s love, the way Adora is still a living, guiding presence in her life… it’s overwhelming. It speaks of a bond so fierce, so deep, that not even death can sever its core.

Adora’s love was so immense, so selfless, that it actively urges Catra towards life, towards connection, even beyond the grave.

The thought takes Perfuma’s breath away.

"I…" Perfuma trails off, voice thick with tears. She gathers herself, then speaks softly, but with conviction, directing her words towards the space beside Catra as much as to Catra herself. "Thank you, Adora. For trusting me. For trusting me with her."

She looks back at Catra, her hazel eyes shimmering. "Catra is a very special woman. Fierce and funny and… and so strong, even when she doesn’t feel it. I’m honored to have the chance to know her. To care about her. Truly."

Adora’s ghost shimmers. She leans forward, her translucent hand hovering just beside Perfuma’s where it rested on Catra’s arm. *'Tell her,'* she whispers, her voice a soft echo only Catra can hear. *'Tell her I’m proud. Proud of you both.'*

Catra manages a small, watery, sniffle-laugh. “She’d be… proud of me for letting you in." She pauses, looking at Perfuma. "And… I think proud of you too. For… being here."

Perfuma can’t hold back her own tears. They spill over, tracing paths down her cheeks as she squeezes Catra’s arm gently.

A profound, comfortable silence descends. The late afternoon sun slants lower, painting golden stripes across the floor, illuminating the dust motes dancing around Adora’s jersey.

The shared grief, the raw vulnerability, the tentative new connection–it hangs in the air, heavy but not oppressive. It feels like the quiet after a storm, the air washed clean.

Catra leans back against the couch cushions, utterly drained. The emotional outpouring has left her feeling hollowed out and fragile, her eyelids heavy.

The chronic pain, momentarily eclipsed by the emotional tempest, reasserts itself with a dull throb in her hips and shoulders.

Perfuma seems to sense her exhaustion. She gives Catra's arm one last gentle squeeze before carefully disentangling herself and standing up.

"I should let you rest," she says softly, her voice still thick with emotion. "Thank you, Catra. Truly. For having me. For sharing Adora with me. It… meant a lot."

Catra nods, unable to muster words. She watches as Perfuma gathered her thermos and the now-empty honey jar. At the door, Perfuma pauses, looking back. "Saturday? Usual time at the café? Or… the park bench?"

Catra manages a faint nod. "Café's… closer."

Perfuma smiles, warm and genuine despite her tear-streaked face. "Okay. See you then." She slips out, closing the door softly behind her.

Catra sits in the sudden silence, the echo of her own sobs and Perfuma's comforting words still ringing in her ears. The apartment felt different. Not empty of Adora, but… perhaps less suffocatingly full of grief.

Adora's ghost gives her a soft, encouraging smile before fading slowly, like mist in the sunlight.

Perfuma walks home through the crisp evening air, the streetlights flickering on as dusk deepened. The city sounds–distant traffic, a barking dog, the murmur of conversations from open windows–seem sharper, more present.

The weight of Catra's grief, the raw power of her love for Adora, the incredible trust she'd placed in Perfuma… it settles around her like a mantle. Heavy, but not burdensome. Sacred.

She feels something shift inside her, deep in her chest. A subtle realignment, like a root finding purchase in new soil.

The careful distance she maintains with customers, the way she’s learned to protect her own soft heart after her burnout and the gentle ending with Scorpia… it feels less like necessary armor and more like… a habit.

Holding Catra as she shattered, witnessing the enduring power of Adora’s love even in death, hearing Adora’s ghostly encouragement through Catra’s words… it cracks something open in Perfuma too.

Gratitude, profound respect, and a fierce, protective warmth towards the prickly, grieving magicat fills her.

The air feels charged with possibility, fragile and new. She takes a deep breath, inhaling the scent of damp earth and distant rain, feeling a quiet sense of awe settle within her.

Two days later, Mara bustles in with her usual efficiency, medical bag clattering onto the kitchen table. "Alright, Trouble, let’s see how those hips are holding up after your big park expedition last week," she announces, already pulling out fresh linens.

Catra, sitting stiffly at the table nursing her third cup of black coffee, just grunts. She feels… different. Lighter, somehow, despite the persistent ache.

The memory of Perfuma’s arms around her, the release of those pent-up tears, lingers like a physical warmth.

Mara starts stripping the bed, chattering about her own weekend. But Catra notices the sidelong glances, the way Mara’s gaze lingers a fraction too long on her face, the subtle tilt of her head as if assessing.

She changes the sheets with practiced speed, then gatheres supplies for the shower. "Right, bath time. Let’s get you freshened up."

The routine is well-worn, a dance of necessity stripped of shame. Catra leans heavily on Mara and her cane as they navigate the short distance to the bathroom.

She perches on the shower stool, the cold plastic a familiar shock against her skin. Mara turns on the water, adjusting the temperature with the handheld sprayer before starting the methodical process of wetting Catra's fur.

"So," Mara says casually, squeezing floral-scented shampoo onto her palm and working it into the thick fur around Catra's ears. "Anything… interesting happen lately? Besides the thrilling saga of whether Waddles the duck has a new mate?"

Her tone is light, but the curiosity vibrates beneath the surface.

Catra closes her eyes as warm water sluiced away the suds. "Not really," she mumbles, the automatic deflection kicking in.

Mara hums, moving to scrub between Catra's shoulder blades. "Hmm. Must be my imagination then. Could've sworn the air in here felt… less like a tomb this morning. And you only snapped at me twice so far. Practically cheerful."

Catra keeps her eyes closed, focusing on the sensation of the water and Mara's efficient hands. Mara rinses her back and moves lower.

Mara's hands work soap over her legs, her belly, the intimate spaces, before the handheld sprayer rinses it all away with warm water.

Mara's touch is clinical, respectful, focused solely on cleanliness. Catra stares at the familiar cracks in the tiles, counting them as she always does. *Professional. Normal.*

But today, even this routine feels… less weighted. The shame feels distant, muted.

Mara rinses the last of the soap away and turns off the water. She wraps a large, soft towel around Catra and begins the careful process of patting her fur dry.

"You know," she says, her voice softer now, "if you *did* happen to have a visitor the other day… say, a certain sunshine-barista… that would be completely understandable. And frankly, kinda awesome."

Catra sighs, exasperation warring with a flicker of something that might have been… pleasure? She shouldn't have said anything last week. "Mara…"

"I'm just saying!" Mara holds up her hands defensively, a wide grin spreading across her face. "Perfuma sounds like good people. Kind. Patient. Seems to actually *see* you, not just the EDS or the cane or the…" she gestures vaguely at Catra's demeanor.

Catra stands, one hand white-knuckled on Mara's shoulder for balance as she steps into the clean pajama pants Mara holds out. Catra's legs tremble with the effort. "Easy does it. Gotcha."

Once Catra is settled back in the armchair, wrapped in a towel while Mara fetches her sweatshirt, the aide can't contain herself any longer.

She kneels in front of the chair, her expression earnest and excited.

"So? *Did* she come over? Please tell me she came over! Tell me you didn't scare her off with your legendary charm?"

Catra rolls her eyes, but a faint, reluctant smile tugs at her lips. She looks away, focusing on a loose thread on the armrest. "...Yeah. She came over."

Mara's gasp is theatrical. "Catra! That's huge!" She bounces slightly on her knees. "How did it go? Was it weird? Awkward? Did you talk?"

"It was… fine," Catra mutters, the understatement almost comical given the emotional earthquake that had occurred. "We talked. Had tea."

"And?" Mara presses, her eyes shining. "Come on, details! Was she nice about… everything?" She gestures around the room.

Catra hesitates. The memory of sobbing into Perfuma's shoulder, of sharing stories of Adora, of Perfuma speaking to Adora's ghost… it feels too raw, too intimate to share fully.

"She was… respectful. Listened." She pauses, then added quietly, almost grudgingly, "She liked Adora's pancake story."

Mara beams, radiating pure delight. "See? I *knew* it! Oh, Catra, this is so good. Really, really good. You *need* this. Connection. Someone who isn't paid to wash you or therapize you."

She squeezes Catra's knee gently. "I'm really proud of you. That took guts."

"Ugh, stop," Catra grumbles, lifting her arms as much as she can manage. Mara tugs the sweatshirt over her head and down, her movements efficient. It's an intimacy born of necessity, but today, the clinical nature of it feels muted. But she can't quite suppress the warmth that spreads through her chest at Mara's genuine enthusiasm. It feels… validating.

"It was just tea, Mara. Don't make a thing."

"Just tea," Mara repeats, her voice dripping with knowing sarcasm as she stood up, gathering the damp towels. "Right. And the Grand Canyon is just a ditch. I'll see you Thursday. Eat something that isn't coffee, okay?"

She winks and lets herself out, leaving Catra in a silence that feels less empty than before.

That night, clean and dry, her fur soft and fluffy, dressed in fresh, warm PJs with her cane propped faithfully beside her bed, Catra powers on her Switch. The cheerful *Animal Crossing* music fills the quiet room.

She navigates to Adora's cottage. The pixelated structure, nestled among virtual trees, looks peaceful. Three weeds have sprouted near the doorstep. Catra methodically pulls them.

She hesitates, then opens the inventory, selecting a packet of lily seeds–Adora's favorite. She plants three around the cottage, then adds a few purple hyacinths nearby.

The small act of digital gardening feels soothing, a quiet communion.

She opens the in-game mailbox, selecting 'Write Letter'.

To: Adora

Subject: not miserable

hey.

weird day. week. whatever.

i don't feel miserable today. not… actively. it's strange. like background noise turned down low. i'm not used to it. five years… i've wanted to die every single day since you left. every morning, like clockwork.

perfuma was here. a few days ago. felt… weird. letting her in. letting her see the museum of you. your jacket on the chair like you might grab it any minute. that stupid tub of protein powder still hogging the counter. like I froze everything the second you were gone.

for the first time… i wondered if i should… put some of your things away. not get rid of them. just… make room. for more of

me. maybe. but saying that… it feels like betrayal. like i'm erasing you.

you want me to move on, to let someone in. but what if… what if *i* just want to keep living with your memory? what if i don't *want* to let you go? not even to make room for someone who can actually… be here? now?

anyway. perfuma said she wishes she could've met you. properly. i wish you could've met her too. she's… persistent. annoyingly kind. you'd like her.

love you. always.

She hits 'Send'. The little mail icon wings its way into the pixelated sky. Catra shuts off the Switch and the light, settling into the pillows. The apartment is quiet, but the silence feels different. Less absolute. Less like a tomb.

She closes her eyes, exhaustion pulling her under almost immediately.

Catra dreams.

She dreams of things growing. Not in sunlight, but hidden deep within the dark, silent earth.

Seeds buried under layers of cold, packed soil and grief. Roots, thin and tentative at first, pushing blindly downward, seeking purchase. Then, with a surge of impossible determination, a single green shoot. Fragile, pale, but unyielding.

It pushes upwards, breaking through the suffocating darkness, piercing the surface crust. It unfurls its first tiny leaves, reaching, trembling, towards a sky it has never seen but somehow knows exists.

The landscape shifts. She sees the cactus from her coffee table, its sharp spines stark against the dreamscape. But around it,

wildflowers bloom in a riot of color–purple lupines, golden poppies, tall swaying grasses.

And on the cactus itself, where once there were only needles, vivid, impossible flowers erupt. Hot pink petals unfurl, delicate and bold against the tough green flesh.

The perspective shifts again. Long, wavy blonde hair, cascading past slender shoulders. Not Adora's practical, shorter cut, but a waterfall of gold catching an unseen light. Willowy limbs. The sharp, elegant hollow of a collarbone, visible above the neckline of a simple linen tunic.

A body shaped not by athletic training and protein shakes, but by tending to growing things, by a vegetarian diet, by quiet strength. Graceful where Adora had been powerfully sturdy.

Catra's dream-self feels a jolt, a visceral thrill that's entirely unfamiliar. The desire to touch that slender arm, to trace the line of that collarbone with her claw, to feel the texture of that long, wavy hair between her fingers.

She imagines a hand–thin-fingered, delicate, yet capable–reaching out. Not grasping, not demanding, but exploring. Touching her fur, tracing the curve of her ear, skimming down her side with a feather-light touch that ignites sparks along her nerves.

The sensation is electric, alive with potential, utterly distinct from the grief-soaked longing that usually colors her dreams.

Chapter 9: The Anatomy of Want

Catra wakes with a gasp that tears at her throat, the phantom sensation of slender, strong fingers tracing the line of her hipbone searingly vivid against her skin.

Her heart hammers against her ribs, a frantic, trapped bird. The darkness of the bedroom presses in, but it isn't the familiar, suffocating silence of grief. It's charged, electric.

Her skin feels too tight, her fur bristling with a static energy that has nothing to do with the dry apartment air.

And between her legs, a deep, insistent ache throbs. A heat pools low in her belly, urgent and undeniable. She's achingly hard, a distinct damp spot already cooling on the front of her pajama pants.

Her own hand twitches, a primal instinct moving towards the ache, craving the release and comfort she hasn't been able to grant herself in five years.

She freezes.

A wave of hot, sickening guilt crashes over her, so potent it steals her breath. This… this isn't for Adora. This isn't the familiar, bittersweet arousal born of memory and loss, a mournful tribute to a love that can never be physically fulfilled again.

That ache feels sacred, a continuation, a desperate, lonely way of saying *I'm still yours, always*.

This is different. The images flash behind her eyes—long, wavy blonde hair, the elegant hollow of a collarbone, hazel eyes flecked with green—are not memories.

They're possibilities. And possibility, after five years of choosing the known, desolate landscape of grief, feels like the most profound betrayal imaginable.

"No," she rasps into the darkness, the word a plea. She squeezes her eyes shut, as if she can force the images, the sensations, back into nothingness. "No, no, *no*."

A shimmering form coalesces in the gloom. Adora's ghost sits at the foot of the bed, her form translucent, bathed in the faint blue light from the streetlamp outside. Her expression is soft, concerned.

'Bad dream?' she asks, her voice the familiar echo of memory.

Catra flinches, curling in on herself. "Get out," she snarls, the venom in her voice a defense against the shame burning through her. "Just… go away."

Adora's spectral face doesn't change. She scoots closer on the mattress, the motion natural and familiar, the way she had a thousand times in life. The blankets don't shift. The bed doesn't creak. *'You're upset. Talk to me.'*

"Talk to you?" Catra's laugh is a broken, hysterical sound. "How can I talk to you about this?" She gestures wildly at her own body, at the physical evidence of her treachery. "I'm… disgusting."

'Catra…'

"Don't!" Catra's voice cracks. Tears, hot and shameful, well in her eyes. "I dreamed about her. I… I wanted her. I *want* her. How can I… how can my body do that? How can it just… forget you?"

The sobs come then, racking and brutal, shaking her fragile frame. "I'm betraying you. I'm so sorry, Adora. I'm so, so sorry."

Adora moves, crawling across the bed on her knees with the remembered muscle memory of a living body until she's right before Catra. Her form is insubstantial, a trick of the light, but her presence is immense. *'Look at me.'*

Catra shakes her head, burying her face in her knees, her tail wrapping tightly around her legs.

'Look. At. Me.' The voice isn't a shout, but it holds the same unyielding, gentle force it had in life when Adora needed Catra to hear something vital.

Slowly, Catra raises her head. Her vision is blurred by tears, making Adora's ghost look like a figure seen through rain-streaked glass.

*'It is **not** a betrayal,' Adora says, her tone fierce with love. 'It is not forgetting. It is not disgusting. It's being alive.'

"I don't want to be alive like this!" Catra cries. "I want you! I want your hands, your laugh, your… your everything! Not… someone else's!"

'I know,' Adora whispers, her expression infinitely sad. *'I know you do. And I wish, more than anything, that I could give that to you. But I can't. And I hate it. I hate knowing you're alone. I hate knowing you're in pain. I hate that you wake up every morning wishing you hadn't.'*

She leans forward. There's no sensation of temperature, no chill, only the ghost of a touch, the memory of a sensation. Adora's spectral hands are cupping her face.

Her forehead, a shimmering outline, comes to rest an inch from Catra's. It's their gesture. The one Adora used when the world was too loud, when Catra was spiraling, when she needed Catra to see nothing but her, to hear nothing but the truth.

'I want you to be *happy*, Catra,' Adora's voice is a whisper that vibrated in Catra's very bones.

*'I want you to feel the sun on your fur. I want you to laugh until you can't breathe. I want someone to hold you when it hurts. I want you to feel something other than this pain. If it's her… if it's Perfuma… that's **okay**. It's more than okay. It's what I want for you.'

"I can’t," Catra sobs, her body trembling. "I can’t, I can’t. I don’t want you to go away. If I let her in… you’ll leave. You’ll really be gone."

'Look at me,' Adora urges again, her voice steady as a mountain.

*'I am **never** going to go away. I am woven into you. I’m in every scar on your body, every memory of joy, every moment we fought to build this life. Letting someone else see that light, letting someone else make you laugh… that doesn’t erase me. It honors me. It means the love we had was so strong, it’s giving you the courage to find it again.'*

She holds her intangible position, a perfect, heartbreaking facsimile of their most intimate gesture. *'I am always going to be with you. **Always**. But you need to be with the living, too. Please. For me. Let someone in.'

Catra collapses forward, but there’s no solid form to catch her.

She weeps into the empty space where Adora’s shoulder should have been, her tears dripping onto the sheets, the cold comfort of the ghost’s presence the only anchor in the storm of her guilt and confusion.

The words echo in the hollowed-out spaces of her heart, a permission she’s terrified to accept.

The bell above the door of The Verdant Cup chimes its soft, wooden note. Catra hesitates on the threshold, the familiar scents of coffee and greenery suddenly feeling alien and overwhelming.

Her skin prickles with a fresh wave of shame. How can she walk in here after last night? After her dream? It feels like everyone can see it written on her face.

She shuffles to the counter, her gaze firmly locked on the scuffed toes of her shoes. She can feel Perfuma’s presence before she

sees her, a warm, sunlit energy that now feels dangerously alluring.

"Morning, Catra." Perfuma's voice has its usual gentle melody, but it holds a tentative note.

Catra manages a grunt in response. A mug—her mug—appears on the counter. She fumbles for her wallet, her claws feeling clumsy and obvious.

"On the house today," Perfuma says softly.

Catra's head snaps up. "Why?" The word comes out sharper than intended, defensive.

Perfuma flinches almost imperceptibly. "I just… after last night… I thought you might need a pick-me-up."

Her smile is warm but worried, her eyes searching Catra's face. "It was a lot. I know it was. Thank you again for trusting me with it."

She thinks I'm upset about Adora. About crying. She has no idea. The realization is a relief and a torment. Of course that's what she thinks. It's the logical, sane conclusion. Not that Catra is wrestling with a desperate, inappropriate want for her.

Catra's ears burn. She forces her eyes away from Perfuma's concerned face, her gaze dropping to the safe, neutral territory of her collarbone, visible above the neckline of her soft tunic.

The memory of dreaming about that exact hollow of skin makes her stomach swoop.

"Thanks," Catra mumbles, grabbing the mug. As she does, her fingers brush against Perfuma's.

It's the briefest contact. A spark. A jolt of sensation that shoots straight up Catra's arm.

Her tail, which had been a tightly wound coil against her leg, puffs out to twice its size and shoots straight into the air for a split second before slamming back down, the fur on end. Her ears spring forward, alert, then pin back flat against her skull in a confusing, contradictory signal of interest and panic.

She knows her face is flushing, the heat unmistakable even beneath her fur.

She snatches her hand back as if burned, clutching the warm mug like a lifeline, and all but flees to her corner table, her cane tapping a frantic, uneven rhythm.

Perfuma stands frozen behind the counter, her own hand hovering in the air. She sees it. The tail, the ears, the blush.

She's been cataloguing every flinch and flicker over weeks, learning the language of Catra's hybrid body. This is new. This isn't pain or anxiety. This is… something else entirely.

Oh no, Perfuma thinks, her stomach twisting into knots of worry. *I moved too fast. I overwhelmed her. Sharing Adora, holding her while she cried… it was too much, too soon. I scared her.*

She mentally berates herself, her usual calm evaporating. *Be patient. Be understanding. Give her space. Don't hover.*

She busies herself with wiping down the already-spotless counter, her movements stiff. She doesn't look at Catra's corner, but she's hyper-aware of her presence, a prickly, tense energy disrupting the café's peaceful hum.

Catra drinks her coffee in record time, the bitter liquid doing nothing to calm the riot inside her. She can feel Perfuma's worried attention like a physical weight. She has to get out.

She stands, her joints protesting the sudden movement, and shuffles toward the door.

She has her hand on the handle when she stops. Adora’s words from earlier this morning echo in her mind. *Let someone in.*

Gritting her teeth, she turns around, shuffles to the counter. Perfuma’s watching her, her expression a mask of carefully neutral concern.

"Hey," Catra says, the word raspy.

Perfuma’s eyes widen slightly. "Yes?"

"Thanks for…" Catra gestures vaguely, unable to look directly at her. "…coming over last night. It was a lot but…"

She takes a shaky breath. "It was good. To have someone. In the apartment with me, and… thanks. For listening."

The relief that washes over Perfuma’s face is so profound it’s almost painful to witness. Her beaming smile could power the city. "Oh, Catra. It meant so much to me to be allowed in like that. Thank you for showing me that trust. Truly."

Catra gives a jerky nod. Her eyes flicker to the empty space beside the pastry case where Adora’s ghost stands, giving her two translucent thumbs up. *'Do it,'* she mouths.

Blushing furiously, Catra fumbles in the pocket of her hoodie and pulled out a crumpled receipt. She snatches a pen from the cup on the counter and scrawls her number on it.

"Here," she mutters, thrusting the paper at Perfuma as if it were on fire. "If you want to text or whatever. Don't… feel like you have to."

And before Perfuma can form a reply, Catra wrenches the door open and hobbles out into the street with a speed her cane usually doesn’t allow.

Perfuma stands, stunned, holding the scrap of paper. She looks from it to the empty space by the pastry case, a slow, dawning

understanding replacing her worry.

A silent, grateful thought blooms in her mind. *Thank you, Adora. For not letting her retreat.*

The video call window shows Dr. Netossa's calm, attentive face. Catra has the tablet propped on a pillow on her thighs, the camera angled, as always, to show only from the nose up.

She reclines in bed, a fortress of pillows supporting her back. She can't waste her precious few minutes of sitting upright on this. Even this position aggravates the constant, grinding ache in her spine and hips.

"...And how have you been since our last session?" Netossa asks, her stylus poised over her tablet.

"Fine," Catra says automatically, her gaze fixed on a stray thread on the comforter.

"Catra."

The use of her name, the gentle prodding tone, breaks through her defenses. She squeezes her eyes shut, a faint throb starting in her tailbone from staying so still.

"I had a dream," she whispers.

"Okay." Netossa's voice is neutral, encouraging.

"A… sexual dream. About… the barista. Perfuma." The words feel like shards of glass in her throat.

Netossa nods, making a note. "And how did that make you feel?"

"Like a monster," Catra spits, her eyes flying open, hot with unshed tears. "A traitor. How can my body do that? How can it

want someone else? It feels… filthy. Like I’m erasing Adora. Like I’m spitting on her memory."

Dr. Netossa sets her stylus down with a definitive click and leans into her camera, her gaze intent.

"Alright, let's pause and reframe this. You're not a traitor, Catra. You're a living being. Your body is finally signaling a return to life after five years of dormancy. That isn't disgusting. It's a significant, healthy development."

Catra opens her mouth to retort, but Netossa presses on, her voice leaving no room for argument.

"The guilt you're describing? It's a protective mechanism. It served a purpose when the loss was fresh. But holding onto it this tightly now is what's causing you harm. It's isolating you from the very things that could help you heal."

She picks up her stylus again, tapping it lightly against her tablet. "Honoring Adora doesn't require you to stop living. It means living the life she would have wanted for you. Do you truly believe she would want you to feel monstrous for feeling a connection? For feeling a moment of want? I find that very hard to believe."

She pauses, letting that land. "The love you have for her isn't a finite resource. Making room for a new connection doesn't mean you're taking away from what you had. It means your capacity for love is, bravely, beginning to grow again."

Netossa’s voice softens, becoming firm yet compassionate. "This feeling you're describing? It's not betrayal. It's not filth. It's a sign of life. Your body, your spirit, after years of winter, are sensing the spring. They are reaching for warmth, for connection. This is a profoundly healthy and courageous thing."

She folds her hands on her tablet, her focus entirely on the camera lens. "I’m going to suggest something. And I want you to think of it not as an act against Adora, but as a reclamation of yourself."

She pauses. "I want you to consider exploring your own body again. On your terms. Reacquainting yourself with your own sexuality, separate from anyone else. Remember what pleasure feels like, for you and you alone. It belongs to you, Catra. It is not Adora's. It is not Perfuma's. It is yours."

Catra's ears pin back so flat they hurt. Her fur fluffs up. A hot blush burns its way from her chest to the tips of her ears. "I—that's—" The words jam in her throat, mortifying and warm. "That's… not why I'm here."

"Perhaps it should be," Netossa says gently. "Think about it. That's all I ask."

Catra mutters something noncommittal and the second the session ends, she jabs her finger at the "end call" button with such violent force that her knuckle bends backward with a sickening twinge.

Her heart is racing. The blank, black screen now reflects only her own flushed and furious face back at her.

Reclamation. The word echoes in the sudden silence, both terrifying and tantalizing.

She lays in bed that evening, her Switch a familiar weight in her hands. The cheerful music of her island feels like a mockery.

She pulls weeds around Adora's cottage with vicious, repetitive button presses, trying to drown out her therapist's voice, the memory of the dream, the feel of Perfuma's hand.

It's no use.

Finally, she navigates to the little beach café she built. She opens the mailbox.

To: Adora

Subject: my dumb therapist

my therapist wants me to jack off. do you think i should sue her for sexual harassment?

… i had a dream. about perfuma. she was. touching me.

you wont… be sad? if i think about her?

She hits send, watching the little letter icon vanish into the pixelated sky. The act feels silly and sacred all at once.

A few minutes later, her phone pings. A number she doesn't know.

Unknown Number: Hi Catra, it's Perfuma from the café. Just wanted to send you my number so you have it. I'm headed to Scorpia's for game night and am already preparing my arguments against the likely appearance of Monopoly (give everyone homes!). I hope you're having a peaceful evening.

Catra stares at the message. The candidness. The silliness. The sheer, unvarnished Perfuma-ness of it. A sound escapes her—a huff of air that turns into a genuine, surprised laugh. She hasn't seen this side of Perfuma before. It's… adorable.

Almost without thinking, she opens a browser, searches for an image, and finds it: a perfect picture of a cat smugly knocking over a row of monopoly houses and game pieces. She attaches it and types a reply.

Catra: down with the bourgeois. theres no way i could sit through a whole game of monopoly without my skeleton falling apart. have fun dismantling the rental industry.

Perfuma: This is the perfect image for my mood! The revolution has a mascot. 😂 (I literally laughed out loud, thank you for that.) I hope your joints are being kinder to you tonight.

A warmth spreads through Catra's chest, effervescent and light. The ease of it. The connection. It's an inside joke. She hasn't had an inside joke with anyone in five years.

The warmth travels, settling low in her belly, a familiar, insistent heat. Her first impulse is to clench against it, to ignore it, to drown it in guilt.

But she remembers Dr. Netossa's words. *Reclamation. It belongs to you.*

With a groan, as if embarking on a grueling physical therapy session, Catra slowly slides her hand down from her stomach to cup the slowly swelling bulge in her sweatpants.

She feels the warmth of her own hand through the fabric. The gentle pressure.

Her hips give a minute, involuntary rock up into the sensation.

She lets them.

For slow, cautious minutes, she just rocks—a gentle, seeking rhythm against her own palm, feeling herself harden. The dull ache sharpens, condenses, becomes a bright and focused need.

While her cock presses into her palm, she drives two fingers on the same hand, firmly, deeply into the sensitive, swollen area behind her balls.

Her head falls back against the pillow with a soft *thump*. A low moan escapes her—a raw, surprised sound—as she grinds her cock into the heel of her hand. The moan fractures into a sharp whimper when her fingers find the perfect angle, the deep, internal pressure sending a jolt of pure sensation straight to her core.

Her breath comes in shallow pants now. Heat blooms across her face, flushes the tips of her ears. Her tail begins a slow, heavy *thump, thump, thump* against the mattress, keeping time with the frantic beat of her heart.

Alive. The word isn't a thought, but a feeling that floods every nerve. She feels, intensely and vibrantly, alive.

Her heart pounding a frantic rhythm against her ribs, she hooks her thumbs in the waistband of her sweatpants and pushes them down.

The air is cool against the heat of her cock, swollen and red, achingly hard and beading wetness at the tip. She leaves the sweatpants pooled around her thighs.

She reaches her hand back down to continue pressing firmly into her perineum. The deep pressure to the root of her penis makes her cock twitch and bob, untouched.

She works herself like that until the muscles in her wrist begin to protest, the dull ache a warning of potential injury.

She lays there for a moment, chest heaving, staring at the ceiling, at the water stain that's both a cloud and just a stain, at the same time. One doesn't replace the other.

It's been… so long.

A few times over the years she's tried, but she's never been able to take herself to climax without being overwhelmed by a grief so profound it feels like dying, or a guilt so sharp it kills the mood entirely.

This time feels different. She's focusing on the physical sensations, yes, but she's also monitoring her emotions, and they aren't spiraling into darkness.

It feels a little easier, this time, to just… feel good. She can enjoy these sensations for herself, outside of the context of Adora. It can just be… Catra, making herself feel good.

She closes her eyes.

She imagines slender hands. Golden, wavy hair. The elegant hollow of a collarbone. Hazel eyes with flecks of green in the sunlight.

She moves her tired hand back down to press firmly at the swollen spot behind her balls. Her other hand reaches down to grip her cock, which has softened slightly, and begins to stroke herself in time with the pressure of her other hand.

She imagines those delicate fingers wrapped around her cock, stroking her. Pressing firmly into her perineum, feeling her tense and throb.

How hard would those willowy arms be able to press? Catra wonders. She imagines Perfuma's arms shaking with the effort, trying to generate the firmness of pressure that Catra needs.

A snort of laughter escapes her at the image, but it's swiftly drowned out by a sharp whine as the fantasy overwhelms her.

Her grip tightens convulsively, and the drag of that perfect, aching sensitivity sends pure lightning up her spine.

Catra imagines seeing the slick wetness of her tip getting on Perfuma's fingers—marking those slender hands.

A possessive thrill runs through her. That's right. Marking has *always* turned her on. It wasn't something Adora needed; it was something Adora had simply understood *Catra* needed, a part of her sexuality she'd recognized and welcomed.

A sudden, visceral memory, sharp and unbidden: *she's sixteen, pressed against a chain-link fence behind the high school, her claws digging into the metal as she kisses a girl whose name she's already forgotten.*

The overwhelming, confusing urge wasn't just to touch, but to claim. To leave her scent on the other girl's neck, to bruise the skin with the pressure of her mouth. To make sure everyone knew who had been there.

A flash of a more familiar memory: *Catra, older, rubbing her cock against Adora's face, making a noise somewhere between a purr*

and a growl. Adora laughing, breathless and adoring, saying "Okay, kitty, I'm yours! I'm yours!"

This isn't a 'Catra and Adora' thing. This is a 'Catra' thing, as fundamental as the cartilage in her ears or the claws at her fingertips. She is always going to be turned on by seeing herself glistening on her partner's skin. Belonging to Catra.

A heavy, gathering tension pulls deep in her groin, a familiar tightening that means she's close. Her balls pull up tight. Her fingers dig viciously into that swollen, perfect spot behind them. The wet, slick rhythm of her own hand is the only sound in the world.

Thoroughly lost in the fantasy, her breath hitches into sharp, punched-out whines. The fur along her spine bristles and her tail lashes a frantic, unconscious rhythm against the bed, every nerve screaming to life. The thoughts are fading, replaced by a static hum and the blinding need for release.

The last coherent image her mind can form is the warm heat of Perfuma's mouth. That smooth human tongue laving the sensitive underside of her cock. Tasting her. Swallowing her—

A sound tears from her throat—half-gasp, half-sob—as the world dissolves into a white-hot seizure of pleasure. Every muscle in her body locks, back arching off the bed in a soundless scream.

A sequence of tiny pops and cracks resonate through the room as joints all over her body—hips, shoulders, spine, ribs—subluxate and realign under the intense wave of tension and release.

Her ears pin back, tail stiff and straight. Her cock pulses violently in her hand, in the fantasy of Perfuma's mouth. Her perineum spasms under the press of her fingers.

A guttural groan, on the edge of pain and pleasure, escapes her as she rides out the contractions racking her entire body.

Finally, after an eternity, she collapses. Boneless. Spent. Her chest heaves with breath, her heart pounds, blood surges through her veins. For a few precious moments, she exists in a state of mindless, blank presence in her body.

Then, a laugh starts to bubble up. It begins as a disbelieving huff of air, a single chuckle, and grows into a full, belly-deep laugh that shakes her frame.

The rush of endorphins, the sheer, shocking relief that she was able to do this, to connect with this part of herself… it's dizzying. Tears bead at the corners of her eyes from the intensity of the feeling.

They well over, tracing hot paths down her cheeks as her chest hitches on a single, ragged breath.The laugh dies down, and the tears intensify, morphing into great, shaking sobs. Not of sadness. Not entirely. But of release. Of relief.

Of the sheer, staggering magnitude of feeling alive after half a decade of living in a tomb, feeling herself slip closer and closer to the welcoming, quiet dark.

She's alive.

In her mind's eye, she sees it: the simple, unassuming door that had whispered promises of peace and oblivion. And she sees it, not with longing, but with a quiet, final certainty, swing shut. The lock clicks into place.

Her life isn't over.

In this moment it doesn't even matter if Perfuma feels the same way. This isn't about Adora, and it isn't about Perfuma.

This is about Catra.

For the first time in five years, she has touched a part of herself that grief and pain had walled away, and found it still whole, still wanting, still **hers**.

As her sobs gentle into hiccups and then into exhausted, even breaths, the space cleared by that catharsis fills with a new, tentative warmth. She thinks of Perfuma. Of her kindness, her patience, her gentle strength.

Catra has noticed the way Perfuma acts around her, a care that feels different from her general benevolence. Catra is rusty at social cues, but she thinks… maybe Perfuma feels something, too.

The thought sends a fresh thrill of fear through her. She's so starved for affection, so desperate for connection, that she could be reading it all wrong.

The mortification of being rejected, of damaging this fragile, precious connection to the outside world—to Perfuma, to the Verdant Cup—is a risk that makes her want to curl into a ball. Perfuma would be gentle, she's certain.

But Catra isn't ready. She needs time.

A momentary flash of the memory—the audible pops and cracks of her joints echoing in the room as she came—makes her cover her face with her hands and groan in sheer embarrassment.

If we ever… Perfuma would hear that. The thought is completely mortifying.

But underneath the embarrassment is a core of levity. It would be awkward. Humiliating, even. Adora had been well acquainted with the sound.

"Your body sounds like someone dropping a box of rocks down the stairs," she'd joked once.

But Catra has a feeling–lying there in the aftermath, the scent of her own release and the quiet of the apartment settling around her–a deep and certain knowing, that Perfuma wouldn't make her feel ashamed. She wouldn't flinch. She'd understand.

The thought, when it comes, is her own. No ghostly whisper, no therapist's prompt. A hard-won, quiet certainty. *She's safe*.

Chapter 10: A Delicate Orbit

Catra wakes.

Dawn is its usual grey intrusion around the edges of the curtains, but the weight feels different. Lighter. She wakes not with a gasp or a groan, but with a slow, deliberate inhalation, as if testing the air in a new world.

The memories of the previous night descend not as a shaming avalanche, but as a warm, private flush that spreads from her cheeks down her neck, up her ears.

The phantom sensations—the press of her own hand, the shocking, body-seizing climax, the echoing *pops* and *cracks* of her protesting joints—are vivid, but they're paired with a quiet, steadying sense of pride.

She did that. She reclaimed a piece of herself from the void.

She feels different in her body. The deep, familiar orchestra of aches is there, a constant hum of wrongness in her bones, but today she feels more like its conductor than its captive. She's present in the vessel, not just trapped within it.

Experimentally, she tries to flex the fingers of her right hand. A white-hot stab of pain lances from her fingers up her forearm, so sharp and sudden it draws a punched-out gasp from her lungs.

She freezes, breathing raggedly through her nose until the worst of it subsides into a throbbing, fiery ache.

Right. That.

She holds the hand up in the dim light. The two middle fingers are visibly swollen, sitting at a slightly wrong, nauseating angle.

The entire joint of her wrist is a hot, angry mess. She'd pushed too hard, lost in the moment, desperate for that specific,

grounding pressure.

Her body, ever the treacherous partner, has given her what she needed and then sent the bill, with interest.

"Damn it," she mutters to the empty room, a rueful, almost affectionate exasperation in her tone. The price for self-reclamation is a pissed-off wrist and two dislocated fingers.

A fair trade, all things considered, but an inconvenient one. This is the price of passion. She's intimately acquainted with the math.

With a sigh, she sits up, her spine crackling in protest. She reaches for the bedside drawer with her good left hand, claws snagging on the handle, and pulls out a familiar, bulky wrist brace.

The task of securing the brace one-handed is a familiar, decades-old dance of teeth, claws, and sheer stubbornness. Velcro straps are a special kind of hell designed to mock the dexterity-impaired.

Finally, with a final, satisfying *rrrip* of velcro, the brace is snug and secure, immobilizing the treacherous joints. The immediate, firm pressure is a relief, muting the sharpest edges of the pain to a dull, bearable roar.

Now comes the real problem. The internal calculus.

She stares at the brace, then at her cane leaning against the nightstand. Her cane. She uses it in her **right** hand. It's muscle memory, a part of her. Her right wrist and two fingers are now a rigid, useless block of plastic and pain.

Her gaze drifts to her legs. Her **left** knee is the traitor—the most unstable, the one most likely to buckle without warning. The proper technique, the one every physical therapist had drilled into her, was simple: cane on the *opposite* side of the weak leg. Offload the weight, create stability.

Her weak leg is the left. The cane should be in her right hand. Her right hand is currently out of commission.

The equation has no good solution. Use the cane in her left hand, sacrificing proper support for her treacherous knee? Or try to go without, relying on doorframes and sheer willpower, risking a fall that could dislocate a hip or a shoulder?

She weighs the risks. The kitchen is only sixteen steps. Doorframes line the hall. But the price of a fall—agony, helplessness, humiliation—is astronomically higher than the price of a stiff, awkward gait.

Gritting her teeth, she reaches for the cane with her left hand. The grip feels alien, wrong. She plants it, testing her weight. The support is off-center, inefficient. A poor substitute, but better than nothing. It would have to do.

Leaning heavily on the cane in her *wrong* hand, she shuffles the sixteen steps to the kitchen. The routine is muscle memory: reach for the coffee tin with her left hand, fumble with the lid—

She stares at the tin, then at her braced, useless right hand. A growl of frustration rumbles in her chest. She'd have to set her cane down to wrestle the lid off one-handed, and it's not worth risking a fall for coffee. The math, once again, provides a bleak, infuriating answer.

A shimmering form coalesces by the kitchen doorway. Adora’s ghost leans against the frame, arms crossed, a sly, playful smile on her translucent face.

‘Oh no,’ she says, her voice a warm echo in Catra’s mind. *‘I guess you’ll have to go to the café if you want coffee. What a shame. A real hardship.’*

Catra scoffs, rolling her eyes, but a corner of her mouth twitches upward. “I don’t need your sass right now, Princess.” The old, affectionate, ironic petname—reserved for her strong, butch, athletic meathead of a wife—slips out with an ease that feels startlingly normal.

Adora's ghost doesn't miss a beat. She pushes off the doorframe and drifts closer, leaning in with an exaggerated leer. *'Oh? What do you **need** right now, Catra?'*

Catra feels the blush warm her cheeks, but for the first time, it isn't accompanied by a crashing wave of guilt or the acid taste of betrayal. It feels… good. Playful. Like falling into an old, comfortable rhythm. Adora would have teased her mercilessly about a crush. Of *course* she would have.

"Alright, that's enough from the peanut gallery," Catra says, shaking her head, "or I'm going to go on one of those trashy daytime talk shows: 'Help! My dead wife won't stop trying to set me up with the hot barista!'"

Adora's booming laugh—that loud, uninhibited, donkey-braying sound that had once filled every corner of their home—echoes through the silent apartment. It's a memory, a phantom noise, but to Catra, it feels real. And then, as suddenly as it came, it's gone. The ghost fades, leaving Catra alone in the kitchen.

The silence returns, but it doesn't feel heavy. It feels… inhabited. This is the new shape of her relationship with Adora. She isn't failing her by loving someone new. Adora is her cheerleader. Her incorporeal, deeply annoying wingwoman. The warmth in Catra's chest isn't just from embarrassment; it's from the normalcy of it.

Adora can still be a part of her life, can still be a part of this new, terrifying, exhilarating thing growing between her and Perfuma. It feels safe. Her love isn't a shrine she's desecrating; it's the stable foundation she's building from. Growing, expanding. Not replacing.

I am always going to be with you.

The words are a comfort.

The bell above the door of The Verdant Cup chimes. Catra stands on the threshold, steeling herself. A man in a bright blue bike

helmet holds the door open for her.

“After you,” he says with a polite nod.

Catra’s instinct is to duck her head, mutter thanks, and shuffle past. But today, she meets his eyes for a fleeting second. Her breath is already coming in shallow pants from the walk, her braced hand throbbing in time with her heartbeat.

She shakes her head, gesturing with her cane for him to go first. “You’re… faster,” she manages to rasp.

He smiles and goes ahead. Catra follows, the simple act of navigating the doorway feeling like a monumental effort.

From behind the counter, Perfuma is chatting with Scorpia during a lull. Her eyes, however, are already tracking Catra’s entrance, having seen her approach through the window.

She notices the brace immediately—the rigid support holding Catra’s wrist immobile, the way she cradling the injured limb protectively close to her body. Her professional smile tightens with concern.

She takes the bike-helmet man’s order distractedly, passing it to Scorpia with a murmured, “Large Americano, for here,” before turning her full attention to Catra.

And then she sees it. Catra is making eye contact. Not a fleeting glance at her collarbone, but a direct, if weary, look. And there, lurking in the gold-and-blue depths, is a flicker of sly mirth.

“Looks like you survived Monopoly,” Catra rasps, her voice rough from the walk and the morning’s disuse.

Perfuma snorts a laugh, the sound surprised and genuine. “I took a strong, principled, anti-Monopoly stance last night, so we played games that were actually fun instead. No real estate tycoons.”

Catra huffs her amusement, a soft puff of air. “Proud of you for sticking to your convictions.”

Behind Perfuma, Scorpia is polishing the same spot on the espresso machine for the third time, her large frame practically vibrating with the effort of pretending not to listen.

Perfuma’s gaze softens, drifting back to the brace. “What happened?” she asks gently, her voice lowering. She leans forward slightly, her eyes tracing the swollen, slightly crooked fingers visible at the edge of the brace. “It looks painful.”

Catra’s ears pin back. Perfuma sees the flush rise on her cheeks, coloring the fur. Catra breaks eye contact, a nervous, self-deprecating laugh escaping her.

“Oh, nothing important. This just happens. Did I ever tell you I dislocated a bone in my hand grabbing a doorknob once?” She says it lightly, with a casual, wry flippance that is a shield. “Once the swelling goes down a little bit, I’ll reduce the joints.”

Blank stares from Perfuma and Scorpia.

Catra blinks. “I’ll… put the fingers back in joint,” she explains.

Scorpia makes a faint gagging noise, her large pincers snapping together reflexively. "Yikes! New fear unlocked.” She shudders, holding her claws up. “Suddenly feel a lot better about these.”

Perfuma feels a wave of visceral, sympathetic unease, a cold prickle on her own skin. The casual brutality of it—*I’ll put the fingers back in joint*—is staggering. She imagines the act, the pain, the sheer force of will it must require, and her stomach lurches.

But she doesn’t let it show on her face. Instead, her expression settles into one of profound awe. “You’re so amazingly strong, Catra,” she says, her voice full of genuine reverence. “You carry pain that would debilitate other people like it’s a slight annoyance.”

Sometimes, when people call Catra ‘strong,’ she wants to scream. It feels like a dismissal, a demand to keep enduring without complaint.

But today, from Perfuma, it feels… different. It feels like being seen. It’s an acknowledgment of the relentless, exhausting labor of simply existing in her body, saying '*Yes, this is as hard as it feels. You are not weak for struggling.*'

She often wonders what it's like to *not* be in pain 24/7, to *not* be in constant negotiation with her own faulty scaffolding.

Catra feels her face heat. She isn’t sure what to say. But she feels comfortable here, in this space fragrant with coffee and plants, safe to share the full, unvarnished spectrum of her lived experience.

“Sometimes *I* forget that other people’s bones stay where they’re supposed to,” she admits quietly.

A memory flashes: her, years ago, in a room full of friends, cackling as she bends her thumb backward at a nauseating angle, delighting in the collective gasp of horror. Adora is laughing too, a proud, slightly queasy grin on her face.

It’s a party trick born of a lifetime of pain, a way to externalize the internal chaos, to prove to herself and others that the struggle is real. *It’s not in my head. This body **is** broken. And I’m still here, laughing at it.*

The humor isn’t self-deprecating; it’s defiant. It’s her way of saying, *Look at how strong I am. I can carry this thing that horrifies you, and I can still laugh.*

It’s in that spirit, emboldened by the memory and Perfuma’s warmth, that Catra makes a decision. She rests her cane against the counter, carefully balancing her weight on her protesting legs. She lifts her braced arm.

“See?” she says, a mischievous glint in her eye.

She presses the thumb of her good hand firmly against the forearm of her injured one. There’s a barely audible, wet *thunk* as the digit slides out of joint. The connective tissues around this particular joint are loose enough that she doesn't feel more than a slight twinge.

Scorpia lets out a sharp gasp, her pincers snapping shut. Perfuma’s hand flies to her mouth, her eyes wide.

Catra holds it for a second, a grotesque display, before pulling her left hand away. The dislocated thumb slides almost silently back into place with a soft sigh of tissue.

And then Catra cackles. It’s the same bright, unfettered laugh that had bubbled from her chest the night before—a sound of pure, defiant glee.

Scorpia, after a moment of stunned horror, bursts into nervous laughter herself, a loud, relieved bellow. “Holy crap! Don’t *do* that!”

Catra misses Perfuma’s expression in that moment. She misses the look of profound tenderness and awe that transforms her face. The concerned horror replaced by a dawning, breathtaking understanding.

This isn’t just a party trick. This is a language. This is Catra showing her, in the most visceral way possible, who she is and what she carries. And she's *laughing*.

Oh, Perfuma thinks, her heart swelling with an affection so fierce it steals her breath. *Something has changed in her. She’s coming back to herself.*

Affection for this burdened, hurting person—who carries so much and still chooses to laugh about it, who trusts her enough to show this raw, strange, defiant part of herself—washes over Perfuma in a warm, undeniable wave.

The laughter subsides, leaving Catra breathless and wincing as the movement agitates her injuries. She reaches for her coffee mug on the counter, then stops, her left hand hovering. She can’t hold the mug and her cane at the same time.

Perfuma sees the hesitation instantly. Without a word, she smoothly picks up the mug. “Your usual table?” she asks, her voice neutral, offering an escape from the emotional intensity of the moment.

Catra nods, grabbing her cane. The thumb on her good hand aches dully now, a reminder of her folly, but as she totters after Perfuma to her corner table, she decides that for the lightness in her chest, the echo of her own laughter, the look in Perfuma’s eyes—are all worth a little extra pain.

The walk home is a slow, careful recalibration. The defiant joy of the café, so bright and loud, gradually settles into a quieter, more private warmth. Each step sends a fresh throb through her wrist, a stark reminder of her body’s limits, but it's a price paid for a greater gain.

By the time she sinks into her armchair, the laughter has faded but the feeling remaines—a new, quiet sense of equilibrium that holds the pain at bay. She's still sitting there, cradling that feeling, when Mara arrives.

Mara notices the change the second she bustles through the door, her medical bag thumping onto the floor. Catra is sitting in her armchair, her braced hand resting on a pillow, but she isn’t hunched in on herself.

There’s a looseness to her shoulders, a quiet calm in her expression that Mara hasn’t seen in years.

"Someone's found a sunbeam to lie in" Mara chirps, though her eyes are sharp with assessment, taking in the brace. “What did

you do, Trouble?"

"Overdid it," Catra says simply, a shrug in her voice. There's no defensiveness.

The shower routine begins. Catra sits on the cold plastic stool, the brace carefully set aside on the closed toilet lid. Mara tests the water temperature with her hand before directing the spray.

"Anything need special attention today?" Mara asks, her voice professionally casual as she massages shampoo into the thick fur around Catra's ears. "Any new aches? That wrist looks nasty."

Catra hesitates, the warm water sluicing over her shoulders. She doesn't want to tell Mara about the reclamation, about the profound, private journey of the night before. But she has to.

Mara needs to know. She has to have these conversations after the dreams that she wakes up sticky and grieving from, too. This is different, but the awkwardness is the same.

The familiar question—*Anything need special attention?*—now conjures a different memory entirely. One that doesn't hurt so much as sting with its distance.

A memory surfaces, unbidden: *30-year-old Catra, sitting on this same stool as Mara works shampoo into the fur around her ears*

"It was our anniversary last night," Catra says, a faint, smug smile on her face.

"I'll give your downstairs a little more attention, then?" Mara asks, matter-of-fact.

Catra's ears perk up, her tail giving a happy twitch against the stool. "That would be great."

In the present, Catra's ears pin back flat against her skull. The memory is a ghost of a different life.

Mara prompts again, her voice gentle. “Catra?”

Catra keeps her eyes fixed on the familiar cracks in the tiles. The victory is too immense to hold alone in the silence. Netossa knows the facts, but Mara is the only one who has washed the grief off her skin. She’s the only one who will understand the full, physical scale of the mountain she just climbed.

“I, uh… I had an orgasm last night,” she mumbles, the words almost lost in the spray of the water. Then, forcing the crucial distinction, she adds, “While I was awake. On purpose.”

Mara’s hands still for a fraction of a second. She understands the monumental difference immediately. Her expression, had Catra been looking, would have betrayed a flash of pure, unadulterated joy and victory before her professional facade slams back into place. Internally, she connects the brace to the confession, the lightness. *Of course. Pushed too hard. Worth it.*

Externally, her voice is light and neutral. “Okay. I’ll be more thorough than usual, then. Front and back?” she asks, as if inquiring about the weather.

Catra’s face burns beneath her fur. “Just the front,” she mumbles. “I was just… touching myself. My therapist made me.” The lie is pathetic, but it’s all she can manage.

Mara’s lips quirk in a hidden smile. Her voice is a soft, steady murmur beneath the water's spray. “Choosing that for yourself is real progress, Catra.” She shifts the sprayer. “Now, how’s this water temperature? Too hot?”

The rest of the shower passes in the usual clinical silence, but the air feels different. Lighter. The shame Catra braced for never comes.

Later, clean and fluffed up, dressed in soft, clean sleep clothes, Catra lays propped in bed.

The adrenaline and laughter of the day have drained away, leaving the full, deep exhaustion of pain in its wake. Her hand throbs relentlessly, a sharp counterpoint to the duller, broader ache in her hips and spine.

She holds her Switch in her lap, her left thumb clumsily navigating the buttons. She clears a few weeds from in front of Adora's pixelated cottage, the cheerful music a soft murmur in the quiet room. But her energy is gone.

She navigates her avatar away from the cottage, down to the beach café she built, her movements slow and clumsy with her good hand. Her character sits in the pixelated sand, watching the tiny waves roll in.

She opens the mailbox.

To: Adora

Subject: (no subject)

gonna fall asleep soon. wanted to say goodnight.

today was… weirdly okay.

i laughed.

my hand hurts.

thank you for helping me, even now.

i love you, adora. good night.

She hits 'send.' The little letter icon vanishes into the blue pixelated sky.

She powers down the Switch, the screen going black, and lets it rest on her stomach. Her eyes are already closing, the weight of the day pulling her under into a deep, dreamless sleep.

The silence of the apartment is no longer a void to be filled, but a blanket, gently settling over her.

For the first time in a long time, she’s not just enduring the weight of mornings. She’s resting before the next one comes.

Chapter 11: To Release and to Hold

The weeks pass in a new, fragile rhythm. The memory of her own laughter in the café becomes a talisman Catra carries, a small, warm light against the encroaching gloom she knows is coming.

The anniversary of Adora's death is a storm on the horizon, its approach felt in the increasing heaviness of her limbs, the sharper ache in her bones that has nothing to do with the weather.

The morning of, she wakes before dawn. The silence in the apartment isn't just empty; it's expectant. Heavy. Five years. A lifetime. A blink of an eye.

She'd told Perfuma a few days prior, the words clumsy and stiff. "This Saturday… it's the day. Five years. I probably won't… be around." Perfuma had just nodded, her eyes soft with understanding. "Thank you for telling me. I'll be thinking of you. Text me if you need anything. Anything at all." There was no pressure, no expectation. Just an open door.

Catra has no intention of using it. Today is for Adora.

A shimmering form solidifies at the foot of the bed. Adora's ghost isn't her usual playful self. She's subdued, her translucent edges seeming to bleed into the grey morning light. She looks sad. *'Hey, you,'* she whispers, her voice a faint echo.

"Hey, Princess," Catra rasps, the petname feeling more tender than teasing today.

'It's today, huh?'

"Yeah."

'I miss us.'

The simple words shatter something in Catra's chest. A sob catches in her throat. "I miss us, too."

The ghost moves closer. *'The box under the bed. The one with the letters from my first away-game camp. The sappy ones. Wanna read them?'*

It's exactly what Catra needs. A task. A shared mission. A way to be with her, not just drown in missing her.

And so the morning is spent not in solitary mourning, but in a shared wake. Catra pulls the dusty box out, and they go through it together.

Photos of a younger, less-aching Catra perched on a rain-slicked fire escape, a grinning Adora waving from the ground below. A ticket stub from a terrible action movie Adora had dragged her to.

And the letters—cheap notebook paper filled with Adora's loopy scrawl, detailing every boring detail of her days away, always ending with *"I miss you like crazy. Don't burn the apartment down."*

Catra reads them aloud. Adora's ghost cringes at her younger self's melodrama. *'Ugh, I was such a dork! 'The sky here isn't as blue without you'? Really?'*

They laugh. They cry. The ghost fills in details Catra had almost forgotten—the name of the cook who'd made the terrible meatloaf in the mess hall, the feeling of the sun on her shoulders during drills.

For the first time on this day, Catra isn't alone in her apartment. She's with her wife.

By the afternoon, the raw, sharp edge of the grief has been gently worn down to a deep, tender ache. The memories feel lived-in again, not like shards of glass. And in that tenderness, a new, shy want blooms in Catra's chest.

She looks at the ghost, who is smiling softly at a photo of them covered in paint after a disastrous DIY project. "Adora?" Catra's voice is small.

'Yeah?'

"I'd... like it if Perfuma could be here. For the rest of the day. With us. If that's… okay?" The old fear of betrayal is a distant whisper, easily quieted by the need for shared comfort.

Adora's ghost looks up, her expression infinitely kind. She moves over and places a shimmering, non-corporeal hand over Catra's heart. *"Of course it's okay. She's part of your world now. She should be part of this, too. Invite her over."*

With trembling fingers, Catra picks up her phone.

Catra: can you come over, please?

The response is immediate.

Perfuma: On my way.

—

When Perfuma arrives, she doesn't bring platitudes or forced cheer. She brings a quiet, solid presence and a small bag of pastries from the café. She takes in the scene—the open memory box, the photos scattered on the coffee table, Catra's red-rimmed eyes—and simply says, "I'm here."

Catra shyly pats the space on the couch next to her. "We were… looking at stuff."

Perfuma sits, her warmth a palpable comfort. Her gaze falls on a photo tucked halfway under a stack of letters: Adora, face smudged with grease, grinning triumphantly as she points at a newly installed ceiling fan.

Perfuma gently taps the photo. "Tell me about her," she asks, her voice soft. "What was she like in her element?"

Catra picks up the photo, her thumb stroking the worn edge. A real smile touches her lips. "A force of nature," she says, her voice

fond. “She could fix anything. It was her superpower.”

She launches into a story Perfuma hasn't heard—the time their old ceiling fan had started making a death rattle in the middle of a heatwave.

Adora had marched off to the hardware store, spent three hours studying diagrams online, and then single-handedly replaced the entire unit, muttering about torque and electrical loads under her breath.

“She would get so focused,” Catra recalls, a laugh in her voice. “Her tongue would stick out just a little, right here.” She points to the corner of her mouth.

“She had this look of pure concentration, like the fate of the world depended on this fan. And when she flipped the switch and it worked… god, she was so proud. She strutted around for a week.”

Adora’s ghost, sitting cross-legged on the floor, puffs out her translucent chest. *'It was a complex install! Required significant forearm strength. And it **still** doesn’t wobble.'*

“She says it was a complex install,” Catra translates for Perfuma, her eyes sparkling. “And that her forearms were very impressive. Which,” she adds with a soft snort, “they were.”

She finds herself sharing smaller, quieter things. How Adora would get completely absorbed in a project, losing track of time until Catra had to physically drag her away for food.

The way she’d always, without fail, accidentally smear dirt or grease on her face. The soft, satisfied sigh she’d let out after solving a particularly stubborn problem.

Perfuma listens, her presence a steady anchor, smiling in the right places, her eyes soft with understanding. After a while, when the stories have settled into a comfortable, wistful quiet, she gestures to the box. “Would it feel right… to write to her? We could.”

Catra’s hand has been out of the brace for a week. It's stiff, the joints protesting, but it's functional. She looks at the stories scattered around them, at the ghost of her wife smiling up from the floor, and then at the woman beside her who's helping her carry it all.

She nods. “Yeah,” she says, her voice thick with emotion. “I’d like that.”

They find paper and pens. The scratch of Perfuma’s pen is steady and smooth. Catra’s is slow, laborious, each letter a small victory over pain and emotion.

Catra’s letter is short, earnest, and vulnerable.

Adora,

It’s five years today. I still miss you so much it feels like I can’t breathe sometimes. This apartment is so quiet without your big, loud laugh. I’m so sad you’re gone. And I’m so grateful I got to know you while you were here. I love you. Always.

-Catra

Perfuma’s letter is different. It is not to the past, but about its enduring shape in the present. She writes slowly, thinking of the grease-smudged photo, the stories of focused silence and proud strutting.

Adora,

I see your fingerprints everywhere. Not just on the fan that doesn’t wobble, but in the way Catra’s eyes go soft when she talks about your concentration. In the love that’s still here, five years on. It hasn’t gone anywhere.

Thank you for loving her so well. I’ll try to be careful with what you left.

-Perfuma

She doesn’t show it to Catra. She simply places it on the coffee table next to Catra’s own.

Adora’s ghost floats over. She reads Perfuma’s lines first. Her smirk, ready with a quip, falters. She reads them again. Her spectral form seems to grow still, more solid in the lamplight.

She looks from the paper to Perfuma, who is studying her own hands in her lap, then to Catra, who is staring at her own blunt words as if seeing them for the first time.

‘Huh,’ the ghost says softly. Not a punchline. A real, quiet exhalation of surprise. The humor is gone from her face, replaced by something like wonder, and a deep, settled respect. She gives a slow, definitive nod, her eyes on Perfuma. *‘Okay.’*

It’s not grand. It’s not a speech. It’s the ghost of the most stubborn person Catra ever knew looking at the woman who sees the blueprint of her love in the ruins, and accepting her. *Okay.*

Catra’s breath leaves her in a shaky sigh she didn’t know she was holding. The acknowledgment isn’t for her; it’s between them. A silent transaction of understanding that lifts a weight she hadn’t fully felt until it was gone.

Adora’s ghost turns to Catra’s letter then. Her bravado is completely gone. She reads the three aching lines, and her face does something complicated—pride, a wrenching grief, and a love so vast it has no shape. She doesn’t speak. She reaches out, a shimmering hand hovering just above the paper as though she could touch the ink, the pain, the love. Then she presses that same hand over her own translucent heart.

Catra watches her. The tears that come aren’t the storm of earlier. They’re quiet. An overflow. She looks at Perfuma, who is watching her with an expression of such open, gentle solemnity it makes her chest ache in a new way.

Perfuma doesn’t reach for her. She just opens her hand, palm up, on the cushion between them. An offering. A landing pad.

After a long moment, Catra places her own hand over it. Her claws are sheathed. Her stiff fingers curl, just slightly, around Perfuma's. They sit like that, not looking at each other, looking at the ghost and the letters, holding on over the silent, sacred ground of the past.

As the evening begins to wind down, a comfortable silence settles over them. The emotional storm of the day has passed, leaving a calm, weary peace in its wake.

Catra's eyes drift around the room, landing on the familiar relics. The jacket on the chair. The photo on the shelf.

And then, the tub of protein powder and the box of bars on the kitchen counter. A museum exhibit of a life interrupted.

Make more room for me. Her own thought from weeks ago echoes back to her.

They're years past expired. Useless. They need to go.

But her whole body locks up at the thought. It's not about the powder; it's about having less of *Adora* in the world. These stupid, inanimate objects have been her companions, her anchors, for five years. Throwing them away feels like a desecration.

Her ears burn with the vulnerability of what she is about to ask. "There's… something I'd like to do," she mumbles, not meeting anyone's eyes. "It's a little silly."

"Anything you need right now is what we'll do," Perfuma says without hesitation.

"I want to get rid of the protein powder. And the bars. They're expired. But it feels… heartless. To just throw them out." She trails off, the words inadequate.

Perfuma's face lights up with immediate, perfect understanding. "Would it feel better to release them if we held a ceremony? We

could show them respect and gratitude for their presence in your and Adora's lives. Thank them, and then let them go. Would that help?"

The tension that had turned Catra's spine to ice melts instantly. That's it. Exactly it. She nods, relief washing through her. "Yes. Please."

They convene at the dumpster in the back alley, the world hushed and grey in the misting rain. Perfuma carries the items. Catra, leaning on her cane, takes a shaky breath.

"Thank you," she begins, her voice wobbly, addressing the tub of powder. "For making Adora's muscles so big and… and bite-able." A wet laugh escapes her. Adora's ghost, standing beside her, nods fervently. *'Yeah! Thanks for that!'*

Catra turns to the box of bars. "And thank you for making sure the dummy didn't go hungry between workouts."

Then her voice breaks. "And thank you… for keeping me company. For being here when I was alone. For… being something of hers I could still hold onto." The tears come in earnest now.

Perfuma says a few soft words about release and gratitude for things that have served their purpose. Adora's ghost has a hand hovering over Catra's back, a gesture of comfort she can't feel. Perfuma, her own eyes shining, reaches out and squeezes Catra's free hand, her grip solid and real.

"I'm ready," Catra whispers.

One by one, she takes each item from Perfuma and sets it reverently in the dumpster. It's not an act of disposal. It's a burial.

Back inside, Catra collapses into her armchair, utterly spent. Every ounce of emotional and physical energy is gone. Perfuma busies herself making tea in the kitchen that now has a little more empty space.

Adora’s ghost kneels by the chair. She reaches out, her shimmering hand pausing just inches from Catra’s cheek, her expression a heartbreaking mix of awe and anguish.

'You did so good today. I’m so… so sorry I left you all alone with all of this.' It's the closest she’s ever come to apologizing for her own death.

“It wasn’t your fault,” Catra breathes, fresh tears spilling over.

'I know. I’m still sorry.' The ghost manages a watery smile. *'I really enjoyed today. It was special. Having her here… it was good.'*

“I liked it too,” Catra says, her voice cracking. “I like telling her about you. I want her to know you.”

They look at each other then—the living and the dead—and a universe of love, understanding, grief, and acceptance passes between them in the silence.

Finally, Adora’s ghost stands. *'Well, I’m exhausted. I’m gonna hit the hay early tonight. You two have fun.'* And with a last, tender look, she fades away.

Perfuma returns with tea. They sit and sip, talking in hushed tones about the day, about how it felt, about how special the ceremony had been. When the conversation lulls, the silence is comfortable.

But as the adrenaline of the day truly fades, Catra’s body begins to scream.

Her SI joint is a molten knot of pain, grinding with every slight shift in the chair. A bone in her foot, shifted hours ago, sends a sharp stab up her leg. Her shoulders are rigid cliffs of tension, her hands trembling with fatigue.

She fidgets, wincing, unable to find a position that doesn't hurt.

Perfuma notices instantly. “It looks like you’re in a lot of pain. Is there anything I can do to help?”

Catra freezes. It's so embarrassing to ask. But the thought of trying to sleep like this, of the certain injury that will follow, is worse.

“I… could really use a massage,” she admits, her ears flattening. “My body is killing me. I’m worried if I don’t get rid of some of these knots, I won’t be able to stand up tomorrow. Would that be… okay?”

Perfuma’s face shifts to one of immediate, concerned care. “Of course it’s okay. Thank you for asking me.”

She lays out a blanket and helps Catra down to the floor. Catra lays face down with a grateful sigh. Perfuma kneels beside her, hesitating, her hands hovering. “I’m a little worried I’ll accidentally hurt you.”

“I’ll tell you if something doesn’t feel good,” Catra promises, her voice muffled by the floor.

And so Perfuma begins. Her hands, strong from kneading dough and repotting plants, find the terrifying knots riddling Catra’s trapezius and shoulders.

With a yogi’s understanding of anatomy, she applies pressure not just with muscle, but with intention, tracking the pathways of tension.

Catra is intensely responsive. A sharp hiss of pain gives way to a low, guttural groan of relief as a knot begins to yield.

Whimpers and sighs guide Perfuma’s hands, a wordless map of Catra’s pain. It's the most physically intimate thing they have ever done.

For Perfuma, the initial clinical focus begins to blur.

The feel of Catra’s fragile body under her hands, the sheer trust it represents, combined with the utterly uninhibited, needy sounds Catra's making… a flush of heat spreads through her own belly. She feels flustered, her heart beating a little faster.

“I can keep going,” she says, her voice slightly unsteady. “Do you want me to do your lower body too?”

Half-asleep, Catra gives a slurred, affirmative mumble, her tail giving a lazy, contented swish on the floor.

Perfuma moves down, kneading the tight muscles of Catra’s hips, her buttocks, the backs of her thighs. The noises Catra makes here are even more desperate—sharp intakes of breath, pained groans that melt into long, low moans of pure relief.

As Perfuma works a particularly vicious knot in her calf, Catra lets out a desperate whine that goes straight through Perfuma, sparking another, stronger wave of heat.

She shakes her head slightly, trying to stay grounded in her purpose: to help.

Finally, her own hands aching and tired, Perfuma has to stop. It feels like she could work for hours and never fully unravel the story of pain written in Catra’s muscles. She sits back on her heels, looking down.

Catra is asleep. Her breathing is deep and even, a soft, contented purr rumbling through her chest—a sound Perfuma has never heard before, so visceral and alive it feels like a secret she’s been entrusted with.

In sleep, the familiar lines of pain and grief are smoothed away. She looks peaceful. Young. Unburdened.

Moving with a gentle reverence, she rolls Catra onto her back, then carefully slides one arm under Catra’s knees and the other behind her shoulders. For a fleeting second, she sends up a silent

prayer of gratitude for every sun salutation and warrior pose that has made her strong enough for this.

She takes a steadying breath and lifts.

“Oh,” she breathes out, the word a soft puff of air. The weight in her arms is startlingly slight, a stark contrast to the immense weight of pain and grief Catra carries every day. *You hold so much, yet you weigh so little.*

The observation is immediate, followed by a sharp spike of concern that cuts through the warmth. The sheer physical lightness of her feels like a vulnerability she hadn't fully appreciated until this moment.

She makes a silent, firm promise to herself to gently ensure Catra is eating more.

She carries her the short distance to the bed, her steps slow and careful, and kneels to lower her onto the mattress. Catra murmurs something indistinct, nuzzling her cheek into the pillow without waking.

Perfuma’s hands are careful as she arranges the blankets over her, tucking them snugly around her shoulders the way one might for a cherished child.

She allows herself a single, fleeting moment to brush a stray strand of hair from Catra’s forehead, her touch as light as a dandelion seed.

She finds a notepad. She hesitates, the pen hovering, then scribbles a note—*Thank you for trusting me with today. -P.*—and places it on the pillow where Catra will see it.

She turns to leave when the drowsy voice stops her.

“Thank you… 'Fuma.”

Perfuma turns. Catra's eyes are still closed, her face smushed into the pillow.

"For being… with me today," she mumbles, the words slurred and thick with sleep. "You made it easier… Adora liked getting to know you."

Perfuma's throat tightens, her vision blurring with sudden, warm tears. "It was my honor to be here with you," she whispers, her voice thick with emotion. "Get some rest, okay? Sweet dreams."

A soft, purring snore is her only reply. Perfuma lets herself out, locking the door with a quiet, final click behind her.

The walk home is silent but for her footsteps and the distant hum of the city. The crisp night air does little to cool the warmth in her cheeks or settle the new, certain feeling in her soul.

The feeling of Catra's body under her hands. The sound of her purr. The sight of her, vulnerable and trusting and finally at peace.

Perfuma knows, with a certainty that is both thrilling and terrifying, that she wants to be the one to help carry the weight.

She wants to hear that cackle again. She wants to learn the map of that pain not to erase it, but to soothe it.

She wants to know what it would feel like to kiss her.

She needs to talk to Scorpia. She has to decide how to tell the woman with the broken body and the ferocious heart that she wants to love her.

Chapter 12: A Purr in the Quiet

The quiet in Catra’s apartment is a living thing. It isn't the hollow, echoing silence of a month ago, a void that presses in on the ears and the soul.

This is a different quality of quiet, thick and warm, spun from the soft rhythm of their breathing and the faint, distant sounds of the city easing into dusk through the slightly cracked kitchen window.

Spring is a promise on the evening air, a scent of damp earth and something green pushing its way through the concrete world outside.

Perfuma sits on the worn green velvet of the armchair, her hands curled around a mug of tea long gone cold.

Catra is on the couch, a respectable, carefully distance between them, her body a study in controlled tension.

She's narrating, in her clipped, dry way, the scandalous political machinations of her *Animal Crossing* villagers, but the performance is wearing thin. The words are a shield, and the shield was cracking.

Perfuma watches, her heart a soft, aching drum in her chest. Her eyes, as they often do, trace the lines of Catra’s form, reading the text of her pain and her resilience written in the set of her shoulders, the cautious placement of her limbs. But now, her gaze is catching on the restless, metronomic twitch of Catra’s tail against the couch cushion.

It's a tiny motion, a furious, trapped energy at odds with her attempted nonchalance. It speaks of a storm brewing behind the carefully constructed walls of gold-and-blue eyes.

The air between them grows heavier, saturated with all the words they haven't said.

The raw intimacy of the anniversary, the trust of the shared memories, the profound vulnerability of the massage, the shocking tenderness of being carried to bed—it all hangs in the space between the couch and the armchair, a constellation of moments waiting to be named.

Perfuma's palms feel slightly damp. She knows what she wants to say. The need to say it is a physical pressure behind her ribs. But the fear is a cold counterweight in her stomach.

What if her words, however well-intentioned, are a stone thrown into the fragile, still water of Catra's hard-won peace?

Yesterday. The stockroom of The Verdant Cup. The air is thick with the cloying scent of lavender she's been desperately bundling into jars, her hands shaking.

"Scorpia, what do I do?" Her voice is a frayed wire. She twists a tea towel into a tight rope. "My feelings... they're so strong. But her pain is so deep. What if my telling her is too much? What if it hurts her? She's so… fragile."

Scorpia, a mountain of steadfast compassion, moves without a sound, her large pincers coming to rest on Perfuma's shoulders, grounding her. "Sweetpea, look at me."

Perfuma forces her eyes up, meeting Scorpia's dark, earnest gaze.

*"Has it occurred to you," Scorpia says, her voice a low, gentle rumble, "that telling her **isn't** being reckless? Maybe it's being brave."*

*She points a claw for emphasis, her expression softening with a wisdom that always surprises Perfuma. "Think about it. **She** asked **you** over. **She** gave **you** her number. That woman has been climbing a mountain all by herself for years. She's doing so much better, we can all see it, but that doesn't mean the climb isn't exhausting."*

*Scorpia’s voice drops to a near-whisper, infused with a heartbreaking tenderness.

“Maybe she’s used up all her bravery for a while. Maybe the idea of saying how she feels out loud is just... too heavy to lift right now. You putting your feelings out there first... that isn’t pressuring her. That’s you taking the weight for a second. You’re saying ‘Here, let me carry this part. Your job is just to listen.’ You’re making it safe for her.”

She gives Perfuma’s shoulders a gentle squeeze. “And you’re brave enough to handle it if the answer isn’t what you hope.”

Perfuma stands there, the frantic energy leaching out of her, replaced by a new, solid certainty. The anxiety doesn't vanish, but it morphs. It's no longer a fear of causing harm, but a gardener's resolve to plant the truth and let it grow as it will.

The memory fortifies her, a shield of its own. In the present, on Catra’s couch, Perfuma takes a soft, steadying breath, the sound loud in the quiet room. Catra’s ears swivel toward the noise, the twitching of her tail pausing for a single, suspended second.

“Catra…” Perfuma begins, her voice softer than she intended. She let a silence hang, a space that holds everything she hasn't yet named.

“Can we talk about…” Another deliberate pause, her eyes gently holding Catra’s. “…this?” The single word encompasses the space between them, the weight in the air, the entirety of the unsaid things.

Catra goes rigid. Perfuma sees the minute flinch, the way her claws, which had been retracted, emerge just enough to prick into the worn upholstery of the couch cushion, catching on the weave.

Her defense snaps into place so fast it's almost audible.

“What,” she rasps, a forced smirk tugging at her lips that doesn't reach her wide, startled eyes, “you’re not here for the stunning

conversation and five-star hospitality?”

It's her old armor, but the delivery lacks its customary edge. The words are brittle, a papier-mâché shield over a trembling core.

The deflection, the visible panic, sends another memory flashing through Perfuma’s mind, clarifying her purpose.

But this time, the memory comes not as a single image, but as a diptych, two moments separated by mere minutes that had forever shaped her understanding of the woman before her.

A crisp, sunny winter afternoon. Perfuma is on her break, leaning against the brick exterior of The Verdant Cup, sipping hot tea and tilting her face to the weak sunlight.

Her gaze drifts across the street to the park. And there, moving slowly along the path, is a stranger. A woman hunched in on herself, her posture a map of pain, bundled in a thin hoodie against the cold. A cane taps a grim rhythm on the pavement.

A toddler, a roly-poly bundle of bright yellow, lurches off the grass and directly into the woman’s path. The child is already clutching a dandelion. Before the flustered mother can intervene, the child thrusts the flower triumphantly toward the woman's face.

Perfuma watches, mesmerized. The stranger freezes, staring at the unexpected offering. Her face is all sharp angles and shadowed eyes, etched with a weariness that seems ancient.

The woman freezes. For one long moment, she’s a knot of pure tension, a creature cornered by kindness. The snarl never reaches her lips; it dies in her eyes. Then, with a stiffness that speaks of deep exhaustion, she relents.

Her clawed fingers, which look so sharp and defensive, are impossibly gentle as they accept the gift. She gives a single, gruff nod to the apologetic mother, then stuffs the flower into her hoodie pocket before moving on, her cane finding its rhythm again.

The act is not one of sweet grandmotherly affection; it's one of sheer, stubborn, breathtaking will. A refusal to completely shut out the world. It's a moment of profound, wordless endurance that cost her something.

Perfuma's heart aches with a surge of protectiveness for this nameless, suffering, beautiful soul.

Minutes later. The bell above the café door chimes. Perfuma looks up from wiping the counter, a greeting on her lips that dies instantly.

It's her. The woman from the park.

Now, up close, the pain is not just a suggestion in her posture; it's a palpable force. She leans on her cane like it's the only anchor in a turbulent sea, her gait a painful, calculated shuffle.

The defiance is clearer now, too, in the set of her jaw, the flick of her tail. A part of Perfuma's mind, the part that notices small, sacred things, wondered if the crushed stem of the dandelion was still tucked away in her pocket, or if it had been discarded as a momentary burden.

Her initial feeling sharpens from a general ache into a focused, surprising jolt of concern.

This person is carrying a weight Perfuma can't see. And she carries it with a defiance that is both heartbreaking and awe-inspiring.

Perfuma won't be deflected. Not by the ghost of who Catra used to have to be. Perfuma leans forward slightly, her gaze unwavering, holding Catra's flickering, nervous stare.

"I'm here for the company," she says, each word deliberate and clear. "Specifically, yours." She sees Catra's breath catch, the slight parting of her lips. She presses on, her heart a wild thing in her chest. "I need you to know… my feelings for you… they aren't casual."

The effect is immediate and devastating. All the false bravado drains from Catra's face, leaving behind a stark, vulnerable panic. She looks cornered, terrified.

"Perfuma…" Her voice is a strained whisper, the name tearing from her throat. "I… you can't… I'm a mess. You've *seen* the mess."

"I've seen your strength," Perfuma says, her voice firm, infused with the conviction of that dual memory. She leans forward, closing the physical and emotional distance by a few more precious inches.

"I saw it the very first day, before I even knew your name. I see it every time you walk into the café. I see it in the way you carry what you carry."

Her eyes flick to the cane propped against the armrest, then back to Catra's stunned face. "I see it in the way you loved Adora so fiercely that her love is still a force in this world, still shaping you, still protecting you."

Her own composure fractures then, her voice cracking under the weight of her sincerity. "It's the most beautiful thing I've ever witnessed."

For a long, suspended moment, Catra is perfectly, utterly still. It's as if the words had struck her physical form like a tuning fork, and her entire being was vibrating with a new, shocking frequency.

Then, the impact hits.

Her breath hitches—a sharp, ragged, desperate intake of air that sounds like it tears at her throat. Her ears, which had been flicking with anxious energy, pinned back completely, flattening tight against the sides of her skull.

Her shoulders, usually a permanently hunched fortress of tension and pain, slump. Not in defeat, but in a sudden, profound release, as if a weight she's been carrying for a lifetime has been

momentarily lifted, only to be replaced by the sheer, overwhelming mass of the emotion itself.

Silent tears, shiny and perfect, well in her mismatched eyes, magnifying the gold and blue into brilliant, liquid pools. They overflow, tracing slow, glistening paths through the tawny fur of her cheeks.

She doesn't sob, doesn't gasp, doesn't make a move to wipe them away. She just lets them fall, her gaze locked on Perfuma’s as if she's seeing her truly for the very first time.

It's the look of someone whose entire identity has been built around a foundation of being a “mess,” a “burden,” a creature of pure, grinding survival, being told they are instead a thing of awe-inspiring beauty and resilience. The revelation doesn't just move her; it dismantles her.

Perfuma watches, her own tears now mirroring Catra’s, with the profound sense of witnessing ancient, deeply fortified walls crumble into dust in real time. Catra’s hand, resting on her own knee, begins to tremble slightly.

Another memory surfaces, bright and warm, a counterpoint to the cathartic sorrow in the room.

Her phone, buzzing in her pocket as she walks to Scorpia’s for game night. Catra’s name on the screen. The image that loads: a cat, smug and defiant, knocking over a row of Monopoly houses. The utterly unexpected burst of laughter that escapes her, loud and unguarded in the quiet street.

The warm, glowing realization that blooms in her chest: this prickly, complex, hurting person is also funny. She has a wicked, smart sense of humor that emerges like a sunbeam through clouds. And Perfuma wants, more than anything, to be the reason Catra makes jokes like that.

“I’m scared,” Catra whispers into the quiet, the admission seeming to cost her every ounce of strength she has left. “I’m so scared

of… all of this. Of needing you. Of this…" She gestures weakly at her own body, a heartbreakingly familiar motion of self-reproach. "…being too much. Of fucking it up."

Perfuma moves then. She shifts from the armchair to the couch, closing that final, careful foot of distance. She doesn't touch yet, but her presence is a palpable warmth. "I'm scared too," she admits, her voice a soft confession.

"I'm scared of moving too fast. Of not understanding your pain. Of not being what you need." She takes one more breath, readying herself to speak the the truest thing she has ever felt.

"But I'm more scared of never telling you that I'm falling in love with you, Catra."

The final memory comes then, not as a flash of the past, but as a full-sensory echo.

The weight of Catra in her arms, so frighteningly light. The soft, contented purr rumbling through Catra's chest and into her own, a sound of pure, unconscious trust. The feeling of rightness, of protectiveness, as she lays her down and tucks the blankets around her.

*Walking home that night under the cold stars, her own heart feeling too large, too full for her chest, and the crystal-clear, undeniable thought that had risen, simple and absolute: **Oh. I'm in love with her.**

The words hang in the air between them, a completed circuit.

And then, the perspective shifts. Perfuma sees the change in Catra's eyes. The shock and the tears are still there, but now they're being viewed through a new lens.

It's as if Perfuma's confession, and the raw honesty behind it, hands Catra a beam of light. And in that light, Catra isn't just hearing the words; she's finally seeing the journey behind them.

The careful attention, the patient kindness, the unwavering presence. She's connecting the dots from the first cup of coffee to the shared silence to the gentle massage.

The fear in Perfuma's eyes isn't fear *of* her; it was fear *for* her, and fear of losing this.

It isn't pity. It has never been pity. It has always been awe. It has always, from the very beginning, been a dawning, wondrous love.

The realization breaks over Catra's face like a dawn. Some distant, watchful part of her notes the unusual quiet in her mind; the ghost that usually lingers with advice or comfort is respectfully, significantly absent, allowing this moment to be wholly and completely theirs.

A shuddering breath escapes her, and a wet, shaky laugh follows, bordering on a sob. "I think…" she starts, her voice raspy with tears and a dawning, terrified wonder. "I think I'm falling in love with you, too."

Perfuma's breath catches. Slowly, giving Catra every opportunity to pull away, she reaches out. She placed her hand over Catra's, where it trembles on her knee.

Her touch is warm, her palm solid and steady against Catra's cool, soft fur. It's a question. It's an answer.

They move simultaneously then, drawn by a gravitational pull that feels both utterly new and deeply inevitable.

That last, careful foot of space between them vanishes, and the kiss is not frantic or desperate. It's slow, exploratory, a tender mapping of uncharted territory.

It tastes of black coffee and herbal tea and the clean, salty truth of shared tears. It's a conversation without words, a silent vow, a promise to be scared together.

When they finally part, breaths mingling, they stay close, Catra resting her forehead against Perfuma’s. Perfuma feels the solid, present warmth of her, the soft puff of her breath. The gesture feels practiced, instinctive, an echo of another life. But the feeling—the warmth, the rightness of it—is entirely new. This keeps the poignant echo of Adora while firmly in Perfuma's experiential POV.

The silence in the apartment, which had moments before been so heavy with the weight of unspoken words, is now entirely different.

It's peaceful. Deep. Brimming with a new, fragile, and breathtaking understanding.

The light from the window is fading to deep blue, and in the soft twilight, everything feels possible.

Perfuma doesn't move, unwilling to break the sanctity of the moment. She feels the faint, steady pressure of Catra’s forehead against hers, the soft puff of her breath, the warm weight of her hand still beneath her own.

The silence is no longer a thing to be filled or feared. It's simply… theirs.

And then, a new sound. A low, thrumming vibration, so subtle she feels it before she hears it. A purr. It rumbles through Catra’s chest, a soft, unconscious engine of contentment, and resonates gently against Perfuma’s own skin.

It's the sound of a fortress, finally at peace. It's the most beautiful answer Perfuma could have ever hoped to receive.

Chapter 13: The Architecture of a Body

Dawn does not intrude so much as it seeps into the apartment, a slow, grey tide of light that gradually defines the shapes of the room.

The first thing Perfuma becomes aware of is warmth. A solid, living weight against her side, the soft tickle of fur against her chin, and the deep, even rhythm of Catra's breathing.

The second is the scent—faintly of lavender from her own clothes, overwhelmingly of Catra, a musky, comforting smell that is beginning to feel like safety and belonging.

They fell asleep on the couch last night, tangled together in a way that felt both daring and inevitable after the earthquake of their confessions. Perfuma's arm is numb from being pillowed under Catra's head, but she wouldn't move it for the world.

Catra is curled into her, one hand fisted loosely in the fabric of Perfuma's tunic, her face smooth and peaceful in sleep, all its usual sharp lines softened.

Perfuma lays perfectly still, memorizing the feeling. The profound quiet of the morning after the storm. The rightness of it.

A soft, unconscious sound escapes Catra—not quite a purr, but a hum of deep contentment that vibrated through Perfuma's chest. She stirs, nuzzling closer for a moment before her body registers its own reality.

Perfuma feels the change instantly. The hum cuts off. The loose fist tightens. The easy rhythm of her breathing hitches, then shallows.

Catra is awake, and she is in pain.

Perfuma stays still, allowing her the privacy of the moment. She feels Catra's careful, minute adjustments, the subtle shifts as she

takes inventory of her body. A stifled gasp as she tries to straighten a leg. The tension coiling back into her shoulders.

“Morning,” Perfuma whispers, her voice raspy with sleep.

Catra’s ears twitch. She doesn't open her eyes. “‘Morning,” she mumbles, the word thick with something that wasn’t sleep—a grim acceptance. “Don’t… move. Yet.”

“I’m not going anywhere,” Perfuma assures her, her heart aching. She wants to kiss her temple, to smooth the fur on her brow, but she understands that any external stimulus right now is just more data for a nervous system already screaming with it.

After a few long minutes, Catra slowly, carefully, peels herself away. The loss of her warmth is immediate.

She gropes blindly beside the couch, her fingers closing around the familiar, worn handle of her cane before she even attempts to move. Using it as a pivot, she sits up with a groan that seems to be torn from the very core of her, every movement stiff and deliberate.

She looks… fragile. The vulnerability from last night is still there, but now it's underscored by a stark, physical misery.

“Coffee,” she declares, her voice a ragged scrap of itself. It's a goal. A purpose. A tiny act of normalcy to grasp onto.

Perfuma sits up as well, giving her space. “Would you like any help?”

“I’ve got it,” Catra says, too quickly, a flicker of defiance surfacing through the pain. She needs to do this. To prove she can.

She plants the cane firmly on the floor, using it to leverage herself upright. Her knuckles are white on the handle, her legs trembling visibly as they take her weight.

She stands for a second, swaying, the cane her only anchor. Her tail lashes once in a spasm of discomfort before stilling again. She takes a shuffling, calculated step towards the kitchen, the cane tapping a hesitant rhythm.

And then it happens.

Her left knee, the weaker one, simply… folds. It isn't a dramatic collapse; it's a sickening, inward buckle of the joint, a betrayal from within. Her body jerks instinctively, trying to catch her weight on her right leg.

The compensation is catastrophic.

A white-hot blade of agony lances through her pelvis, so sharp and sudden it steals the air from her lungs. She doesn't cry out. There's no time. A lifetime of experience takes over.

The moment she feels the deep, internal *wrongness*, the searing *pop* of her sacroiliac joint slipping out of alignment, her brain issues one primal command: *Let go. Go limp.*

The cane clatters to the floor. She drops right after it. Not like a felled tree, but like a puppet with its strings cut, her body going completely slack before she hits the worn hardwood floor with a dull, ugly thud.

Perfuma is on her feet before the sound has even finished echoing in the quiet room. “Catra!”

Catra lays on her side, curled slightly, the cane on the floor beside her, useless. She is utterly still except for the violent, shallow gasps that rack her frame. Her eyes are squeezed shut, her face a mask of pure, unadulterated agony.

“Catra! What happened? How can I help?” Perfuma’s voice is high with alarm, a cold fear gripping her chest. It had been one second. One second she was fine, if in pain, and the next she was… this. Broken on the floor.

A low, warning growl vibrates in Catra's throat, a sound of pure animal distress. "Don't touch me!" The words are less spoken than torn from her, a raw and venomous snarl.

Every muscle is locked, braced against an anticipated touch that would only worsen the white-hot fire in her side.

The viciousness of the rebuff hits Perfuma square in the chest. She feels a sharp sting of hurt and a flush of shame—she was only trying to help.

She takes a single, involuntary step back, and for a moment, she is caught in her own storm. *I startled her. I moved too fast. I made it worse.*

But she doesn't retreat into that feeling. She breathes into it, acknowledging it with a swift, internal clarity: *When I heard that snarl, I felt hurt and ashamed because I need to be a source of comfort, not distress.*

Having named her own need, it loses its power to overwhelm her. It simply is. And now, her focus can clear. Her eyes sharpen on Catra—not on the anger in her voice, but on the terrifying stillness of her body, the agony contorting her features.

She listens underneath the words. The snarl isn't malice. It's a raw cry of *I am in unbearable pain. I am terrified. I need safety. I need control.*

This understanding settles Perfuma completely. She kneels, settling carefully onto the floor a few feet away, making her posture soft and open. When she speaks, her voice is low, even, and steady—a calm pool offered in the midst of a hurricane.

"Okay," she says, her tone a gentle murmur. "I hear you. You're in terrible pain. You're scared. And you need to feel safe and in control right now."

She keeps her hands visible, resting on her own knees. "I am not going to touch you until you say it's okay. I'm right here. Just tell

me what you need. I'm listening."

For a long moment, there is only the ragged sound of Catra's breathing. Then, a subtle shift. The vicious, locked tension in her shoulders eases a fraction of a millimeter.

The panicked edge of her gasps softens, just enough to let a sliver of air reach her lungs. It is not surrender, but it is a ceasefire.

She could see it now: The anger was a spike of adrenaline, a defense against the overwhelming tidal wave of pain, embarrassment, and shame that threatened to drown her.

'*Why me? Why now? The day after… Can't I ever just have something nice?*'

Perfuma's calm, non-reactive presence is a lifeline thrown into that storm. The words—*I hear you, I'm not going to touch you*—aren't a negotiation. They are a statement of fact. A boundary that creates a fragile ring of safety around her.

After a moment, Catra's voice comes, choked and halting, forced out between clenched teeth. "SI joint… dislocated." A sharp gasp. "Can't… move. Can't stand. Can't… roll over." The admission is laced with a profound humiliation. "I'm… stuck."

Perfuma's mind reels. *Dislocated.* The word is so clinical for something that looks so utterly debilitating. Her gaze sweeps the room, and a new, horrifying understanding dawns.

'How many times? How many times has this happened when Catra was utterly alone? How many times has she lain on this very floor, trapped in her own body, in unimaginable agony, with no one to hear her whimpers, no one to help her?'

The thought is a cold knife in Perfuma's soul.

"What do you need from me right now?" Perfuma asks, her voice still soft but firm. "Right this second."

“Ice pack,” Catra grits out. “Freezer.”

Perfuma moves swiftly, retrieving the gel pack and wrapping it in a thin dish towel. She returns to her spot on the floor. “I have it.”

“I can’t… reach it,” Catra pants, frustration etching her words. “You’ll have to… get under my clothes. Pull my hoodie up. Waistband down. Press it into… just to the left of where my spine meets my pelvis.”

Perfuma’s hands tremble slightly as she leans forward. “Okay. I’m going to touch you now.”

Her fingers are gentle but deliberate as she carefully gathers the fabric of Catra’s hoodie, pulling it up to expose the small of her back.

She then hooks her fingers into the waistband of Catra’s sweatpants, easing it down just enough to reveal the inflamed, swollen area at the crest of her pelvis.

The fur there is matted with sweat. The skin beneath is visibly angry and hot to the touch. She places the wrapped ice pack directly against the swollen joint.

Catra’s entire body tenses at the contact. A raw, guttural sound is torn from her throat—a noise of such pure, animal pain that it makes Perfuma’s heart clench violently.

Beneath the towel, under her palm, Perfuma can feel it. A horrible asymmetry. The left side of Catra’s pelvis is hitched up higher than the right, and even through the fur and muscle, she can feel the angry, hot swelling around the joint, the tissues already traumatized and inflamed.

She holds the pack there, her own eyes filling with helpless tears. She can feel the muscles in Catra’s back and buttocks locked in a rigid, spasmodic vise around the injured joint, a brutal, involuntary reaction to prevent further damage.

It's a prison of pain, the body’s defense mechanism becoming its own torturer.

After what feels like an eternity, but is likely only ten minutes, Catra’s breathing begins to change. The desperate, shallow gasps deepen into ragged, controlled pants.

The white-knuckled grip of agony has lessened its hold, just enough for her to surface slightly.

“Waistband,” she instructs, her voice hoarse but clearer. “Tuck it… in my pants. So it stays.”

Perfuma does so carefully, securing the ice pack against the swollen joint. “Okay. It’s secure.”

“Bedside table. Muscle relaxers. Painkillers. Small orange bottle. Big white one.”

Perfuma fetches the medications and a water bottle with a straw from her own bag. What follows is a study in agony. Even the simple act of lifting her head enough to swallow the pills is a Herculean effort for Catra.

Perfuma supports her head, her heart breaking at the groans, the strain, the pitiful whimpers that each tiny movement costs.

“…Thanks,” Catra rasps, finally letting her head flop back to the floor with a thud, utterly spent.

They stay like that for another fifteen minutes, the only sounds Catra’s ragged breathing and the quiet hum of the city outside.

Perfuma gently, so gently, begins to stroke Catra’s hair, her slender fingers combing through the dark, messy tufts. Slowly, infinitesimally, some of the terrible tension begins to leach out of Catra’s frame.

“I think…” Catra’s voice is a weary whisper. “I think I’m ready to move to the bed. If you can… help turn me over. On my stomach.

I can drag myself. Be… careful. With my legs."

Perfuma is struck, not for the first time, by the casual, pragmatic way Catra adapts to the catastrophic failure of her own body.

There's no self-pity in the statement, only a weary expertise. This is a known protocol. She has solutions for the problems her body creates.

The sheer number of times she must have gone through this to develop such a deep, almost clinical, confidence is staggering.

"Okay," Perfuma says, her voice thick with emotion she's fighting to keep in check. "Talk me through it."

With Catra's halting instructions, Perfuma gently helps straighten her legs, and then carefully rolls her onto her stomach–a process that elicits a series of ragged, wet gasps that catch and break into something like a low, wounded whine deep in her throat.

Her claws scrape against the hardwood as she fights to stay limp against the tearing fire in her pelvis.

Catra's breathing grows harsh again as the movement sends fresh shockwaves through her system. Engaging any muscle, from her neck to her feet, is a calculated risk, each one sending a flood of warning signals to her overwhelmed brain.

As she begins the slow, torturous process of dragging herself toward the bedroom, her arms trembling with the effort, a memory flashes, vivid and unbidden.

Her and Adora, years ago. Catra is in bed, propped up by a fortress of pillows, largely immobile during a bad flare. Adora is seated nearby, watching with her.

On the TV, Princess Serenia stands on the bridge of her starship, the ***Star Runner****. The ship is under attack, badly damaged. The camera shakes with explosions. Warning klaxons blare. Red lights*

flash across screens filled with error messages. Smoke pours from a console, sparks flying.

Princess Serenia, usually flawlessly composed, leans against a command console, her ponytail coming undone. She's battered, bruised, panting with exertion, but a grim, fierce determination burns in her eyes.

Catra, her hand resting on the remote, presses pause. "It's like that," she says.

Adora looks away from the screen. "What's like what?"

"Right now," Catra says, gesturing vaguely at her own body. "My body. I'm Princess Serenia on the bridge. Warning lights and alarms and smoke and sparks. Every time I move my body, another siren starts blaring. Engineering's reporting that the engines are on the verge of failure. Hull strength is at five percent. Another direct hit is going to finish us."

Adora absorbs this, her expression sad and thoughtful. "And you're standing on the bridge, looking exhausted and sexy and determined."

A surprised snort escapes Catra, who immediately winces at the pain the laugh causes. "I didn't say she was sexy, Adora!"

Adora's face splits into a teasing grin. "And you're Princess Serenia, standing sultrily on the bridge, looking extremely fuckable." She doubles down, her eyes sparkling.

*"What is **wrong** with you?!" Catra cackles, playfully exasperated, the pain momentarily forgotten in the warmth of Adora's ridiculous affection.*

Back in the present, Catra reaches the bedroom doorway, her energy spent. She pauses, her forehead resting on the cool hardwood.

If she was alone, she'd still be lying in the living room. She wouldn't have an ice pack. The pills would still be out of reach. Getting to the bed would be an hour-long ordeal of unimaginable pain and certain further injury.

But she isn't alone.

Perfuma is here, a silent, steady presence trailing behind her. She isn't hovering, isn't offering panicked suggestions or making it about her own fear.

She's just… here. Present. It's a gift Catra hadn't known how to ask for.

"Perfuma."

"Yes?"

"Could you help me into the bed?"

"Of course. How do you want to do this?"

A pause. A memory surfacing through the pain-fog. "Did you… carry me to bed? The other night? I fell asleep on the floor and I woke up in bed."

"I did, yes," Perfuma says softly. "I didn't feel good about leaving you on the floor, especially when you were already in so much pain."

Catra has things to feel about that—a whole universe of vulnerability and trust to examine—but now is not the time. Now is for survival.

"Could you… help me onto my back, and then lift me? One arm under my knees, keep my legs bent and my spine round? Don't… straighten me out."

Again, Perfuma marvels at the anatomical specificity. Catra speaks about her body with the deep, intimate knowledge of a master

mechanic describing a broken, beloved engine.

She's like a yogi of chronic pain, Perfuma thinks, the term springing to her mind with a surge of admiration.

She pulls the covers back, then kneels. The process of helping Catra turn over is slow and arduous, pulling a short, miserable whimper from Catra's lips and making Perfuma's own muscles tense in sympathetic strain.

Then, she slides one arm under Catra's knees, keeping them bent, and the other behind her shoulders. She takes a steadying breath, centers her weight, and stands.

Catra is… light. So frighteningly light in her arms. The thought is a spike of concern—a silent promise she has made once before and now reaffirms—to gently ensure Catra is eating more.

But the act itself is smooth. Perfuma's daily yoga practice, her core strength, makes the motion fluid.

She takes the two steps to the bed and lowers Catra onto the mattress as gently as placing a precious seedling into fresh soil, pulling the covers up over her.

She looks down and sees Catra's expression. Her ears are pitched forward, her pupils dilated. A faint, unmistakable flush colors her cheeks and the tips of her ears.

The pain is still there, etched into the lines around her eyes, but it's now sharing space with something else entirely.

"You're stronger than I thought you'd be," Catra admits, her voice breathy in a way that has nothing to do with pain. She's still staring.

Perfuma feels her own face heat. "I practice yoga every day."

"I see," Catra says, her gaze flicking over Perfuma's willowy frame with new appreciation. "Thanks, yoga."

She delivers it with her trademark dry nonchalance, but Perfuma's mind instantly flies back to the ceremony by the dumpster, to Catra's words to the protein powder: *'Thanks for making Adora's muscles so bite-able.'*

Oh, Perfuma thinks, a warm, proud flush spreading through her chest. *She's aroused by how strong I am.* The realization is a bolt of lightning.

She's used to people seeing her as soft, weak. She doesn't eat meat, doesn't lift weights. People often mock her yoga, her vegetarianism, her "hippy" traits. For Catra—who had loved a strong, athletic, protein-powder-fueled wife—to look at Perfuma's lean, plant-based strength and find it desirable…

It's validating on a level she hadn't known she needed. It isn't just about being found attractive; it's about being seen *correctly*. For once, someone isn't seeing the softness and mistaking it for weakness.

They're seeing the disciplined strength that weaves through it, the power that comes from a different, deliberate kind of cultivation.

In Catra's pained, appreciative gaze, the very parts of herself the world often mocks are suddenly, fiercely desirable. She's making space for her, too.

Exhaustion was quickly reclaiming Catra, her eyelids growing heavy. Just before she slipped under, her voice, thin and frayed, cut through the silence. "Pillow," she mumbled, barely audible. "Under my knee. Left side."

Perfuma gently arranged a pillow to support her leg in the precise position that offered the most relief, a small adjustment that spoke volumes of Catra's hard-won knowledge. By the time Perfuma's hands withdrew, Catra had already drifted into a heavy, drug-and-pain-induced doze.

Perfuma retrieved her knitting from her bag in the living room and settled into the chair by the bed. As the adrenaline of the morning

finally faded, it left behind a profound emptiness. The deep fatigue settling into her muscles was nothing compared to the emotional drain.

It took every ounce of her focus to be a pillar of calm—to make her voice gentle, her hands steady, to project an aura of certainty when a cold knot of fear was tightening in her own chest.

The effort of constantly measuring her words, of anticipating need, of holding space for so much pain and fear without flinching, is a weight all its own.

It is a weight she takes on willingly, out of a love that is still startling in its intensity, but a weight nonetheless. Now, alone with the silence, she feels the full cost of it.

The soft click-click of her needles becomes a meditation, a way to slowly knit her own frayed edges back together.

This little sprouting seedling has been hit by an early frost. It will recover, but it needs gentleness and patience. And so, perhaps, does the gardener.

Several hours later, after rest and ice and medication have begun to blunt the sharpest edges of the pain, Catra's croaky voice breaks the comfortable silence. "'Fuma…?"

Perfuma puts her project down immediately, the sound of her name cutting through her reverie. "I'm here."

Catra's eyes are half-lidded with exhaustion, her voice a thready whisper frayed by pain. She gestures weakly with her chin toward the television, a slight grimace tightening the corner of her mouth at the small movement.

"Would you… watch 'Celestial Wars' with me?"

The request feels weightier than a simple distraction. It's hesitant, oddly formal. Perfuma gets the distinct sense this is about far more than just a show.

“Of course,” Perfuma says, her smile soft. She finds the remote on the nightstand. “What’s ‘Celestial Wars’?”

A weak huff of air—the ghost of a laugh. “The worst… show ever made.” She swallows hard, squeezing her eyes shut for a moment before forcing them open. “Adora… loved it.”

The simple statement lands with the force of a revelation. *Celestial Wars*. Adora. The sacred, silly ritual of a shared past. This isn't just any show; this is a direct line to the most profound relationship in Catra's life. It is the key to a sacred vault, an offer to step into the space she and Adora shared.

And in the offering, in the quiet trust that Perfuma would cherish what was inside, Perfuma feels a surge of warmth that chases the lingering chill of her fatigue away. It is, impossibly, a form of healing offered back to her.

“Then I can’t wait to see it,” Perfuma says, her voice thick with an emotion she doesn't try to name, powering on the TV. The screen glows to life, casting a soft blue light in the dim room.

Catra’s instructions are slow, deliberate as she talks Perfuma through the streaming menu.“ The original series… not the shitty remake.”

She is silent for a long moment, then shifts slightly, her breath hitching sharply. She gestures to the pillows. “Could you… help me get propped up? And then… lay with me?”

Perfuma carefully helps her arrange the pillows behind her back, creating a supportive nest that lets her see the screen, and doesn't put too much pressure on her injured pelvis.

Once Catra is settled, Perfuma slides in beside her, reclining against her own stack of pillows so they are lying side-by-side, a solid, warm line of support. Catra hits play on the remote.

Catra doesn't just watch; she narrates in a soft, pain-softened stream. Each observation is punctuated by pauses for shallow

breaths or a brief, suppressed wince, her eyes fixed on the screen that had clearly been the site of so many past shared moments.

“Adora thought… that spaceship looked like a croissant.” The words are followed by a slow, deliberate exhale, as if even laughing in memory was a strain she had to manage. “We paused it and… laughed for ten minutes.”

“She cried here. Every time.” Her voice is fond, weary. She braces her hands against the mattress, trying to shift her weight and lift her hips a fraction, a sharp, stifled gasp revealing her attempt to relieve the pressure on her SI joint. “She'd deny it… but her nose… got all red.”

“This episode… effects budget ran out.” A slight, abortive gesture with her chin that she abandons with a faint grimace. “See that alien? Just… a guy in a rubber suit. Didn't even paint him.”

This isn't a painful exhumation of the past. It's cathartic. It's an act of remembrance and an act of incredible trust. She is giving Perfuma a piece of her most sacred history, not as a replacement, but as an inheritance, inviting her into a ritual that was once exclusively hers and Adora's.

Perfuma listens, her heart swelling. She laughs softly at the stories, her eyes occasionally filling with tears not of grief, but of gratitude. She sees not a ghost, but the outline of the person who helped make Catra who she is.

She is being granted citizenship in a country she has never known, and her only job is to be its most honored and respectful guest.

And as they recline there, propped against the pillows, the weight of Catra’s head eventually comes to rest trustingly on her shoulder. The deep, even rhythm of her breathing slowly settles into the soft purr of sleep.

As she slips deeper into unconsciousness, she shifts, curling instinctively onto her side towards Perfuma, her body seeking the

warmth and safety of the presence beside her.

Perfuma stays perfectly still, not wanting to disturb her. The glow of the starship *Star Runner* flickers against the walls, painting them in soft, shifting shades of blue.

Watching Catra sleep, finally peaceful after the brutal morning, Perfuma knows there is nowhere else she wants to be—she learned the terrifying architecture of Catra's body today, not from a textbook, but from holding its broken weight in her arms, and she would spend a lifetime learning how to better love its design.

Chapter 14: The Cartography of a Body

Chapter Notes

> friends, next week is the LAST CHAPTER. are you ready for it to be over? i'm not, but i'm also really excited for you all to finish this journey with me. <3

The quiet of the last few days has a new texture. It isn't the hollow silence of grief, nor the electric quiet of anticipation that had filled the apartment before Perfuma’s confession.

This is a quiet of convalescence, soft and slow, punctuated by the rustle of blankets, the click of Perfuma’s knitting needles, and the low hum of the television.

Catra is recovering. The white-hot agony of the SI joint dislocation has receded into a deep, grinding ache that is, by her experienced standards, manageable.

Perfuma has become a constant, gentle presence, stopping by for hours each day between her shifts at The Verdant Cup. Catra can see the subtle tension in Perfuma’s shoulders when it's time for her to leave, the faint worry-line between her brows.

“I can stay a little longer,” Perfuma offers, her voice soft with concern, already pulling her phone out to text Scorpia. “I can reschedule my shift. It’s no trouble.”

And it's the truth, Catra knows. It would be no trouble for Perfuma. But it's also no trouble for Catra to be alone.

“Don’t you dare,” Catra says, her tone firm but fond. She reaches out, stilling Perfuma’s hand with her own. “Go to work. I’ll be fine. I’ve survived this long on my own. A few hours is nothing.”

This—the dedicated hours of company, the carefully prepared meals left in the fridge, the tender, unwavering attention—is so far beyond the scope of what she's used to that the stretches of

solitude feel trivial. Surviving alone while Perfuma is at the cafe is a familiar, easy rhythm.

Surviving *with* Perfuma's help feels like a miracle. She's healing faster, the inflammation subdued by consistent care and, she suspects, the sheer power of not being stressed about her own survival for the first time in years.

Perfuma is also becoming more physically demonstrative. It starts in the raw aftermath of the fall—a hand stroking her hair on the floor, a palm warm on her back as she struggles to breathe. And it never stops.

Now, Perfuma absently brushes the hair from Catra's forehead as she reads, her fingers tracing the line of Catra's jaw. She strokes the fur on Catra's arm with a reverence that makes Catra's breath catch, her touch a silent, constant reassurance:

I am here. You are not alone. You are loved.

It's during one of these quiet afternoons, with Catra propped on the couch and Perfuma working on a long, saffron-yellow scarf, that a familiar, firm knock sounds at the door—three sharp raps, efficient and unmistakable. Right on time.

Catra's ears flatten slightly against her skull. She's been steeling herself for Mara's next scheduled visit, but the sound still jolts her.

A tangled knot of emotions tightens in her chest: complicated, ashamed gratitude for the help she desperately needs, a familiar dread for the ordeal, and a new, sharp spike of anxiety.

This is it. Perfuma is about to see another part of her life—not the strength or the defiance, but the bare, humbling need. The dependency.

"It's open," Catra calls, her voice deliberately even, burying the weariness and the tremor of nerves beneath a layer of practiced control.

Mara steps inside, her sharp eyes taking in the scene in a single, efficient sweep: Catra on the couch, the blanket, the cup of tea, and Perfuma in the armchair, her knitting paused mid-stitch.

A flicker of surprise passes over Mara's face, quickly replaced by her usual neutral competence.

"Hey, kid. Heard you took a tumble," Mara says, shrugging out of her jacket and hanging it on the hook by the door with practiced ease.

"Just a little SI nonsense," Catra replies, waving a dismissive hand, though the movement makes her wince. She takes a steadying breath. "Mara, this is Perfuma. Perfuma, Mara. She's my aide."

Perfuma sets her knitting aside and stands, offering a warm smile. "It's so good to finally meet you."

Mara gives a short, approving nod. "Likewise." Her gaze is assessing, but not unkind. She looks from Perfuma's calm presence back to Catra, a silent question in her raised eyebrow. *'Is it okay for her to see this part of your life?'*

Catra meets her gaze and gives a tiny, almost imperceptible nod. *It's okay. She can know. She can see.*

"I'm here for the usual," Mara says, her voice matter-of-fact, breaking the silent communication. "You up for it?"

"Yeah," Catra says, her voice tighter now. She looks at Perfuma, whose expression is one of calm curiosity, untinted by pity. "Mara helps me with things like dressing and showering all the time. She helps with using the bathroom when I need it, when I'm injured like this."

Understanding dawns on Perfuma's face, followed immediately by a profound and gentle compassion that feels like a physical warmth in the room. There's no shock, no awkwardness. Just acceptance.

“Of course,” she says, her voice soft as dandelion fluff. “Whatever you need. I’ll be right here when you’re done.”

She settles back into her armchair and picks up her knitting, the gentle *click-click* of the needles a clear and unpressuring signal that she will hold this space for them, a peaceful anchor in the storm of vulnerability.

The trust Catra feels in that moment is a solid thing in her chest, warming her from the inside out.

The trip to the bathroom is, as always, a brutal negotiation with a body in revolt. It's a slow, painful shuffle supported by Mara’s strong frame, every step a fresh jolt of lightning through her pelvis.

The process itself is a humiliating ballet of agony and weakness and assistance that she has long since learned to divorce from her sense of self. It's maintenance. It's biology. It's miserable.

When Mara helps her back into the living room, Catra is trembling, her face pale and drawn with exhaustion. She looks… fragile. Beaten. Every ounce of her energy has been spent on performing her body’s basic functions.

Perfuma’s heart clenches at the sight, but she keeps her expression a placid lake, her energy calm and still. She sees the ghost of shame trying to cloud Catra’s eyes and she silently wills it away. *There is no shame here. Not with me.*

Mara helps Catra settle back onto the couch with an expert’s touch. “All set. You’re good for a few days.” She squeezes Catra’s shoulder lightly, a gesture of deep, unspoken camaraderie, then turns to Perfuma.

“It was good to meet you.” Her tone is professional, but her eyes hold a deeper meaning, a quick glint of approval: *You're gentle with her. You make her feel safe.*

After Mara leaves, the apartment settles back into quiet. Perfuma doesn't mention what had just happened. She doesn't ask invasive questions or offer hollow platitudes.

She simply rises, brings Catra a fresh glass of cool water, and says, “The color in this scarf is reminding me of sunshine. It feels hopeful.”

And just like that, the moment passes. The shame has nowhere to land, no purchase in the face of such unshakeable, matter-of-fact acceptance.

Catra feels the last of her tension ease. Perfuma’s compassion isn't a thing she offers; it's the very air she breathes, and Catra is learning to let herself breathe it as well.

The fortress of Catra’s self-reliance has allowed someone past the outermost wall, not as an invader, but as a honored guest. And the fortress has not fallen. It has grown stronger.

Two days later, the inevitable finally happens. Catra is shifting on the couch, trying to find a more comfortable position, when she feels it—the familiar, nauseating slide and sudden, shocking *clunk* deep within her pelvis.

The sound is audible, a thick, wet pop of bone and ligament snapping back into place.

A raw, strangled cry tears from Catra’s throat, her body seizing up, eyes flying wide with the shock of the pain that always accompanies the reduction.

Perfuma, who has been watering a small succulent on the windowsill, spins around at the sound. She sees Catra’s back arch, her face contort in a rictus of agony, hears the awful, unnatural noise.

Her breath vanishes. For one frozen, heart-stopping second, her mind goes utterly blank, wiped clean by the sight and sound of

Catra's suffering. To Perfuma, still unfamiliar with the specific horrors of Catra’s condition, that sound and that pain can only mean something terrible has happened.

“Catra!” The cry tears from her as she rushed forward, her voice strangling into a higher octave of panic. Her hands flutter over Catra’s body, wanting to help, terrified to cause more harm. “What happened? Are you okay? Did it go out again?”

Catra’s breath is still coming in ragged pants, but the excruciating spike is already receding into the familiar, welcome ache of alignment. She forces her eyes to focus on Perfuma’s terrified face.

“I'm okay,” she manages to grit out. “It's okay. The joint just went back into place.”

Perfuma’s face goes pale. Her hands, which had been fluttering near Catra, still and then rise uncertainly to her own mouth. “That sound…” she stammers, her voice barely a whisper. “The way you… I thought…” The words die as the adrenaline crash hits her, leaving her visibly trembling.

The fear that had gripped her—the image of Catra’s injury worsening, of a bone breaking, of another week of immobilizing pain—releases its hold, and in its wake comes a wave of pure, helpless sorrow.

A sob breaks from her chest, and then another. She brings her hands to her face, tears welling and spilling over. “I thought something terrible had happened. Oh, Catra, it sounded so awful.”

Catra, now mostly present again, watches in stunned silence as Perfuma cries. The pain is a dull throb now, secondary to the strange, aching tenderness unfolding in front of her.

Adora’s love had been a fierce, protective fire; she would have been a force of nature, solving the problem, or trying to make Catra laugh to distract her from the hurt.

Mara’s is a steady, pragmatic support. But this raw, unfiltered grief? This is a heart breaking *for* her, weeping *with* her, and it's entirely new.

“Hey, no, don’t—” Catra says, her voice soft. She shifts gingerly, making room on the couch. “Come here. I’m okay. It’s okay.”

Perfuma sits, still wiping at her eyes, looking utterly embarrassed. “I’m so sorry,” she hiccups. “I’m being so silly. You’re the one in pain and I’m the one crying.”

“You’re not silly,” Catra says firmly, putting an arm around her and drawing her close. Perfuma melts into the embrace, burying her face in Catra’s shoulder.

“I’m the one who should be sorry. I should have warned you. It always hurts like a bitch when it goes back. The sound is gross. I forget that it’s… a lot to witness.”

Perfuma shakes her head against Catra’s shoulder. “It just scared me so much. That there’s nothing I can do to stop that pain from happening again.”

She takes a shuddering breath. “I feel so selfish, needing you to comfort me about your own injury.”

Catra holds her tighter, her voice a low rumble. “Perfuma, look at me.” Reluctantly, Perfuma lifts her head. Catra’s gaze is soft, her thumb brushing away a stray tear on Perfuma’s cheek.

“I’ve been dealing with this nonsense for more than twenty years. It’s miserable, but I know how to handle it. This is all new for you. Of course it’s scary and upsetting. You’ve been so brave, taking care of me. You’re allowed to be scared.”

Perfuma’s breath hitches. The understanding in Catra’s voice, the softness—it's a side of her she’s only seen glimpses of.

To have it directed at her, to comfort *her*, unlocks something deep in Perfuma’s chest. The last of her tears dry up, replaced by a

swelling wave of pure, overwhelming love.

She leans forward slowly, giving Catra every opportunity to pull away, and presses her lips to Catra’s in a kiss that's achingly tender. It's a kiss of gratitude, of reassurance, a silent *thank you for seeing me.*

Catra accepts the kiss, expecting the gentle pressure to end. But it doesn't. Perfuma’s lips move against hers with a new intention, a slow, building passion. Her slender hand comes up to cup Catra’s face, her thumb stroking the soft fur of her cheekbone.

The kiss intensifies, and Perfuma’s other hand begins to roam, tracing the line of Catra’s shoulder, the curve of her hip through the soft fabric of her sweatpants, a slow, deliberate mapping.

A low purr starts in Catra’s throat, vibrating against Perfuma’s mouth. The shift from comforting to desiring is dizzying, electric. Perfuma pulls back just enough to speak, her eyes dark, her breath coming a little faster.

“Is this okay?” she whispers, her voice husky. The question hangs in the air, meant for her heart and her hurting body alike.

Catra’s own desire, so long dormant, roars to life at the question, at the exquisite care behind it. The purr deepens in her chest, a rumble of pure contentment and want. “I’m okay,” she breathes, the words soft but certain. “We’re okay. Please, don’t stop.”

Perfuma doesn't hesitate. She kisses her again, deeper this time, and Catra’s mouth opens beneath hers, letting her in. A tiny, breathless whimper escapes Catra’s throat—a sound of pure, overwhelmed sensation.

The kiss itself is devastatingly familiar—the smooth, hot slide of a human tongue against her own. It's an act woven from a lifetime of experience with Adora.

But it's also entirely new. This is Perfuma’s rhythm, Perfuma’s taste—herbal tea and kindness and a sharp, desperate want that

is all her own.

The collision of memory and newness sends a jolt straight to her core. A raw, aching moan tears from her throat, lost against Perfuma's mouth.

She hears the ragged hitch of Perfuma's breath, feels it hot and urgent against her mouth, feels the slight tremble in the hand skating up her side.

Emboldened, Catra lets her own hands explore, learning the geography of a body so different from Adora's.

Her palms map the new terrain: the sharp planes of her cheekbones, the soft skin of her neck, the surprising, solid strength of her arms.

Finally, one hand skims up Perfuma's torso, over the soft, worn cotton of her blouse, to cup the elegant swell of her breast. Her palm finds a perfect fit against her, the softness yielding to her touch even through the fabric, a delicate weight that makes her breath catch.

A shudder racks Perfuma's frame, and her kisses turns desperate, almost frantic.

Catra feels the stiff peak of Perfuma's nipple against her palm and, claws meticulously retracted, she strokes it through the fabric with a fingertip.

She gives it a gentle, insistent pinch between her thumb and forefinger, a soft tug. A broken, ragged cry tears from Perfuma's throat. She jerks back, her eyes wide and wild with hunger, her lips swollen.

"I want to touch you," she gasps out, her voice thick with a desire Catra has never heard there before. "I want to make you feel good. Is that okay?"

The question hangs in the air, heavy and real. Catra's mind, hazy with lust, struggled to catch up. *Is* she ready? This is it. The point of no return.

Her eyes drop to Perfuma's hand, the elegant, slender fingers that plant seeds and stir tea and stroke her fur with such tenderness. She wants those hands on her. Everywhere.

A sudden, clear thought slices through the haze of arousal. Perfuma doesn't know. She's been so focused on pain and care and confession that she forgot a fundamental piece of herself that needs to be shared. A familiar calm settles over her, built from a lifetime of repetition. She knows how to do this. She is certain, bone-deep, that this woman will not falter.

She holds Perfuma's hand in both of her own, brings it to her mouth, and presses a soft, reverent kiss to the fingertips. "I want that too," she rasps. "I want you to make me feel good."

She takes a steadying breath, her gaze locking with Perfuma's. "There's something I have to tell you first."

Perfuma goes still, her expression one of open, attentive patience. Waiting. Listening.

"I'm trans," Catra says, the words feeling both foreign and familiar on her tongue.

"I have a penis. I should've probably told you a while ago, but it's been a long time since I had to tell anyone and I… kind of forgot it was a thing I needed to do."

She tries to smile, but it feels weak. "If it's a problem for you, I need to know now. Before we go any further."

Reading humans is always harder—no expressive ears, no tail to give them away, but she watches Perfuma's face, looking for a subtle flicker of disappointment, a shift in energy, a polite withdrawal. What she sees instead makes her breath catch.

There's no disgust. No hesitation. There is only a deepening of the love in Perfuma’s gaze, a fierce, protective desire, and a look of such profound acceptance that Catra feels her own eyes begin to sting.

“Thank you for telling me,” Perfuma says, her voice earnest and clear. “It doesn’t change anything about how I feel about you, Catra. You’re the same beautiful woman I’ve loved since the day I first saw you.”

She leans forward, pressing another soft, firm kiss to Catra’s lips. “Tell me if you need to be touched or not touched a certain way, okay?”

The relief that washes through Catra is so potent it feels like a drug. She nods, words failing her.

Perfuma resumes kissing her, a claiming, passionate kiss that leaves no room for doubt. As their tongues tangle, her hand, which has been resting on Catra’s thigh, begins to move.

It slides upward, over the curve of her hip, and then up further, until her palm is cupping the small but unmistakable bulge in Catra’s soft sweatpants.

Catra’s breath hitches. Perfuma let out a satisfied, hungry moan against her mouth, feeling the stiffening heat of Catra’s arousal through the thin fabric.

She rests her hand there for a few precious beats, a claiming, then begins to explore. She presses down gently.

“Ah!” Catra’s hips jerk upward instinctively, the movement instantly tempered by the deep, bruised ache in her pelvis.

A soft whine escapes her—a sound as much of frustration as pleasure—as she carefully ruts into Perfuma's palm, grinding not with abandon, but with measured, desperate need into the pressure.

Perfuma rubs her hand back and forth, stars bursting behind Catra's eyelids from the friction. She squeezes gently, and Catra's breath leaves her in a ragged pant. All the while, Perfuma never breaks their kiss, her lips moving softly against Catra's between murmured reassurances and gentle sighs.

"I like to have my balls played with, too," Catra whispers, her voice raw against Perfuma's mouth.

Perfuma's hand trails down, her fingers gently cradling the small, delicate shape of Catra's testicles, held tight against her body by her panties.

"And behind my balls, my perineum," Catra continues, guiding Perfuma's exploration with her words. "I really like pressure there."

Perfuma pauses, absorbing the information, filing it away as she leans in to kiss Catra again. Then her hand drops lower, her fingers tentatively seeking the spot Catra described.

Her touch is questioning, a gentle press here, then there, mapping the hidden landscape through the soft cotton.

"A little lower," Catra murmurs into the kiss, arching slightly with a ragged, almost pained groan. "There. Right there."

Perfuma stills her hand, focusing on the area beneath her fingertips.

"Harder," Catra instructs, her voice a strained whisper against Perfuma's lips. "You'll be able to feel it swelling and tensing."

Perfuma pushes a little deeper with her fingers, and—oh. There's a firmness, a distinct, swollen knot, deep inside. She maps the hard tension with her fingertips, an unfamiliar root system of pleasure she desperately wants to understand.

She feels a little out of her depth, wishing she knew more about the anatomy of this beautiful body.

But then she sees Catra’s cock twitch visibly in her sweats, and she feels a corresponding tense-and-release in the spot she was pressing on.

“Oh. God, like that,” Catra breathes, her voice thick and fraying with need.

Perfuma experiments until she finds the rhythm that makes Catra fall apart—slow, heavy, insistent circles pressed into that secret, swelling place while Catra writhes and grinds against her hand.

Perfuma rests her other hand on top of the stiff, dampening bulge, feeling the evidence of Catra’s arousal soaking through the fabric.

Electricity shoots through Catra at the feeling of Perfuma’s hand on her wetness. A fantasy flashes, vivid and hot: Perfuma’s slender fingers, glistening with her. She breaks the kiss, her gold and blue eyes dark with need.

“I want you to touch me,” Catra pants, her voice rough. “I want to see your hand wrapped around my cock, stroking me.”

Perfuma is flushed, her own breath coming in fast little pants. Without breaking eye contact, she slides off the couch and kneels on the floor between Catra’s legs.

It's an act of such worship that Catra’s heart stutters. Perfuma hooks her fingers in the waistband of Catra’s sweats and panties and pulls them down in one smooth motion.

Catra’s stiff, red cock springs free, bobbing in the cool air. It's small, curved slightly upward, utterly exposed.

Perfuma’s gaze is one of pure, unadulterated awe. “Oh, Catra,” she breathes, her voice full of reverence. “You’re so beautiful.” Her eyes drink in the sight, and the words slip out, affectionate and unfiltered. “What a perfect little cock.”

A beat of silence. Then, a flicker of panic in Perfuma's eyes as her own words register. "I— oh. I'm sorry, was that— I didn't mean to —"

Catra cuts her off with a breathy, strained laugh. "It's okay. Seriously." She holds Perfuma's worried gaze, her own eyes dark with desire. "I like it. I like that it's small."

The memory arrives, visceral and unbidden: *the slick, wet sounds of Adora's hand stroking her, fast and sure. Adora's voice, a low growl against her ear, "You like that? You like when I play with your pretty little kitten cock?"*

Catra, past the point of words, can only whine—a high, desperate, keening sound—as her hips stutter. "Yeah? You gonna come for me?"

A smirk tugs at her lips. "And I *really* like when my partner talks about how small it is. So trust me, you're not offending me."

The profound relief that washes over Perfuma's face is almost comical. The new, playful confidence returns instantly, her worry replaced by a sultry smile.

"Good to know," she purs, her fingers ghosting along Catra's inner thigh. "So… you want my pretty hands on this sweet little thing?"

A full-body shudder racks Catra. Her head falls back against the couch with a thud. "Fuck. Yes. Please, 'Fuma. Touch me."

Perfuma obeys. Her grip is warm, sure. Catra is throbbing in her hand, her cock both rock-hard and impossibly soft-skinned. The tip is already slick with wetness.

Perfuma gives a few experimental strokes, her eyes fixed on Catra's face, reading every micro-expression. She moves her hand down to fondle Catra's furry balls, to press on that swollen, magical spot underneath them.

She revels in the desperate trembling of Catra’s thighs, the whimpers and whines she can't suppress.

She finds a devastating rhythm: one hand stroking Catra’s cock, the other alternating between cupping her balls and applying that deep, perfect pressure.

Catra is coming apart, her claws digging into the couch fabric, her tail thumping a frantic, rhythmic beat against the cushion.

Perfuma stops stroking for a moment. She trails a single, curious finger through the slick wetness beading at Catra’s tip.

A choked, guttural noise escapes Catra. Her eyes snap open, wide and fixated on Perfuma’s hand, her mouth slightly agape. A sound that's half-purr, half-growl rumbles deep in her chest.

Oh, she really liked that, Perfuma thinks, a thrill arcing through her. *Does she… like the messiness?*

Driven by the reaction, she begins stroking again, using Catra’s own slickness to smooth her way, coating Catra’s shaft, her own hand, until her fingers are glistening.

Catra falls completely silent aside from the raw animal purr-growl vibrating through her, her entire world reduced to that sensation.

Perfuma looks up from between Catra’s legs, her gaze dark and heavy. “You like getting me all messy?” she murmurs, her voice a husky thing.

Catra gives a sharp, frantic nod, her breath hitching.

“Tell me,” Perfuma urges softly, her thumb circling Catra’s tip, spreading more slickness. “What does it do to you? Seeing my hand like this?”

A ragged groan tears from Catra’s throat. “Fuck. It makes me want to…” she pants, her hips giving an involuntary jerk, “…want to mark you. Cover you in it. Just… *mine*.”

A jolt of understanding hits Perfuma. *Marking. It's not just about the mess. It's about possession. It's about claiming.*

A dark, possessive fire lights in Perfuma's eyes. She doesn't break eye contact as she swipes two fingers through the slickness, brings them to her lips, and slowly, deliberately, draws them into her mouth.

Thump. Thump. THUMP. Catra's tail hammers the couch cushions. Her eyes are blown wide, pupils swallowing blue and gold.

Perfuma lowers herself, leaning in until her face is nestled between Catra's thighs. Her breath ghosts over Catra's cock, a promise on wet, heated skin.

"Do you want me to make you come like this?" Her voice is a whisper, thick and wanting. "Make me yours?"

Catra can only nod, her expression one of disbelieving, overwhelmed need. A tiny, broken sound escapes her—a half-suppressed sob that's pure emotion.

Leaning in, Perfuma runs her flattened tongue up the length of Catra's cock from base to tip in one slow lick. She gives the slick head a soft, closed-mouth kiss. A string of wetness connects her lips to Catra's cock.

Maintaining fierce eye contact, she drags the slick, velvety head of Catra's cock over the plush swell of her bottom lip, painting a glistening trail. She smears it across her cheekbone, down to the corner of her jaw, the air cooling the wet path left behind.

Not content, she opens her mouth, lets the tip slap against her waiting tongue—once, twice—a wet, obscene sound that hangs in the air between them.

She guides it, lets it tap lightly against her chin. It's a playful, filthy baptism, and she is the willing acolyte, the sacred vessel, utterly devoted to her worship.

“Fuck, Perfuma! I’m so close, please!” Catra begs, her voice cracking, her hips starting to stutter.

The playful worship melts into a single-minded focus on Catra’s pleasure. Perfuma closes her lips around the head of Catra’s cock. She hollows her cheeks, sucking gently, and begins to bob her head. Her tongue works the sensitive underside, and her hand fondles Catra’s furry balls, now drawn up tight.

She can hear the tears in Catra’s ragged breaths, the little whimpers of overstimulation and bliss, and it only makes her more determined to wring every last bit of pleasure from her.

It doesn't take long. Catra’s claws tangle in Perfuma’s golden hair. “Ah! Ah! Ah!” The sounds punch out of her, involuntary. Her body bows, a wire pulled taut, every muscle seizing as the climax roars through her. A series of sharp, percussive *pops* echo from her spine, ribcage, shoulders, hips—the very architecture of her body protesting the unbearable intensity of the pleasure.

Perfuma feels the throbbing pulse on her tongue, the faint, salty taste of her release, thin and not overwhelming. The warmth spreading in her mouth as Catra’s hips stutter against her. She doesn't stop, stroking and sucking and fondling through each wave of the climax, until the last shudder passes through Catra and she collapses back into the cushions with a final, shattered sigh. Only then does Perfuma gently release her, kissing the oversensitive tip.

Catra's eyes flutter open, hazy and spent. Perfuma makes eye contact, holds it, and deliberately swallows.

The image sears itself into Catra's vision. A fresh, sharp shudder runs through her body at the sight—a jolt of possessiveness and raw awe that leaves her breathless.

Carefully, Perfuma climbs up into Catra’s lap, supporting her own weight. Catra’s softening cock bumps against her thigh, leaving a final, slick smear. Perfuma leans in and kisses her.

Catra meets her halfway, kissing her deeply, tasting herself on Perfuma's tongue. "'Fuma," she breathes when they part, her voice wrecked and thick. "That was… amazing."

She sniffles, wiping hastily at her eyes with the back of her hand before rolling her shoulders with a wince and a soft grunt. "Sorry about the… structural noises."

Perfuma's eyes soften. A gentle, reassuring smile touches her lips. She leans in and presses a soft kiss to Catra's damp cheek. "You have nothing to apologize for," she murmurs. "I love all of you. Every part."

Catra lets out a long, shuddery breath, the last of the tension leaving her. "Okay."

Perfuma nuzzles against her, her giggle a light, joyous sound. "I'm so glad it felt good for you. I really wanted to show you how much you mean to me."

When Perfuma pulls back, she sees Catra's eyes are shiny with more unshed tears, a watery, overwhelmed smile on her face.

"You did," Catra says, her voice small. She sniffles again, the vulnerable sound stark in the quiet room. "It's been so long since anyone made me feel that good. Thank you, Perfuma."

She hesitates, then adds, shyly, "You… mean a lot to me too, you know."

They sit for a long moment in the hazy, contented afterglow, both acutely aware of the profound line they have just crossed.

Finally, Catra shifts with a wince. "As much as I hate to ruin the atmosphere, I'm going to die if I sit on this couch any longer."

"Oh!" Perfuma hops up out of her lap with an eager energy that is utterly endearing. "Of course! Whatever you need."

Catra huffs a laugh. “I think I just need to lay down for a while. And Perfuma…” Her face softens, vulnerability returning. “Would you… stay here, with me, tonight? I don’t want to be alone after that.”

Perfuma’s expression melts into pure kindness and love. “Of course I’ll stay, sweetheart. Maybe I can order us takeout and we can have a quiet night in.”

Later that night, stomachs full and wrapped in a comfortable silence broken only by the melodramatic dialogue of *Celestial Wars*, Catra curls herself around Perfuma in her bed. As she drifts towards sleep, she marvels at the tectonic shifts in her life.

After five years of the same, gray landscape of grief, the last few months have brought startling, vibrant color. She has a life to live again.

In the dim light, she sees her. Adora’s spectral figure, sitting on the edge of the bed next to a sleeping Perfuma. She's translucent, made of memory and starlight, but her smile is real. She makes eye contact with Catra. Her eyes are happy. Relieved.

'I’m so proud of you, Catra.' The words aren't heard; they're felt, settling in Catra’s heart like a truth she’s always known. *'I’m **so** proud of you for not giving up. I’m so happy you keep me in your heart and I’m so happy you’ve opened up your heart to her.*' Her gaze drifts to Perfuma, full of tenderness.

'I’m always going to be with you. I love you.'

A deep, peaceful warmth spreads through Catra’s chest. Her heart, held gently by the past and the present, is warm, full, and finally, finally safe.

I love you too, Princess, she thinks, her consciousness fading. *Goodnight.*

Chapter 15: To Be Full Again

Chapter Notes

> I can't believe it's the last chapter! I cried so much writing this...
>
> Also it's a bit late because this might be the longest chapter of anything i've written? almost 6k words. I had a lot to say!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The park is no longer a battlefield. It is a landmark.

Catra walks its paths with a gait that is no less pained, but significantly less guarded. Her cane taps a familiar rhythm against the pavement, a metronome measuring a life that is slowly, incrementally, expanding.

She doesn't count dandelions or cracks in the path anymore. She simply exists within the noise. The shrieking children, the squabbling ducks, the rustle of leaves in the willow that no longer holds the power to gut her—it's the soundtrack of a world that was, finally, just a world. Not a minefield of memory, nor a gauntlet of agony.

She pauses by the pond. Waddles is there, one foot dragging, waddling past with stubborn persistence. Catra's lips quirk into a faint smile.

"Still a menace," she mutters to herself, the words carried away by the breeze.

'He's got determination. You have to give him that.'

The voice comes from beside the willow tree. Leaning against its trunk, translucent and shimmering faintly in the dappled light, is Adora. She's smiling, her arms crossed, looking exactly as she had the last time Catra saw her alive.

Catra doesn’t jump. Her heart doesn’t even clench. She just glances over, her ear twitching. “He’s a weird little duck. You always did like the stubborn ones.”

'I guess I have a type,' Adora says, her grin softening.

“Shut up,” Catra says, but there’s no bite to it. She looks back at the duck, now trying to intimidate a breadcrumb away from a sparrow. “You’re not funny.”

'You’re smiling.'

“I am not.”

'You are. It’s weird. Looks good on you, though.'

They stand in comfortable silence for a moment, watching the duck’s futile campaign.

'Heading to the café?' Adora asks, her tone light.

“Yeah. Perfuma’s there.”

'Nice. Grab me a croissant.'

“You’re a ghost. You can’t eat.”

'Not with that attitude I can't!' Adora returns, grinning. *'I can live vicariously. It’s the thought that counts.'*

Adora pushes off the tree, her form beginning to fade, blending into the sunlight filtering through the leaves. *'See you around, Catra.'*

“Yeah, yeah,” Catra says, waving a hand vaguely in her direction. “Don’t be a stranger.”

Adora’s form dissolves into a warm shimmer, leaving behind only the rustle of the willow leaves.

Catra shakes her head, but the faint, real smile remains. Her solitude no longer feels like a sentence. It’s a quiet space where she can let Adora’s ghost hover—where the past can tease her, and the present can hold her, and neither one demands all of her at once.

At the edge of the park, she hesitates. The Verdant Cup isn't just a destination anymore; it's a destination she's *expected* at.

The bell above the door chimes its familiar, wooden note. The assault of smells—rich coffee, damp earth, sweet pastry—is no longer an assault. It's a welcome, a sensory embrace she now associated with safety.

Scorpia is behind the counter today, her large frame a comforting pillar of stability. Her face breaks into a wide, genuine smile the second Catra shuffles in.

“Catra! Hey! Good to see you out and about,” she booms, her voice dialed down to what passed for an ‘indoor voice’ for her.

She doesn't ask how Catra's feeling. She knows better. She simply acknowledges her presence with a warmth that is becoming familiar.

Perfuma appears from the back, a tray of freshly watered herbs in her hands. Her face lights up like the sun breaking through clouds, a sight that still, inexplicably, makes Catra’s breath catch.

“You made it,” she says, her voice warm and soft. She already has *her* mug in her hand, sliding it across the counter without a word. Black coffee. Steam rising in a gentle curl.

And then, she does something new. She turns to the pastry case, selects a perfect golden-brown almond croissant, and slides it toward Catra on a small plate. "On the house," she says, the words shaped like a key fitting into a stubborn lock. Not a question. Not charity. Just breakfast, between people who know each other. "You'll like this one - the almond paste isn't too sweet."

Catra's ears flick backward, then forward again. The instinctive protest - *I don't need your handouts* - dissolves as she meets Perfuma's steady gaze. There's no pity in those green-flecked eyes, just that quiet certainty that drives Catra half-mad with its persistence. This isn't about weakness. It's Perfuma's way of saying *I see you* without words, of weaving another thread between them.

"Thanks," she mutters, testing the word in her mouth like a foreign spice. It doesn't scrape her throat like she expects it to.

Almost on autopilot, she fumbles for her wallet to pay for the coffee, but Perfuma’s hand covers hers gently, stilling the movement. “I said it’s on the house.” Her smile is unwavering, a mix of tenderness and gentle firmness.

Scorpia gives a small, approving nod from where she is polishing the espresso machine, her attention studiously elsewhere.

“Let me get that for you,” Perfuma says, picking up the plate and Catra’s mug.

She follows as Catra slowly navigates to her usual table, waiting patiently as she settles into the chair and gets her cane leaned safely against the wall. Only then does Perfuma set the coffee and croissant before her.

It’s a simple, seamless act of care that speaks volumes.

Catra is a regular. People know her. The man in the bright blue bike helmet, waiting for his order, catches her eye and gives a friendly, unassuming nod.

Unencumbered, Catra manages a sharper, more confident dip of her chin in return. A silent, reciprocal acknowledgment. *I see you, too.* Progress, measured not in miles, but in millimeters. It is enough.

She takes a bite of the croissant. It is buttery, flaky, and devastatingly good. It practically melts on her tongue. Her body,

so used to subsistence-level protein shakes and bitter coffee, sings a faint, surprised hymn of gratitude.

She eats slowly, savoring each small, deliberate bite, watching the life of the café swirl around her. She is no longer a spectator behind glass; she is a part of the ecosystem.

Later, at home, curled together on the couch, the afternoon sun painting warm stripes on the floor, Catra finds her Switch. The cheerful jingle of Catra's Switch is a familiar sound now, a portal to a world where she can run without her joints screaming, where her hands don't betray her.

"What are you up to?" Perfuma asks, her head resting on Catra's shoulder, her fingers tracing absent patterns in the fur of Catra's forearm. The touch is casual in a way that still surprises Catra—not tentative like it was in the beginning, not heavy with meaning like during her worst pain days. Just existing, warm and constant.

"Weeding," Catra says, her thumbs moving clumsily but with purpose. She navigates to the beach, to the small, crooked cottage nestled near the pixelated sea. *Player 2's House*.

"That's Adora's," she explains softly, her voice devoid of the usual sharp edge that comes with talking about the past. It's just a fact now. A cherished one.

"I pull the weeds around it. Every day. It's a thing I have to do. Like… if I keep it clean, it's like I'm still taking care of her. Still keeping a space for her."

Perfuma watches the screen, her expression one of deep understanding. She doesn't offer platitudes. She simply listens. "A ritual," she says finally. "A way to keep the connection alive."

"Yeah. A ritual." Catra pulls a few more digital weeds. "And I plant lilies. Her favorite." She opens the mailbox. "And I write her letters. Just… telling her about my day. The pain. The silence. You."

She shakes her head, a faint, self-conscious smile on her lips. “It’s probably stupid.”

“It’s not stupid,” Perfuma murmurs, pressing a kiss to her shoulder. “It’s beautiful. You keep a line open. You talk to her.”

Catra is quiet for a moment, absorbing that. She’s never thought of it that way. She’s always seen it as a symptom of her brokenness. Perfuma hands her a new lens, and through it, the act looks like resilience. It looks like love.

Then, without closing the game, Catra says, “Sit up for a sec?” She waits for Perfuma to adjust, then leans into her, holding the Switch between them.

She opens the construction app. Down by the café she’d built, she starts placing a new plot. A small, charming cottage with a flower box under the window, a little monstera plant by the door.

“What’s that?” Perfuma asks, her voice soft with curiosity.

“That’s… yours. If you want it.” Catra’s ears flatten slightly, a nervous tell. The offer feels huge. “I thought… maybe you could help me with the weeding sometimes. With… all of it.”

Perfuma’s breath hitches. She wraps her arms a little tighter around Catra and presses a long, heartfelt kiss to her temple. “I would love nothing more,” she whispers, her voice thick with emotion.

She holds Catra a little closer. “It would be an honor to help you tend to it.”

The simplicity of the pixelated gesture holds a universe of meaning. This wasn't an offer made lightly. It was an invitation into the most sacred, guarded space in Catra's world—the digital heart of her grief and her love for Adora. She wasn't being asked to visit; she was being asked to stay. To become a caretaker of the memory, a co-tender of the love that still grew there.

Not to replace, but to join. To help care for the love that still grows there.

The ‘date night’ is Perfuma’s idea, planned with the meticulous care of a gardener nurturing a rare, precious bloom. Catra watches from her perch on a kitchen stool, her cane propped within reach, as Perfuma moves with a fluid grace that is both enthralling and utterly foreign.

She chops vibrant bell peppers and broccoli with swift, precise cuts, presses firm cubes of tofu between paper towels to dry them, whisks a sauce that smells of ginger, garlic, and a hint of citrus.

Catra’s nose wrinkles. “You’re sure about this… tofu stuff? It looks like little white sponges. Adora tried to get me to eat it once. It was like chewing on flavorless rubber.”

Perfuma laughs, a light, chiming sound that filled the kitchen. “I’m sure. Trust me. It’s all about the sauce and how you cook it. Adora was probably boiling it. I’m going to pan-fry it so it gets crispy.”

She pours a splash of oil into a hot pan. The oil shimmers, and she adds the tofu. The kitchen fills with a satisfying sizzle and an aroma that is actually… promising. Catra watches, skeptical but intrigued, as Perfuma tosses the tofu until it's golden brown, then adds the vegetables, stir-frying them until they’re bright and crisp-tender before pouring the sauce over everything in a cloud of aromatic steam that makes Catra’s stomach rumble in a way it hasn’t in years.

The table is set with actual placemats. A single candle flickers in the center. A bottle of white wine stands open between two glasses, breathing. Perfuma serves the stir-fry over fluffy rice, creating a colorful, fragrant mound on Catra’s plate that looks like a work of art.

Catra pokes at a cube of crispy tofu with her fork, her expression wary. Adora had been a fitness nut, her diet a regimented, joyless fuel of baked chicken, plain rice, and chalky protein powder—macros calculated to the gram for optimal muscle gain.

For Catra, eating has been a necessity, a chore performed to sustain a body that is constantly failing. This feels… different. This feels intentional. Celebratory.

She sees the hopeful, slightly anxious look in Perfuma's eyes, the way she's barely touching her own food, waiting for Catra's verdict. She takes a breath, spears the tofu and a piece of pepper, and takes a bite.

She chews, considering. The textures are new and delightful—the crispy, golden exterior of the tofu giving way to a soft, almost creamy inside, the crisp snap of the vegetables. The flavors are complex, savory and slightly sweet and tangy all at once.

"What do you think?" Perfuma asks, her fork hovering mid-air.

"It's… really good," Catra admits, genuinely surprised. She takes another bite. Then another. Her body, so chronically starved for anything nutritious, seems to wake up and pay attention.

The dense fog of perpetual hunger and exhaustion—the kind that comes from a body using all its energy just to manage pain—lifts slightly. She feels a clarity, a faint thrum of actual, clean energy. She *gets* it.

This isn't just fuel. This is… care. This is balance. This is love, translated into something she can consume.

She can only finish half, her stomach unused to such volume and richness, but she feels stronger for it. Healthier.

The wine, shared between them, leaves a soft, warm looseness in her limbs, a pleasant hum in her head that mutes the ever-present orchestra of aches just enough to feel like a person and not a collection of symptoms.

Later, in the soft, candlelit glow of the bedroom, Perfuma asks, "Should we put on *Celestial Wars*?"

Catra hesitates, her ears pinning back slightly. The offer is kind, a continuation of their new, shared ritual. But it isn't what she wants. Not tonight.

The warmth of the food, the wine, the profound sense of being seen and cared for, have unlocked a deeper, more terrifying want.

A space that has been empty and locked shut for five years, that she is finally, desperately ready to open. To be filled again.

She takes a shaky breath, her glass of wine trembling slightly in her hand. "Perfuma…"

Perfuma turns from lighting a second candle, her expression instantly shifting to one of attentive care. "What is it, sweetheart?"

"I'm ready." The words are a whisper, but they hang in the air, charged and immense, seeming to suck all the sound from the room. "I want you inside of me."

The silence that follows is profound. Perfuma's eyes widen, not with shock, but with the deep, humbling, terrifying understanding of what is being offered.

This is more than sex. This is the key to the innermost sanctuary, the most vulnerable part of the fortress.

She knows the ghost that resides here. She knows the weight of the trust being placed in her hands, a weight that feels both sacred and immense.

A memory surfaces for them both—a different afternoon, tangled together on the living room couch, speaking in hushed, earnest tones.

Perfuma is the one to find the courage first, her voice barely above a whisper. "Can you tell me… what feels good for you?"

Catra tenses, her tail giving a nervous flick before she stills it. The words don't come easily. "I like… touch. A lot." She swallows, forcing herself to be more specific, her gaze fixed on Perfuma's shoulder. "Your hands… your mouth. Pretty much… anywhere." A shaky breath. "Especially… inside."

Perfuma's hand find her knee, a warm, steadying weight. "Inside," she repeats softly, a promise in the word.

"It's… the main thing, for me," Catra admits, the vulnerability making her voice rough. "Fingers are… good. But being… full. With a strap. That's… different. It makes me feel… anchored. Like I'm home."

"I want to make you feel that way," Perfuma murmurs, her thumb stroking a gentle arc on Catra's knee. "Can you show me how? Tell me what to do?"

"There's a… spot," Catra says, guiding Perfuma's hand to her own lower abdomen, mapping the internal geography on the exterior. "Called the prostate. It's like… a spongy little swell, right about here. Curling your fingers up towards there… makes me see stars."

She hesitates for a beat, her breath catching as she imagines the fuller, more complete pressure. Her voice drops, rougher. "And… with the strap… it's the same. The head has to hit that spot." A shaky exhale. "That's what makes me fall apart."

"What size is… comfortable for you?" Perfuma asks, her voice earnestly practical, as if taking notes for a sacred exam.

The question hangs in the air. Instead of answering, Catra's resolve solidifies. She leads Perfuma to the bedroom and to the bedside table. Opening the drawer is an act of immense courage. Inside lies the harness and toy—a relic of a profound love.

Perfuma does not look away. She regards it with a quiet, solemn respect before turning her gaze back to Catra, her attention narrowing until the rest of the world falls away.

"Thank you," she whispers, her voice full of awe. "Thank you for trusting me with this."

Now, in the present, Perfuma's gaze is just as focused, but now it is laced with a passionate intensity. "Catra," she says, her voice thick with emotion. "If you're ready, it would be my honor."

She excuses herself to the living room. Catra hears the sound of her bag unzipping, the running of water in the bathroom sink. She returns holding a new, sleek black harness and a toy of a moderate, thoughtful size. She's slightly breathless.

Catra feels a wave of warmth so intense it's almost dizzying. The preparation. The desire to get it right. The fact that she'd *thought* to be prepared.

She'd missed that feeling of being anticipated, of being wanted so thoroughly that her partner plans for her pleasure.

"Have you just been carrying that with you the whole time?" she teases lightly, an echo of the old, familiar, ribbing rhythm she'd had with Adora.

Perfuma's cheeks flush a faint, lovely pink. "I just wanted to be prepared," she says, her voice softening with a sudden vulnerability. "In case you ever… wanted me to."

The slight uncertainty in her tone dissolves Catra's teasing edge. Her heart softens instantly. Of course. Their languages are different. Hers is all sharp edges and playful challenges, but Perfuma's is built on a foundation of quiet sincerity.

"That's really thoughtful of you, 'Fuma," Catra says, her voice now soft with genuine gratitude. "Thank you. Really."

Perfuma’s expression lights up, all anxiety replaced by beaming warmth and relief. “So,” she says, all business-like care now. “What do you need? How do you want to do this? Talk me through it.”

“Undress me,” Catra whispers, her own voice gaining a thread of certainty. “And then yourself.”

It's a ritual. A slow, tender unveiling. Perfuma’s hands are infinitely gentle as she helps Catra out of her clothes, mindful of every joint, every potential point of pain, her touch reverent. Then she undresses herself, slipping on the harness with a quiet, efficient grace.

This is the first time. Completely nude in front of each other, with nothing between them but the soft glow of candlelight and a breathtaking trust.

Catra takes in Perfuma’s body. The lean strength, the gentle slopes of her breasts, the defined, delicate lines of her abdomen. A temple, maintained with dedication, patience, and a deep respect.

It is a form of strength so different from Adora’s powerful athleticism, but no less beautiful. She sees the focus in every line of her.

Perfuma sees Catra. *Really* sees her. The faint, fatigued tremor in her thigh from the effort of standing, the delicate, bird-like bones of her ribs and collar, the tawny coat of fur that hides a thousand tiny scars and the map of a lifetime of pain. Her heart clenches.

She is so small. So fragile-looking. And yet, there is a fierce, vibrant life thrumming within her, evidenced by the way her cock is already standing, half-hard from anticipation and nervous want.

Perfuma’s throat tightens at the thought of five years without this intimacy. Without this touch. She vows, silently, to give her everything she has been missing.

For a long moment, Catra is utterly still, her tail a frozen question mark behind her. The only movement is in her eyes: they trail over the harness with a possessive, hungry focus that strips away every one of Perfuma's insecurities.

Under that gaze, she doesn't feel silly or exposed; she feels seen. A flush of heat spreads through her chest, and she understands: this is what it feels like to be truly desired.

Perfuma crawls onto the bed, gently guiding Catra down.

She kisses her, slowly, deeply, pouring all her love, her promise, her awe into it until Catra melts into the mattress, a soft, thrumming purr rumbling in her chest, a sound Perfuma is already coming to treasure as the soundtrack of Catra's contentment.

"I'm going to take care of you," Perfuma whispers against her lips, her breath warm. "What do you need first?"

"Fingers first," Catra breathes, her voice dropping to a husky whisper. "One, then two. Go slow. It's… been a long time. And… pillows. We need to build a nest for my hips. My legs… they need support. They can't just… hang."

Perfuma works diligently, with quiet, purposeful care, constructing a fortress of pillows and folded blankets until Catra is nestled securely, propped at just the right angle, her legs drawn up and spread wide, supported at every possible point, her body open and accessible without strain.

The sight of her, safe and held and trusting so explicitly, makes Perfuma's heart swell with an overwhelming wave of protective, adoring love.

She slicks her fingers with lube, and with a steadying breath, reaches out.

Catra flinches as the cool slickness touches her rim, a nervous, high-pitched laugh escaping her, ears pinning back for a moment

before she wills them forward. “Sorry. Just… skittish. Cold. It’s okay. Keep going. Just… slow.”

Perfuma waits, her finger a steady, patient, warming pressure until the tight ring of muscle relaxes under her touch. She presses in, slowly, millimeter by millimeter, letting Catra’s breath and the tension in her body guide the pace until her finger is fully sheathed.

Catra’s panting is immediate, her body clenching rhythmically around the intrusion. Perfuma watches, utterly enchanted, as Catra’s head falls back against the pillows, her face a mask of overwhelmed, focused pleasure.

Minutes pass like this, Catra working herself on Perfuma’s finger with soft, desperate whimpers and sighs, before she croaks the request for a second.

The process is repeated, slower this time, with more conscious relaxation on Catra’s part, guiding Perfuma with hitched breaths and tiny nods, until Perfuma is buried inside her to the knuckles, feeling the incredible, welcoming heat of her.

“Remember where…” Catra rasps, her tail giving a weak thump against the mattress. “That spot… press on it…”

Perfuma curls her fingers upwards, seeking the internal map Catra had drawn for her. She finds it—a distinct, firm, spongy area—and applies cautious pressure.

A shudder runs through Catra. Her body clenches around Perfuma’s fingers in a shuddering, rhythmic grip—a pulse of desperate, involuntary need that steals the air from her lungs in a single, sharp cry. For one breathtaking moment, Perfuma isn't just touching her; she is held at the epicenter of Catra’s pleasure, feeling the insistent, answering throb deep within.

“Oh, god, 'Fuma, harder, *right there*,” she begs, her voice cracking.

Perfuma pulses the pressure, utterly captivated by the sight of a fresh, clear bead of wetness welling from the tip of Catra's cock. It drips onto the fur of Catra's belly, and a low, needy throb of her own answers it.

She works her fingers in that steady, curling rhythm until Catra's thighs begin to tremble with fatigue and building ecstasy.

"What do you think, sweetheart?" Perfuma asks, her voice taking on a deliberately sweet, coy tone that she is learning drives Catra wild. "Are you ready to take my cock?"

That innocent tone wrapped around such a filthy, blatant question sends a lightning jolt through Catra. Her eyes darken, pupils swallowing the gold and blue whole.

"I'm ready. I want you inside of me, Perfuma. I want to be *full* of you. Fuck me until I come all over myself. Make me *yours*."

Perfuma guides the silicone toy to Catra's slick, well-prepared entrance and presses in. There's a moment of firm resistance, a held breath, then a soft, satisfying *pop* as the head slips past the tight ring of muscle.

Catra cries out, a broken, desperate sound of profound relief and deep, consuming need, her body seizing around the new, fuller, more complete intrusion.

Perfuma pauses, her own body trembling with the effort of holding still, before slowly, inexorably, easing the rest of the length into her, until she's sheathed herself completely, her hips pressed flush against Catra. She waits, letting Catra adjust to the stunning fullness, her own breath coming in shallow, ragged pants.

Catra writhes, tears of overwhelm welling in her eyes. "Oh, god, 'Fuma… you're inside me… you're really… you're *here*…"

"I'm here," Perfuma soothes, her own heart clenching with a protective ache, feeling the incredible trust in the body beneath

her. “You’re doing so good. So brave.”

The realization seizes Catra, visceral and absolute: the fullness she had grieved, certain it was lost forever, has now returned to her.

“I trust you,” Catra whispers, the words a vow, a granting of permission.

Perfuma’s heart swells. She leans down, capturing Catra’s mouth in a slow, deep kiss, then shifts just enough to cradle her jaw, her thumb stroking a reverent line across her cheekbone. "I know," she breathes against her skin. "I've got you."

Perfuma begins to move. Her hips roll in a gentle, rocking rhythm, the motion more like a soothing wave than a claiming thrust. She is deeply mindful of the fragile body beneath her, treating it with the same careful attention she'd give a rare, blooming flower.

But soon, under the force of Catra’s desperate, broken litany —“Please—please,” “Harder.... Fuck me harder!” a shattered, gasping sob that sounds like “Don’t stop!”—this nurturing rhythm fractures, quickening into something more urgent. Each thrust presses deep, the firm head of the toy rubbing insistently against that perfect, swollen spot within her.

A guttural, almost pained sound grates from Catra’s throat, the sensation too much and not enough all at once. Her hips try to stutter upward to meet the pressure but are held fast by the careful arrangement of her pillow nest, a helpless, involuntary movement of pure need.

The room fills with the raw, intimate sound of their joining: the wet slap of skin against skin, ragged breaths, the creak of the bed frame, Catra’s escalating, uninhibited cries.

Perfuma watches, mesmerized. The bounce of Catra’s small breasts with each thrust, the desperate, beautiful sway of her neglected cock, the way her face contorts in pure, unadulterated pleasure, completely free of the mask of pain she usually wears.

She's letting go. Completely. Trusting Perfuma to hold her together even as she falls apart.

Catra’s noises take on a new, frantic, begging pitch. “Are you going to come for me, sweetheart?” Perfuma murmurs, leaning closer, her voice a husky whisper against Catra’s ear. “I want to see that pretty little cock make a mess all over you. I want to see what I do to you.”

The words, the possessiveness laced with adoration, dissolve Catra’s last remnants of control. Her eyes snap open, locking with Perfuma’s, her gaze blazing.

“Now. *Now*! Fuck me hard! Don’t stop!” Her legs lock around Perfuma’s waist in response, pulling her deeper, holding her there, as their bodies find a frantic, driving rhythm.

They hold that gaze, a profound, electric connection arcing between them, a silent communication that bypasses all words, as Perfuma drives into her, their movements perfectly synced. Catra’s body tenses, quivers on the very precipice.

Then she breaks.

Her eyes squeeze shut, her ears pin flat against her skull. Her body bows as a keening sob is ripped from her chest—a broken, grieving cry, accompanied by a cacophony of audible pops and cracks that echo like percussion from her spine, her shoulders, her hips.

The climax tears through her, a seismic release of five years of tension, grief, and loneliness.

Perfuma doesn’t stop, fucking her through the convulsing waves. Her eyes are locked on the mesmerizing sight of Catra’s cock pulsing against her stomach, each throb releasing more of that clear, viscous heat, slicking her fur and glistening in the low light, until Catra goes completely limp, boneless and spent and utterly ravished in her pillow nest.

Perfuma slows, then stills, gently leaning forward to rest her weight on her arms, careful not to crush Catra.

"Let me help," she murmurs, her voice husky with exertion and care. With impossibly gentle hands, she first guides Catra's trembling legs from her waist, lowering them to rest over the cushions. She then gently pulls out, a soft, sighing sound escaping them both at the separation.

Unbuckling the harness, she tosses it aside with a quiet clatter. She's panting, shiny with sweat, her arms and core trembling from the sustained exertion.

Finally, with a last touch of care, she adjusts Catra's legs again, settling them fully down onto the bed so she can rest comfortably. She looks down at Catra, who lays with her eyes closed, chest heaving.

A beat of silence. Then a laugh bubbles up from Catra. A disbelieving huff, a wet snicker, then a full, belly-deep laugh that shakes her entire frame. She laughs until tears stream down her temples and into her hair, a pure, unfettered sound of release and joy.

Perfuma grins, her own tears of happiness mingling with sweat, her heart soaring at the sound. This is a side of Catra she's only glimpsed in fragments. To be the cause of its full, glorious expression is the greatest privilege she could imagine.

Catra wipes her eyes as the laughter subsides into breathless, hiccupping chuckles. She looks at Perfuma, her expression soft and wondrous and dazed. "That was… really special, 'Fuma. Thank you."

"Thank you," she says again, and as the words leave her mouth, her face changes. The wonder twists into something deeper, more raw. The tears return, but these are not tears of joy. They are great, heaving sobs that rack her fragile body, stealing her breath.

Perfuma is on her immediately, gathering her up, holding her tight against her chest, rocking her gently. “Shhh, I’ve got you. I’ve got you, my love. Let it out. It’s okay.”

“I was so *lonely*,” Catra chokes out against her shoulder, the words ripped from a deep, long-buried place, a pain so fundamental it is part of her DNA.

“For so *long*. I didn’t think I’d ever feel like that again. I forgot what it felt like to be… connected. To be full.” She takes a shuddering breath. “I loved being full of you. I loved being yours.”

“Oh, sweetheart,” Perfuma whispers, her own tears falling freely into Catra’s fur, her heart breaking and mending all at once. “I’m so glad I can give that to you again. I loved making you mine.”

In the heavy, quiet aftermath, Perfuma does not let go. She feels the exact moment the tension of a lifetime begins to seep from Catra’s bones, the sobs gentling into the slow, steady rhythm of sleep.

She carefully shifts them, never breaking contact, until they're curled together on their sides. She pulls the soft blanket from the foot of the bed up and over Catra’s shoulders, tucking it around her like a cocoon.

Perfuma leans over, careful not to jostle Catra, and blows out the candle on the nightstand, plunging the room into a soft, safe darkness. She lays awake for a long while, simply listening to Catra breathe. In the dark, she traces the lines of Catra’s face, finally smooth and unguarded in repose.

The trust it represents is a physical weight in her chest, immense and humbling. She presses one last, soft kiss to a velvety ear, inhales the scent of their joined sweat and Catra’s unique spice, and finally allows her own eyes to close, wrapped in the profound peace of the sanctuary they had built together in the dark.

Dawn is its usual gray intrusion around the edges of the heavy curtains.

Catra wakes to pain. It lives in her bones, a deep, resonant ache that pulses in time with her sluggish heartbeat. It nests in the sockets of her hips, a grinding dissonance that feels like rusted gears forced to turn. It radiates from her shoulders, a dull, insistent throb that makes the simple act of breathing feel like lifting weights. It hums in the delicate joints of her fingers and wrists, a constant, low-level buzz of wrongness.

But.

There is a warm body next to her in bed. The sound of soft, sleeping breaths. The scent of lavender and sunshine and sex and *Perfuma* woven into the sheets. A slender arm is thrown across her waist, a protective, claiming weight.

She slowly rises, her joints protesting every movement with their familiar symphony of cracks and pops. She leans on her cane, its handle worn smooth by her grip, and shuffles the sixteen steps to the kitchen. She fills the coffee maker, her hands trembling with their familiar stiffness. She presses *brew*.

And she makes enough for two.

She pours a mug for herself, the rich, bitter scent a familiar anchor. She shuffles to the living room window, the south-facing one Adora had chosen for the light, and reaches out, her claws catching the thick fabric of the heavy curtain.

And she pulls it open.

Golden morning light floods the room, illuminating dust motes dancing in the air like tiny, swirling galaxies. It paints the worn green velvet of her armchair, the faded fabric of Adora's jacket still draped over its back. It gleams off the framed photo on the shelf and highlights the fierce, resilient spines of the cactus on the coffee table, beside a half-finished project of Perfuma's—a soft,

cream-colored scarf, knitting needles still tucked into the ball of yarn.

She stands there, sipping her coffee, and feels the warmth on her fur.

The ritual is the same—waking to pain, the shuffle to the kitchen—but the context is transformed. The silence is no longer empty; it's peaceful, humming with the memory of shared breath and whispered love. The warmth isn't just from the coffee; it's from the woman sleeping in her bed, from the life that was, against all odds, growing again within these walls.

The south-facing window finally gets its light.

This is hope.

This is what grows in the silence. Not a grand, dramatic healing, but a quiet, stubborn fullness.

A body that aches, but a heart that is, finally, full again.

Chapter End Notes

> Thank you so much for going on this journey with me! This story is so significant to me, personally. It means the world to share it with you all. Please leave a comment, it will make my day! <3

End Notes

Thank you so much for reading and commenting, it really makes my day!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!